

Fate's Edge

GM Guide

May 17, 2026

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Preface: A Guide for Guides

“The road is a ledger. Every broken wheel is a debt, every lit lamp a witness. The only question is: what are you willing to owe?”

— Dusana of the Raven Road

Welcome, Game Master. You hold a book that is not a novel to be read cover-to-cover, but a toolkit to be consulted, a set of lenses to be put on and taken off as the light changes. *Fate’s Edge* gives you dice, clocks, and a simple resolution loop. What it does not give you is a script. That is your job, and this guide is here to make that job easier – not harder.

How This Book Is Organised

The chapters are arranged from the essential to the optional. Do not feel you must read everything before your first session.

- **chapter 1** – The philosophy of consequences, safety tools, and Session Zero. Read this first.
- **chapter 2** – The core loop, Position, Difficulty, Story Beats, and the infamous “three-clock guideline” (subsection 7.3.1). This is the engine room.
- **chapter 3** – Supply, Fatigue, Boons, Followers, Assets, and Terrestrial Patrons. Skim the first half; save the rest for later.
- **chapter 4** – Running a world without coin counting. The table “When to Charge What” (subsection 4.7.1) is pure gold.
- **chapter 5** – Adjudicating spells, backlash, and dangerous tags. Keep the Dangerous TAGS table bookmarked.
- **Chapters 6–10** – Example play, survival advice, campaign clocks, high-tier play, and advanced techniques. **New GMs: read only the GM Survival Guide (in chapter 10) and the Faction Turn Cheat Sheet.** The rest is for later.
- **chapter 11** – The Known World. Read only the region where your campaign starts.
- **chapter 12** – Core tables, optional rules, rival generator, and the one-page GM screen (section 12). Print the screen. Use the rival generator (section 12) when you need a quick antagonist.

A Reading Plan for New GMs

You do not need to master 200 pages to run a great session. Here is what you actually need:

1. Read **chapter 1** (safety, philosophy, Session Zero).
2. Read **chapter 2** up to section 2.9 – the resolution cycle, Position, DV, and the Story Beat spend menu.
3. Read **section 10.1** and section 10.3 (in chapter 10) – practical “now what?” advice.
4. Print the one-page GM screen (section 12) and the Outcome Matrix (Table 12.1).
5. Keep the Difficulty Ladder (Table 12.2) and Harm levels (Table 12.3) at hand.
6. Run the Quickstart adventure (“The Lantern at Dusk”) before opening any other chapter.

Everything else – faction turns (section 7.5), the Crown Spread (section 7.6), epic tier (chapter 8), domain management – is waiting for you when you finish your first arc. Do not try to use it all at once.

The 10% Rule

From chapter 4 (and echoed in chapter 12): pick *one* subsystem from this book and use it tonight. Next session, pick another. The game will not collapse if you never use the Deck of Consequences (section 12) or the travel clocks (section 7.7). The game *will* collapse if you try to track every clock, every faction, every threshold effect, and every player-managed module at once.

What This Book Is Not

It is not a prescribed curriculum. It is not a contract. It is a set of lenses – put them on when you need focus, take them off when they blur the story. The Golden Rule (see chapter 1) applies to the GM as much as to the players: when in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving. Default to DV 3, Position Controlled, and let the dice fall.

Acknowledgements

This guide stands on the shoulders of every GM who ran a session, forgot a rule, improvised a consequence, and still made the table laugh or gasp. Thank you for doing that work. Now go light a candle, shuffle the deck, and let the road unfold.

— *The Gray Wanderer*
Castra Ferrum, Year of the Iron Harvest

Chapter 1

Introduction: The Weight of Choice

Welcome, Game Master. You hold a unique role in **Fate's Edge**. You are not a solitary storyteller, nor a neutral referee. You are the **weaver of consequences**, the architect of a living world, and the guide on a path where every choice echoes. Your task is to breathe life into a realm of ancient magic, fallen empires, and vibrant cultures—and then let that world respond to the players' ambitions.

Power demands a price. The past never truly sleeps. One decision can reshape a nation or end an age. From the marble forums of Ecktoria to the mist-drenched fens of the Mistlands, the world is alive with stories. Your job is to provide the stage, set the stakes, and embrace the ripple effects of player agency.

1.1 A World Alive with Consequences

In **Fate's Edge**, the fiction is the final authority. The rules are not chains on your imagination, but tools to give weight to your stories. They help you adjudicate risk, track progress, and ensure that both success and failure drive the narrative forward.

Think of yourself as a conductor. The players provide the melody with their characters' actions. You provide the harmony and rhythm with the world's response. The rules are your sheet music—a guide to create a cohesive, dramatic piece, but one that allows improvisation.

Your judgment is the cornerstone of the game. If a rule doesn't serve the moment, change it. If a player's creative idea deserves to succeed, make it work. Your goal is a collaborative story that everyone helps create.

1.2 Core Philosophy: Narrative First

At the heart of **Fate's Edge** is a simple idea: **mechanics serve the story**. A dice roll is never just pass/fail. It changes the fictional landscape.

- **Clean Success** – The plan works as intended.
- **Success with SB** – You get what you want, but the world pushes back.

- **Partial** – You make progress, but the situation remains unresolved.
- **Miss** – You fail, and the situation escalates.

This ensures every roll matters. The story never stalls; it evolves.

1.3 Risk as the Engine of Drama

Fate's Edge is built on **meaningful risk**. Safety is boring. When characters have something to lose—reputation, allies, ideals, life—their actions become heroic or tragically memorable.

Your primary tool for managing risk is the **Story Beat (SB)** economy. When the dice show a **1**, the world reacts. The GM gains SB to introduce complications, escalate threats, or reveal hidden dangers. **Important:** SB are generated on *any* roll that produces a 1, whether the overall roll succeeds or fails. They are not punishment; they are fuel for an unpredictable, responsive narrative.

Example: A successful sword swing defeats an opponent. A Story Beat spent could mean the blade is notched, or that the defeat draws a more powerful foe. The drama continues.

1.4 Characters Who Change the World

Character growth in **Fate's Edge** is not about accumulating abstract power. It is **meaningful growth** rooted in the story. Players earn **Experience Points (XP)** by engaging with challenges and complexities. They spend XP to improve capabilities, acquire assets (a ship, a spy network), or unlock cultural talents.

Thus, advancement ties directly to narrative. A character becomes a legendary commander by leading armies, not by grinding monsters. A wizard masters forbidden lore by surviving backlash. As GM, you curate this growth, presenting challenges that make evolution feel earned and impactful.

1.5 Your Toolkit

To help guide the story, **Fate's Edge** provides interconnected tools:

- **Dice Pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s. 6+ = Success. 1 = Story Beat (SB) for you. Compare successes to Difficulty Value (DV) set by stakes.
- **Position & Effect:** Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) defines stakes of failure. Effect (Limited/Standard/Great) describes what a clean success achieves.
- **Clocks:** Visual trackers for ongoing challenges (e.g., 4-segment lock, 8-segment faction rise).
- **Deck of Consequences (optional):** A standard deck to generate thematic complications when SB are spent. Suits suggest nature of trouble.

These tools are designed to be learned quickly and used intuitively, getting out of the way so you and your players focus on the story.

1.6 How to Use This Book

This guide is for running the game.

- Early chapters cover core principles and basic procedures.
- Later chapters dive into advanced systems (conflict, travel, long-term play).
- Final sections provide guidance for high-tier campaigns, world-building, and the Amaranthine Sea setting.
- Appendices offer practical advice and a collection of tools and tables.

You don't need to memorize everything. Use this book as a reference. The most important chapters to internalize are those on core philosophy (this chapter) and basic action resolution (see SRD ??).

Quick Reference: Where to Find It

Use this one-page guide to jump straight to the rules you need at the table.

Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

Fate's Edge explores mature themes – conflict, loss, horror, betrayal, and difficult choices. The table must always feel safe. Use these three simple tools.

X-Card (by John Stavropoulos). Any player (including the GM) can draw an "X" or say "X" when uncomfortable. The described content is **removed from the fiction** – no questions, no explanations. The scene is retconned or redirected.

Lines. A hard boundary: content that will not appear at all. Examples: "No sexual violence," "No harm to children," "No body horror." Players name their Lines before the campaign; the group honors them.

Veils. A soft boundary: content that can happen "off screen" or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described. Example: "A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit." Veils let you acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

How to Use.

- Establish Lines and Veils in Session Zero. Write them down where everyone can see.
- Keep an X-Card visible (printed card, drawn X, or digital symbol).
- Remind players they can use the X-Card at any time, even mid-sentence.
- When the X-Card is used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate.
- The GM is also a player; they may use the X-Card for their own comfort.
- Respect the tools. If someone calls an X-Card, trust they had a good reason.

These tools are not about censorship – they are about **consent**. They allow the table to tell darker, more intense stories because everyone knows they can tap out. A safe game is a game that can go to the edge.

1.7 Session Zero: The Foundation of Play

Before the first dice roll, before the first scene, gather your players for a **Session Zero**. This is where you build the shared understanding that makes **Fate's Edge** sing.

1.7.1 Core Philosophy to Share with Players

- **Optimal play = most fun.** Spending Boons, embracing failure, and courting Patron attention leads to better stories. There is no "winning" except an unforgettable session.
- **Player-GM contract:** "We are co-creators, not adversaries." The GM frames pressure; the players drive the fiction. No one is trying to "beat" anyone else.
- **Resource mindset: Boons are not XP tokens.** Spend them. Hoarding Boons for conversion starves the table of drama and leads to less engagement.
- **Patron expectation:** Patrons are allies who demand payment—**embrace it**. Obligation is plot, not punishment. When a Patron calls, a story hook arrives.

1.7.2 Sample Session Zero Checklist

Use this checklist to guide your conversation. Write down the answers where everyone can see them.

1. **Lines & Veils:** What content is off-limits (Lines) or only implied (Veils)?
2. **Tone:** Cinematic action? Grim survival? Political intrigue? Dark horror? Mix of several?
3. **Campaign length:** One-shot, short arc (3–6 sessions), or long campaign (12+ sessions)?
4. **Character hooks:** Each player shares one goal and one fear for their character.
5. **Patron interest:** Which Patrons (if any) are already watching the party?
6. **Starting situation:** Where does the story begin? (Use the Crown Spread – see Appendix ?? – or a simple opener.)
7. **House rules:** Any optional subsystems (Threat Pool, Deck of Consequences, etc.) you plan to use?
8. **Scheduling & attendance:** How often do you meet? What happens if a player misses a session?

Taking thirty minutes for Session Zero will save hours of mid-campaign friction and give you a richer, more invested table.

Flavor is Free (Even for Mundane Actions)

Players and GMs: In **Fate's Edge**, **flavor is free** – and it applies to **all descriptive actions**, not just magic.

Add details, cultural touches, and atmospheric flourishes without spending resources or rolling

dice. Want your Vhasian duelist to parry with a flourish from royal fencing schools? Go ahead. Want to describe the eerie silence of a Valewood ruin when searching for clues? Perfect.

Encourage players to narrate even mundane successes. For example:

- "I reload my crossbow with a practiced flick of the wrist – the bolt seats with a satisfying *click*."
- "While the guard checks the other door, I slip the lockpick back into my sleeve and smile innocently."

Flavor enriches narrative and makes the world feel real. It doesn't change mechanical outcomes, but it defines the *how* and the *why*. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate. Mechanics determine success or failure; flavor determines the story we tell about it.

A Guide for Veterans: Fate's Edge in a Nutshell

If you're experienced with other RPGs, here's a quick translation of how **Fate's Edge** handles common concepts:

Traditional RPG Concept	Fate's Edge Approach
Ability Scores & Skills	Attributes (Body, Wits, etc.) + Skills (Melee, Lore, etc.) form a dice pool.
Skill Checks	Roll Attribute+Skill pool. Count successes (6+). Compare to DV. Any 1s give GM SB.
Hit Points / Health	Harm Track for injuries. Fatigue for exhaustion. Consequences are narrative and mechanical.
Combat Rounds	Fiction-first. Actions resolved by narrative timing, not rigid initiative.
Spell Slots / Mana	Magic uses the same core system. 1s generate SB. Powerful spells may require extra time or risk.
Saving Throws	Roll Attribute+Skill to resist (e.g., Body+Resolve vs. poison).
Experience & Leveling Up	Gain XP through play. Spend to increase Attributes/Skills, buy Talents, or acquire Assets. Growth is player-directed.

The key difference is a consistent, unified mechanic applied across all challenges, focused on narrative outcomes.

1.8 Begin the Journey

Your role is a privilege and a creative challenge. You are a facilitator, a fan of the players, and the keeper of a world that will challenge and surprise them. Trust the rules to handle tension, trust your

players to drive the story, and trust yourself to weave it all together.

Now, take a breath. Shuffle the deck. Let the dice fall.

It's time to guide the edge of fate.

Chapter 2

Running the Game: Core Procedures

Running Fate's Edge — Core Procedures in Brief

Your Job: Frame pressure, track consequences, let the fiction move forward.

Default Settings DV = 3 · Position = Controlled · One short Clock

The Core Loop (every meaningful action)

1. Player declares intent & approach (Attribute + Skill)
2. You state Position & set relevant Clocks
3. Player rolls d10s; count **Successes (6+)** & **Story Beats (1s)**
4. Compare to DV → use **Outcome Matrix**
5. Apply consequences & update the fiction

Outcome Matrix (what you do)

- **Clean Success** ($S \geq DV$, $SB=0$) → intent achieved, no complication
- **Success with SB** ($S \geq DV$, $SB>0$) → intent achieved, spend SB for a twist
- **Partial** ($0 < S < DV$) → progress made, player gains 1 Boon
- **Miss** ($S = 0$) → no progress, player gains 2 Boons, spend SB to escalate

Story Beats (SB) – spend them to create drama

- **1 SB:** Minor – noise, tick a clock, small setback
- **2 SB:** Moderate – alarm raised, lose advantage, worsen Position
- **3+ SB:** Major – reinforcements, scene shift, break an asset

Golden Rule

When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving.

Set DV=3, Position=Controlled, ask for the roll, and resolve with the Outcome Matrix.



Position & Effect: Risk vs. Reward

Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) = How risky is this action? – determines severity of failure and re-rolls.

Effect (Limited/Standard/Great) = How much do you achieve on a success? – determines scope, scale, or quality.

Example: Disarming a trap – Limited Effect lets one person cross, Standard lets two, Great lets all four.

Selling the Action – When Players Give You Gold

"Don't just tell me you swing your sword. Show me the dust in your eyes, the tremble in your arm, the desperate prayer you whisper to the Traveler." "And don't just paint a pretty picture – show me what your character risks, fears, or loves in this moment."

When a player **sells the action** – not by piling on adjectives, but by revealing what their character cares about, what they stand to lose, or why this moment matters – you have permission to give them a mechanical edge. This is a reward for **roleplay investment**, not vocabulary.

How to Rule It

- **Basic description:** "I attack the goblin." – No bonus.
- **Tactical description:** The player uses the environment, positioning, or a clever tactic. *Example:* "I feint high, then drive my shoulder into the goblin's shield, shoving it aside to open its flank." → **Improve Position by one step** (e.g., Controlled → Dominant) for this roll.
- **Character-driven description:** The player states a stake, invokes a bond, reveals a fear, or makes a hard choice visible. *One heartfelt sentence counts more than a paragraph of adjectives.* *Example:* "I think of my mother, who died because I wasn't brave enough. I won't let that happen again. I plant my feet and dare the goblin to come through me." → **Improve Position by one step and bank 1 Story Beat** (or upgrade Effect by one step, your choice).

What Counts (and What Doesn't)

Counts:

- Stating a clear stake ("If I fail, my sister doesn't eat.")
- Invoking a bond mid-action ("I owe Marcus my life. I'm not letting him face this alone.")
- Revealing a fear or hope tied to the roll ("I'm terrified of fire, but I grab the beam – the children are behind me.")
- Making a hard choice visible ("I could run, but I don't. Running is what got me exiled.")

Does not count:

- Piling on adjectives ("gleaming," "mighty," "ancient") without stakes.
- Passive sensory laundry lists ("the cold wind, the wet stones, the dim light").
- Repeating the same florid description for every roll.

Guidelines for Fair Play

- **No penalty for plain speech.** Never punish a player who is tired, shy, or simply prefers quick resolution. The bonus is a gift, not a tax.

- **Be consistent.** Reward genuine investment, not vocabulary. A quiet player who delivers one honest sentence deserves the bonus as much as an eloquent storyteller.
- **Let the fiction guide the bonus.** A desperate, reckless action described with real stakes might upgrade Effect but worsen Position – the mechanics should mirror the fiction.
- **Invite quiet players.** Ask leading questions: "What's at stake for your character right now?" or "What are you afraid will happen if you fail?" Gentle prompts help shy players find their moment.
- **Group "selling."** If the whole table contributes to describing a group action (a coordinated ambush, a joint ritual), grant the bonus to the primary roller or give each participant a small benefit (e.g., a one-time +1 die).

Example

Basic: "I sneak past the sentry." (No bonus, roll as normal.)

Tactical: "I wait for the wind to rattle the shutters, then pad across the wet cobblestones – heel-toe, heel-toe – keeping the stack of barrels between me and the sentry's gaze." The GM nods: "Great. Because you're using the wind and the barrels, roll at **Dominant Position**."

Character-driven: "My little brother is in that camp. I've hidden from every fight since we left home – but not this time. I creep forward, not quiet anymore, because he needs to know someone came for him." The GM: "That's the heart of it. Roll at **Dominant Position**, and I'll bank a Story Beat to make his reaction matter."

The dice still decide success or failure. But a well-told action makes the story richer – and earns the player an edge when the dice fall.

2.1 How to Think in Fate's Edge

Running **Fate's Edge** is less about adjudicating difficulty and more about managing momentum. Your primary job is not to block success, protect outcomes, or simulate realism—it is to **frame pressure, track consequences, and let the fiction move forward**.

If you catch yourself asking "How hard should this be?" you are already one step behind. Instead ask:

- What is at stake right now?
- What happens if this goes wrong?
- What pressure is already in play?

The rules exist to answer those questions—not to replace them.

2.1.1 The Core Loop (In Practice)

Every meaningful action follows the same simple loop:

1. **Player declares intent and approach.**
2. **You state Position and set any relevant Clocks.**
3. **The roll resolves the moment.**
4. **You apply consequences and update the fiction.**

Do not search for the "right roll." If the action matters, the procedure applies.

2.1.2 Your Defaults

When in doubt, trust the fiction. The system will follow. Fall back on these defaults:

- **DV:** 3
- **Position:** Controlled
- **Consequence:** Fatigue, time pressure, or exposure
- **Clocks:** One short clock tied to the scene

Escalate only when the fiction demands it.

2.1.3 What You Are *Not* Doing

You are *not*:

- calling for rolls to gate progress
- inflating difficulty to "challenge" the players
- protecting NPC plans from disruption
- hiding information behind unnecessary checks

If the players act decisively, the world must respond decisively.

2.1.4 What You *Are* Doing

You *are*:

- stating Position clearly and confidently
- letting partials move the story forward
- spending Story Beats to make failure interesting
- allowing success to create new problems

The game works best when nothing stalls.

2.1.5 A Useful Reframe

Think of each scene as a **pressure engine**:

- Dice create outcomes
- Clocks track fallout
- Story Beats fuel escalation
- Boons reward risk

Your job is to keep that engine turning—not to decide where it ends.

Let the procedures do the work. Your attention belongs on the fiction.

2.2 The Core Resolution Cycle

When a player rolls, they engage the world through risk, consequence, and discovery.

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** Player states intent, Attribute + Skill.
2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV):** Based on narrative stakes.
3. **Establish Position:** Dominant, Controlled, or Desperate.
4. **Roll Pool of d10s.**
5. **Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).**
6. **Check Against DV** using Outcome Matrix.
7. **Apply Outcome:** Clean Success, Success with SB, Partial, or Miss.
8. **Spend SB** for complications and twists.

Clean Success. The action succeeds as intended. No Story Beats generated unless specified. Fiction advances cleanly.

Success with SB. Action succeeds but generates **Story Beats**. Success stands; cost is GM spending those SB, ideally applied to the inciting action or its immediate consequences.

Miss. Action fails and generates **Story Beats**. GM uses those SB to introduce complications, advance opposition, or shift the situation against the character.

Partial Success (GM Adjudication). A Partial indicates progress but not full resolution. How that manifests is determined by the GM, based on context, scale, and narrative stakes.

Partial results may:

- Improve the character's **Position** on a follow-up attempt
- Reduce the effective **DV** of the next roll
- Achieve the goal at reduced scale or limited duration
- Succeed fully but generate a **Story Beat** as cost or complication
- Reveal information or create a new opportunity instead of immediate resolution

Example: Lockpicking. A character picks a DV 3 lock.

- **1 success (Partial):** Lock loosens but not opened; character gains *Controlled Position* on next attempt.
- **2 successes (Strong Partial):** Lock opens – GM spends the generated **Story Beat** to upgrade to *Success with SB* (lock jams behind them, or someone hears the click).

Guiding Principle. Partials represent *meaningful progress*. Convert progress into advantage, resolution, or complication, depending on what best serves the fiction.

Position Effects

Position	Mechanical Effect
Dominant	May re-roll one failure (die < 6).
Controlled	Default state; no re-rolls.
Desperate	Must re-roll one success (die 6+), keeping second result.

Difficulty Ladder – Beginner Focus

DV	When to Use
2	Routine: clear path, no pressure, almost guaranteed.
3	Default: mild challenge, some risk – use most often.
4	Hard: serious opposition, bad angle, or strong resistance.
5+	Extreme: major boss encounters or dramatic gambles.

2.3 Position & Difficulty Value

Position and DV are your primary dials for setting stakes and difficulty. They work together but answer different questions:

- **DV (Difficulty Value)** – How *hard* is the task? (2 = routine, 3 = pressured, 4 = hard, 5+ = extreme)

- **Position** – How *risky* is the attempt? (Dominant = safe, Controlled = balanced, Desperate = dangerous)

2.3.1 DV 3 as Default

Unless the fiction clearly indicates otherwise, start at **DV 3**. This gives a roughly 50–60% success rate for an average pool (4–6 dice) and leaves room for partials and misses. **Do not inflate DV to "challenge" players** – use Position, Clocks, and SB spends instead.

2.3.2 When to Worsen Position

Worsen Position when the fiction puts the character at a disadvantage:

- Exposed or surrounded → Desperate
- Rushed or distracted → Controlled or Desperate
- Surprised or ambushed → Desperate

Never worsen Position just to make a roll "harder." Position is about **narrative danger**, not arithmetic.

2.3.3 The Golden Rule

Golden Rule

When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving.

If you cannot remember a rule, set DV = 3, Position = Controlled, and ask the player to roll. Resolve the outcome with the Outcome Matrix. You can look up the rule after the session.

2.3.4 Example: Using SB to Escalate a Scene

Spending SB for Drama (The Bridge)

The party is negotiating a narrow mountain bridge. A rival mercenary captain demands a bribe.

- **Player rolls a Partial.** The GM gains 2 SB.
- **GM spends 1 SB:** "The captain leans on his sword – you notice his hand creeping toward the hilt. *Tensions rise.*" (Tick a new clock: **Tempers Flare [4].**)
- **GM spends the second SB:** "A loose stone falls from the bridge and splashes into the river far below. The captain's archers nock arrows. **Position worsens to Desperate.**"

The player still succeeded in negotiating a lower toll, but the GM used SB to introduce escalating pressure and a visible clock. The scene now crackles with danger.

2.4 Outcome Matrix & Story Beats

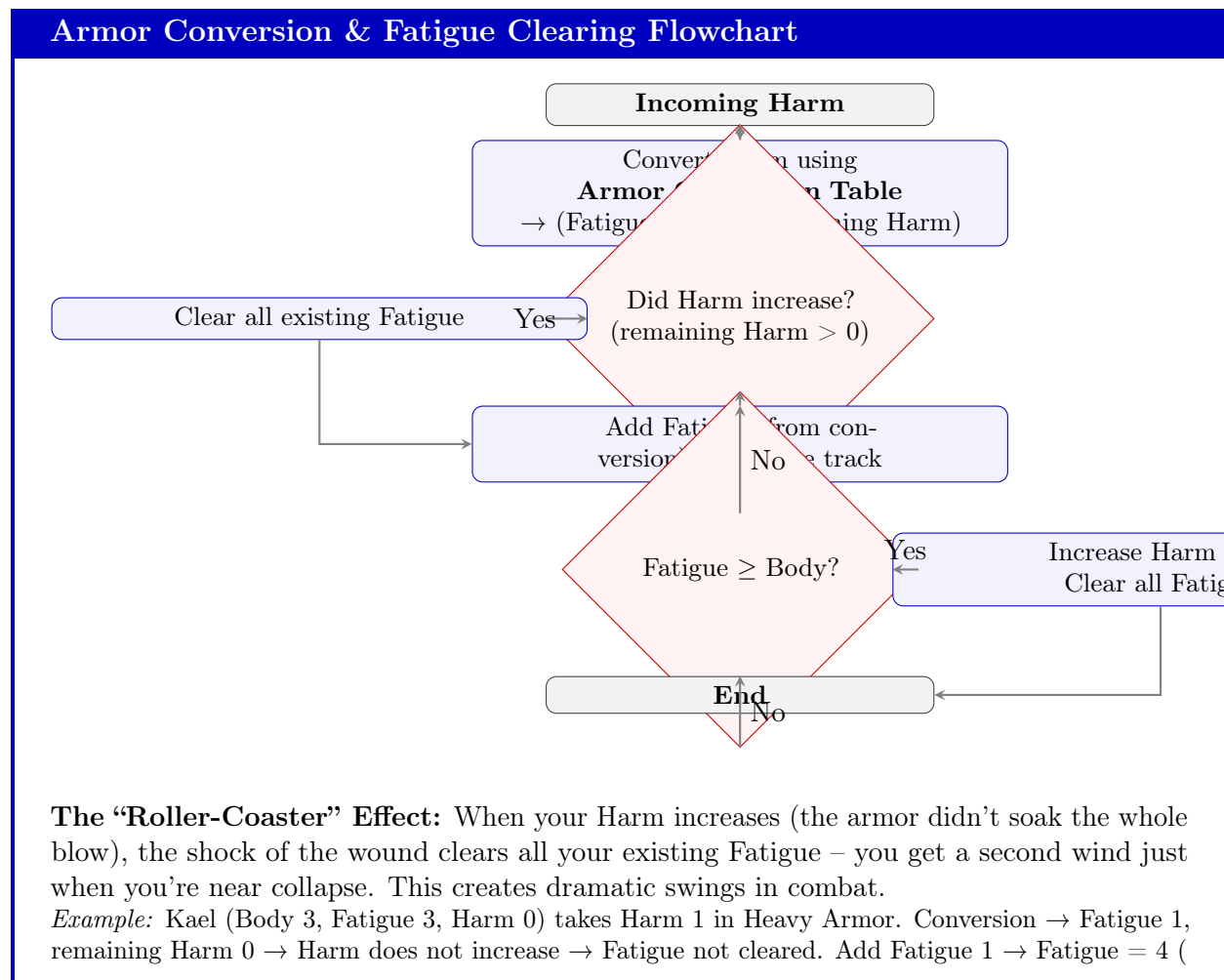
2.4.1 Outcome Matrix

Outcome Matrix	
Roll Result	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success – intent achieved, no complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0	Success with SB – intent achieved; GM spends SB for complication.
$0 < \text{Successes} < \text{DV}$	Partial – progress with complication; player gains 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss – no progress; GM escalates with SB; player gains 2 Boons.

💡 Tip

Remind players that they can spend 1 **Boon** before a roll to increase Effect by one step.

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Body 3) → Overflow: Harm 0→1, clear all Fatigue. Final: Harm 1, Fatigue 0.

2.4.2 Story Beats: The Engine of Drama

Every time a player rolls a 1, you gain Story Beats (SB). These are narrative tools, not punishments.

SB Spend Menu

SB Cost	Simple Complications
1 SB	Minor: noise, distraction, small setback, lost gear, tick a 4/6 clock +1.
2 SB	Moderate: alarm raised, new threat enters, lose advantage, worsen Position.
3+ SB	Major: reinforcements, scene shifts, stakes escalate, break an asset.

2.4.3 Failing Forward with SB

- **On Clean Success:** Use SB to add texture. The hero wins, but something changes.
- **On Success with SB:** The hero gets what they wanted *and* you spend SB to add further cost or threat.
- **On Partial:** Use SB to make the complication sharper.
- **On Miss:** Spend SB to escalate the situation.

Lane Marker: One Complication per Roll

When in doubt, spend SB on *one* clear complication instead of many small ones. Name it plainly – "Guard Alerted", "Floor Cracked", "Oath Owed" – and move on.

Be **aggressive** with Story Beats, but never arbitrary:

- Do not hoard SB – unused pressure is wasted momentum.
- Do not invent contrived consequences that ignore the fiction.
- Spend SB to *sharpen what already matters*, not to add noise.

A single, well-chosen complication should change the situation, not just decorate it.

2.5 Optional Initiative Procedures

2.5.1 Default: Narrative Initiative

By default, **Fate's Edge** uses **narrative initiative**. The GM spotlights characters based on the fiction: the ambushers act first, the character in the most immediate danger reacts, and the pace flows naturally.

Use the optional structures below only if your table prefers a more structured turn order. They are fully compatible with the core rules but are not required for balanced play.

2.5.2 When to Use Structured Initiative

Consider structured initiative when:

- Combat involves six or more participants.
- Players want a clear, rotating turn order.
- The table enjoys tactical positioning and resource management.
- You mix groups with different speeds or reaction times.

Even with structured systems, prioritize the fiction: an ambusher still acts first.

2.5.3 Option A: Popcorn Initiative

Each round, the player who just acted chooses who goes next (friend or foe). The GM may veto unrealistic skips (e.g., an archer at Far acting before the enemy in Close).

Step	Procedure
1	Determine first actor by fiction (ambush, fastest PC, etc.).
2	That character takes their full turn.
3	After their turn, they choose any other character who has not acted this round to go next.
4	Repeat until all have acted.
5	End of round: last actor chooses first actor of the next round.

GM Guidance Use popcorn initiative to reward clever positioning. Enemies will naturally gang up on vulnerable PCs if players always choose foes – that’s fine. If the table feels unfair, limit choice to "adjacent in fiction" (e.g., only those within Near range).

2.5.4 Option B: Side-Based Initiative

All player characters act together, then all enemies act together (or vice versa). Order within the side is negotiated by players.

Step	Procedure
1	Determine which side has surprise or narrative advantage. That side acts first.
2	All members of that side take their turns in any order (players decide).
3	All members of the other side take their turns.
4	Repeat.

GM Guidance Best for large combats (10+ combatants). To avoid "alpha strikes," separate enemy groups into two initiatives (e.g., "archers" and "berserkers") that act on different counts.

2.5.5 Option C: Speed-Based Slots

Each character rolls a die (e.g., 1d10 + Wits) for initiative. Higher scores act first. Ties go to the PC, or roll off.

Step	Procedure
1	At combat start, each player rolls 1d10 + Wits (or other attribute).
2	The GM rolls once for each distinct enemy group (or individually for bosses).
3	Order all participants by score highest to lowest.
4	Act in that order.
5	After each full round, optionally re-roll to reflect changing conditions.

GM Guidance Familiar to traditional players. Use a visible tracker (whiteboard, index cards). Re-rolling each round adds chaos but slows play slightly.

2.5.6 Mixing Narrative and Structured Initiative

Even with a structured system, override it when fiction demands. Examples:

- A PC triggers a trap mid-round → they act immediately, then initiative resumes.
- An enemy surrenders → remove them from the order; do not skip a player's turn.
- A character is delayed (e.g., climbing a wall) → they act at end of round regardless of score.

Always state your override clearly: "The bridge collapses—Kaelen, you react first. Everyone else, hold your action."

2.5.7 Recommendation for New GMs

Start with **narrative initiative** for the first 2–3 sessions. Once players are comfortable with Position and DV, introduce **popcorn initiative** for combat. Reserve side-based or speed-based for large, tactical fights. The best system keeps the fiction moving.

2.6 Standard Rule: Player-Managed Modules

This rule makes each player the primary steward of their character-facing trackers (*modules*). It keeps table pace high, reduces hidden bookkeeping, and clarifies when mechanical thresholds trigger. The GM retains authority over world-facing clocks, faction fronts, and major narrative consequences.

2.6.1 Scope (What Counts as a Module)

Player-managed modules are any **character-facing** clocks, counters, or discrete states on a single character sheet:

- **Obligation** (per Patron or Symbol)

- **Corruption Clock** (Cantor)
- **Leash** (Summoned spirit strain) and **Spirit Bond Clock**
- **Repertoire Clock** (Cantor) or similar progression clocks
- **Asset States** (Maintained / Neglected / Compromised / Shattered)
- **Scene Counters** explicitly tied to a PC (Exposure, personal Buff/Debuff durations)

Not included: GM story resources (global **Story Beats**), location/faction clocks, and mystery/doom fronts.

What Players Track (at a Glance)

Module Tick / Change Triggers (examples)	Owner
Obligation (by Patron)	Player
Invoke/Push/ritual text; Invoker <i>Borrowed Grace</i> ; cracking a Symbol; bargain costs.	
Corruption Clock	Player
Cantor Push; Resonant Rite; GM spends a Beat tied to the PC's occult actions.	
Leash (Summoning)	Player
Harm to spirit; commands against nature; split focus; crossing [WARD] (DV = Cap).	
Spirit Bond [4]	Player
Shared victories, mutual aid, meaningful attempts (once/session/type).	
Repertoire [6]	Player
Learn a new unique Song/rite-as-song; practice milestones.	
Asset State (Symbol)	Player
Maintenance/downtime checks; <i>Crack the Seal</i> → Compromised; breakage → Shattered.	

2.6.2 Core Principle

Players **immediately** mark their own modules when a rule says "mark +X" or a trigger fires. Threshold effects resolve as soon as reached.

2.6.3 Player Duties

1. **Mark on Cue.** When you Invoke a Rite, Push, spend/clear per rules, or a trigger fires, update your module *now*, not later.
2. **Declare Thresholds.** If marking fills a clock or crosses capacity, say so aloud; thresholds resolve before the scene proceeds.
3. **State Ownership.** Keep per-Patron Obligation tallies distinct; track each Symbol's state.
4. **Keep It Visible.** Use a tracker the GM and table can see (sheet boxes, index cards, or shared digital).

2.6.4 GM Duties

1. **Spot-Check.** At need, ask any player: current Obligation by Patron, Corruption segments, Leash state, Asset states.
2. **Enforce Thresholds.** When a player reports a threshold, apply standard effects *immediately*.
3. **Own the Fallout.** Patron intrusions, faction reactions, front clocks, and major narrative consequences remain GM authority.

2.6.5 Standard Thresholds & Effects

Obligation Capacity

$$\text{Obligation Capacity} = \text{Spirit} + \text{Presence}$$

- **Over Capacity:** Mark +1 **Fatigue** per segment over capacity.
- **Over 2× Capacity:** Clear all Fatigue, mark +1 **Harm (Stress)**, and a **Patron Intrusion** occurs (GM frames on-theme demand/complication).

Corruption Full When a **Corruption Clock** fills:

- Apply the last-Patron **benefit & burden** to the PC (and any listed followers/retainers).
- **Reset** the Corruption Clock to empty.
- If the player chooses **Embrace Corruption**, convert the current Patron theme into a permanent boon/curse (see full rules).

Leash Full (Summoning) When the **Leash** fills:

- The spirit acts once to its nature, then **departs** (or turns hostile at GM discretion).

Leash Capacity: Cap + Spirit segments. (*Cap* is the outsider's tier: 1 for Lesser, 3 for Greater.)

Symbol State (Invoker)

- **Maintained** → normal function.
- **Neglected** → GM may impose +1 DV to related rites.
- **Compromised** (e.g., *Crack the Seal*) → instant resolution per rules; mark extra Obligation; repair in Downtime or pay 1 XP.
- **Shattered** → unusable until replaced or ritually restored.

2.6.6 Table Procedure (90-Second Loop)

Start of Session Players read out: per-Patron Obligation totals, Corruption segments, standing Asset States, and any personal clocks at 3+.

End of Scene Quick pass: "Any marks?" Players tick modules from scene events. If a threshold triggers, resolve now.

Downtime Players apply clears (service, contrition, purification, study) to their own modules. GM verifies any costs or fiction.

2.6.7 Disputes & Order of Operations

If two marks land simultaneously, apply them in the **least advantageous order for the acting character**, unless a rule specifies otherwise. The GM is final arbiter.

2.6.8 Accessibility & Tools

Use highly visible trackers: bold boxes on sheets, poker chips for segments, or a shared per-Patron Obligation table. Keep modules at-a-glance to minimize interruption.

2.6.9 Worked Micro-Examples

- **Invoker Rites Twice:** Vessa Invokes two different Patrons. She marks each Patron's Obligation separately. Hitting capacity with Patron A causes Fatigue; Patron B stays below.
- **Cantor Pushes:** Jorel Pushes a Song (mark +1 Corruption). That fills his clock; he gains last-Patron boon/burden immediately, then resets to 0.
- **Summoner Clash:** Kestra's Cap 3 elemental takes Harm and crosses a [WARD]; she ticks her Leash twice. On fill, the elemental flares once and departs.

The Core Loop: Your First 10 Games

Start here for your first session! Ignore advanced systems until comfortable.

1. Player states Goal & Action (Attribute + Skill)
2. GM sets simple DV (2–5)
3. Player rolls. Count Successes (6+)
4. GM consults Outcome Matrix. **Ignore Boons for now. Use simple complications on Partial/Miss.**

Once comfortable, add: Boons | Story Beats | Clocks

First Game Scenario: The Sunstone Tower

Premise: The party is hired to infiltrate the ruined Sunstone Tower and retrieve a magical sunstone before rival treasure hunters do. This scenario uses a limited rules subset perfect for beginners.

- **Ignore for this scenario:** Boons, Corruption, intricate magic subsystems, detailed Follower/Asset upkeep.

- **Focus on:** Core dice pool, Success/Partial/Miss outcomes, Position, Clocks.
- **Character Setup:** Use pregenerated characters or create simple ones with 20 XP and 2–3 clear hooks.

GM Prep in 10 Minutes

Sunstone Tower Prep Checklist

- Name 3 NPCs: hirer, rival delver, tower spirit (or echo).
- Write 1 sentence for each scene: Approach, Interior, Sunstone Chamber.
- Create 2 clocks: **Guardian Alert [4]** and **Tower Collapse [6]**.
- Decide 1 twist: rival arrives early, tower shifts, or sunstone is not what it seems.

Scene 1: The Approach

Lane Marker: Skill Challenge with a Clock

GM Focus: Practice calls for DV and Partial outcomes. For this intro, tick the **Guardian Alert [4]** clock on a Partial or Miss.

The tower stands on a cliffside. Players must navigate three challenges:

- Cross the crumbling bridge (Athletics) – DV 3
- Scale the cliff face (Athletics/Strength) – DV 4
- Sneak past the stone guardians (Stealth) – DV 3

Guardian Alert Clock [4]: Each Partial or Miss advances the clock by 1. If filled, guardians activate and pursue; treat them as a single *Tower Guardian* threat with a simple [4] Harm track.

Scene 2: The Tower Interior

This scene teaches **Position** and **environmental stakes**.

- **Dominant:** "You have the high ground on the crumbling staircase, looking down on the patrol."
- **Controlled:** "The hallway is dark but quiet. You can take your time, but there might be traps."
- **Desperate:** "The floor gives way beneath you as you lunge for the door!"

How to Set Position in Play

- **Listen First:** Hear the player's intent and approach. What are they actually doing in the fiction?
- **Assess the Situation:** Consider leverage, opposition, time pressure, exposure, and consequences. Ask: *How forgiving is the world right now?*
- **Assign the Position:**
 - **Dominant:** Clear leverage, surprise, or overwhelming advantage.
 - **Controlled:** Stable; mistakes are recoverable.
 - **Desperate:** Exposed, rushed, cornered, or facing serious danger.
- **State It Clearly:** Say it out loud before the roll. *"This is Desperate. If it goes wrong, the consequences will be serious."*

Reminder: Position is a statement of risk and consequence, not a reward or penalty. It frames what failure *means*.

Scene 3: The Sunstone Chamber

The chamber is collapsing as rival delvers close in. Use a simple [6] clock for the collapse. Each round, the clock ticks up by 1. On each Miss, advance it by an extra 1 segment.

- **Goal:** Retrieve the sunstone and escape before the clock fills.
- **On Fill:** The chamber seals. Escape requires a final, Desperate group action.

Lane Marker: One New Idea at a Time

Scene 1: Clocks *only*.

Scene 2: Add *Position*.

Scene 3: Combine *Clocks + Position*. Reserve Boons, Corruption, and advanced magic for later sessions.

2.7 Learning Through Examples

This section walks the same situation through multiple passes, adding one rule at a time. Use it as a mental template when you improvise.

Example 1: Core Loop Only

Example 1 – No SB, No Boons

Lyra tries to sneak past a guardian in a narrow hallway. (Agility + Stealth = 5d10).

GM: normal risk, DV 3, Controlled Position.

Roll: 3, 5, 6, 7, 9 → 3 successes (6,7,9).

DV 3 with 3 successes = **Success**.

GM: "You slip past the guardian quietly. You're in position behind it if you want to act."

Example 2: Add Story Beats Only

Example 2 – Adding Story Beats

Same situation. Lyra rolls 5d10: 1, 4, 6, 6, 8.

Successes: 3 (6,6,8). One 1 → 1 SB for GM.

DV 3 with 3 successes = **Success** with 1 SB.

GM spend (1 SB = Minor): "You get past the guardian, but your cloak snags and tears. The sound echoes – the next room has a -1 Position penalty for stealth checks."

Example 3: Add Boons Only

Example 3 – Adding Boons

Later, Lyra scales a loose stone wall (Athletics + Agility = 4d10). DV 3.

Roll: 2,3,4,5 → 0 successes = **Miss**.

GM awards **2 Boons**. "You slip and land hard, taking 1 Harm. Mark 2 Boons – you can use them later to turn the tide."

Next attempt, Lyra spends 1 Boon to re-roll a die, turning failure into success.

Example 4: Putting It Together

Example 4 – SB + Boons + Position

The party flees as the tower collapses. A crumbling staircase blocks the exit.

GM: "Desperate. DV 4 to get everyone across safely."

Lyra leads, rolling 6d10 (Agility + Athletics + help): 1,2,6,7,7,9.

4 successes vs DV 4 = Success. 1 rolled 1 = 1 SB to GM. Desperate Position.

GM: "You all make it across, but the last step collapses behind you. I spend 1 SB: your exit path is gone. You'll need a new way out."

Lesson: Even on a success, SB let you bend the fiction toward drama without erasing the player's win.

2.8 Combat Made Simple

Combat uses the same core loop. The stakes are higher and more immediate.

Combat Quick Reference

- **Initiative:** No fixed order. Ask: "Who acts next?" Follow the fiction.
- **Actions:** Each turn, a character can move and take one meaningful action.
- **Position Matters:** Flanking or ambush → Dominant; surrounded or exposed → Desperate.
- **Use Clocks:** Track enemy morale [6], environmental dangers [4], and boss thresholds.

2.8.1 Three-Beat Combat Structure

When lost in a fight, fall back on three beats:

1. **Opening Exchange:** Establish where everyone is and what they want.
2. **Turning Point:** Spend SB or tick clocks to change the situation (reinforcements, terrain shifts).
3. **Final Gamble:** Make the last few rolls matter – higher DV, Desperate Position, or big rewards.

Example: SB in Combat

The party fights bandits on a collapsing bridge.
On a Partial, GM spends 2 SB: "You push them back, but the bridge loses another support. The *Bridge Collapse* [4] clock advances."
Now every action is also about whether they escape in time.

2.9 Clocks & Fronts

Clocks are visual trackers for threats, progress, and looming changes. They keep pressure visible and shared.

2.9.1 Basic Clock Usage

- **Size:** [4] for small scenes, [6] for bigger problems, [8] for arcs.
- **Advance On:** Misses, certain Partials, or SB spends.
- **Name It:** "Alarm Raised [4]" or "Floodwaters Rise [6]" is better than a blank circle.

Beginner Clock Limits

- No more than 3 active clocks per scene.
- Only 1–2 clocks should matter to the current roll.

- Say out loud when you tick a clock and why.

2.9.2 Mini-Fronts for Short Arcs

A *Front* is a cluster of related clocks and threats.

- **Example Front:** "Rival Delvers of the Sunstone Tower"
- **Clocks:** "Rivals Close In [6]", "Tower Integrity [6]", "Rival Reputation [4]".
- Each time you spend SB, consider ticking one of these clocks.

2.10 Ready for More? Add These Systems

Once comfortable with the core loop, introduce these modules one at a time. Treat each as a new lane marker.

2.10.1 Boons

Boons reward players for pushing their luck.

- On **Miss:** Gain 2 Boons.
- On **Partial:** Gain 1 Boon.
- **Spend:** Re-roll a die, add +1 Effect, or seize a small advantage (GM-approved).

Start with *re-roll only*. Once players are comfortable, add the other options.

2.10.2 Advanced Magic

- **Basic:** Use simple Tag-based magic (single roll, single tag).
- **Intermediate:** Add Runekeepers after 2–3 sessions, when everyone understands SB and Clocks.
- **Advanced:** Introduce Invokers and ritual magic for groups that enjoy planning and complex payoffs.

2.10.3 Followers, Assets, and Domains

Add persistent resources when the group cares about territory, organizations, or long-term projects.

- Start with 1 simple Follower or Asset each.
- Tie them to clocks: "Caravan Reputation [6]", "Temple Influence [4]".
- Spend SB to threaten or complicate these resources.

2.11 Abstracting Time and Currency

Fate's Edge uses **narrative time** and **abstract wealth** to keep the focus on story, not bookkeeping.

2.11.1 Narrative Time (Not Minutes)

Describe durations in narrative beats, not concrete minutes or hours. Use these units:

Narrative Unit	When to Use
A moment	One action, a heartbeat, a single exchange
Some time	A few minutes – picking a lock, searching a room
Significant time	Hours – a ritual, a short rest, a negotiation
Half a day	Morning to noon, dusk to midnight
A day	Dawn to dusk, including travel or major activity

Example: Instead of "It takes 20 minutes to climb the tower", say: "It takes **significant time** – long enough for the patrol to pass and return." That keeps pressure without a stopwatch.

2.11.2 Abstract Currency (XP as Coin)

Fate's Edge abstracts most coinage and barter. Exceptional expenses, bribes, or lifestyle costs are handled through **Boons**, **Assets**, or **Story Beats** – not copper counting.

When a player needs to pay for something significant and has no relevant Asset or favor, they may spend **XP**. Treat 1 XP as a substantial bribe, emergency fund, or major purchase.

When to Use XP for Coin

Appropriate uses:

- Bribing a corrupt official (2–4 XP)
- Outfitting a small expedition (1 XP per full kit)
- Buying a rare magical component (2–3 XP)
- Establishing a modest safehouse (4 XP, counts as Minor Asset)

Inappropriate uses:

- Routine meals, lodging, or travel supplies (cover with narrative)
- Anything that would trivialize a previous asset purchase
- Repeated, low-stakes expenses

GM Guidance: Spending XP for coin should feel like a meaningful sacrifice, not a tax. Always ask: "Is this advancing the story?" If yes, allow it. If not, offer a different cost (a Boon, a Debt, a Story Beat). This keeps material concerns from derailing the narrative.

2.12 Session Flow: A GM Cognitive Checklist

Use this as a quiet mental script. You do not need to say any of it out loud.

2.12.1 Opening 10 Minutes

- Ask: "What does everyone want out of tonight?" (goal, vibe, focus).
- Recap 2–3 key facts and 1 unresolved clock.
- Ask each player: "What is your character worried about right now?"

2.12.2 During Play

- Before a roll: Name DV, Position, and stakes.
- After a roll: Say the outcome type (Clean Success/Success with SB/Partial/Miss) first, then the fiction.
- Between scenes: Look at clocks. Ask, "Which one should move? What changes in the world?"

2.12.3 Closing 10 Minutes

- Ask: "What was your favorite moment?" (signals what to do more of).
- Note any clocks that reached halfway or full.
- Jot 2 bullet points: "Next time on Fate's Edge..." as hooks.

Quick GM Cheat Sheet

- **DV Default:** 3 (adjust ± 1 for ease/difficulty).
- **Position:** Controlled (normal), Dominant (advantage), Desperate (risk).
- **SB Spend:** 1=minor, 2=moderate, 3+=major complication.
- **Max Clocks:** 3 per scene to avoid overwhelm.
- **Golden Rule:** When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving.

Remember: The goal is to tell an exciting story together. These rules are tools, not tests. Start simple, add complexity when ready, and keep lane markers clear: one new idea at a time, one clear consequence per roll, and one or two clocks that really matter.

The GM Mindset: Three Guiding Principles

Principle	Guidance
1. Don't Fear Failure	The dice are not your opposition—they are your collaborators. When unsure, ask: <i>"Does this create a more interesting story?"</i> If yes, lean into it. The system rewards bold GM decisions with momentum, not penalties.
2. Spend SB to Create	Every Story Beat should open a new door, not close one. "The door slams shut" is weaker than "the door slams shut – but the echo draws guards closer." Favor movement, pressure, and consequences over hard stops.
3. The Real DV Is in Stakes	If a scene feels flat, raise the stakes – not the difficulty. Before the roll, be clear about what failure means. When players ask "What happens if I fail?", answer honestly. That answer is where tension lives, not in higher numbers.

Encounter in Action: The Ambush at Raven's Ford

This example shows how the core systems—narrative initiative, Story Beats, Boons, Bonds, and damage—come together in play. The party consists of **Thane** (fighter), **Sariel** (rogue), and **Kestra** (mage).

Setup

The group crosses a rope bridge when two bandits attack from the far side. GM sets the scene:

"The bridge sways under your feet. Two crossbowmen take aim from behind a boulder. Thane, you're closest to them. Sariel is mid-bridge, Kestra still on the near cliff."

No initiative rolled. GM asks: "Who acts first?" Thane says, "I charge." The GM agrees – he's closest and has momentum.

Round 1 — Thane's Turn

Thane rushes the bandits. GM: "Exposed on the bridge, crossbows trained on you – Desperate, DV 3 to reach them before they shoot." Thane rolls Body + Melee (6d10): 7,5,4,2,1,1 → two successes (7 only). One short → Miss.

Result: GM gains 2 SB (two 1s) and player gains 2 Boons. GM narrates:

"You make it halfway, but a bolt grazes your arm. Mark Harm 1. The bandits draw swords – they're in Close now."

Enemy Turn (No Roll)

Because Thane closed the distance, bandits "draw swords" as a consequence of his Miss. GM uses the 2 SB:

- **Spend 1 SB:** "The second bandit kicks a loose plank. The bridge lurches – everyone make Body + Athletics (DV 3) or be knocked Prone."
- **Spend 1 SB:** "Sariel, your footing slips; your next action is Desperate."

Sariel fails; she is Prone. Kestra succeeds.

Player Turn — Sariel Uses a Boon

Sariel stabs the nearest bandit from prone. GM: "Desperate, DV 3." She rolls: no successes → Miss, gains 2 Boons (now has 2 total). Before GM narrates failure, she **spends 1 Boon** to re-roll one die. Re-roll comes up 6 → adds one success, turning Miss into Partial. GM: "You slash his leg – he drops to one knee, but your dagger is lodged. It'll take a moment to free it."

Bond Transfer

Kestra has a Bond with Sariel ("She saved me once; I owe her"). As a free action (Tier III+), Kestra **transfers 2 Boons** to Sariel. Sariel now has 3 Boons.

Kestra's Turn — Boon for Environmental Effect

Kestra uses magic to collapse part of the bridge behind the bandits. She has **Spellcraft** and [EARTH], [BREAK]. GM: "Controlled, DV 4. Spend a Boon to improve to Dominant?" Kestra spends 1 Boon (now Dominant, DV 4). She rolls successfully, generating 1 SB (a 1). GM spends that SB immediately:

"The bridge splinters – the bandits are isolated! But the shockwave also loosens the rope on your side. New Clock: Bridge Collapse [4]."

Damage not rolled. Bandits stranded – a fictional consequence.

End of Encounter

Sariel, with extra Boons, frees the dagger and finishes the wounded bandit (Clean Success). The other bandit surrenders. No enemy "damage" rolled; all consequences came from SB, Position, and player choices.

Key Takeaways

- Initiative is narrative – whoever makes sense acts first.
- Enemies do not roll to hit. Their actions are consequences of PC misses or SB spends.
- Boons can re-roll, shift Position, create environmental effects, or be shared via Bonds.
- Damage (Harm) is applied directly from fiction, not from an enemy "attack roll."

2.13 Threshold Effects Reference

When a player announces "**I cross the threshold**" – a doorway, a riverbank, a crossroads, the space between sleeping and waking – use this table to determine the immediate effect. Thresholds are where the world's memory is thinnest; crossing them without respect invites attention.

GM Procedure for Threshold Crossings

1. Ask the player to describe **how** they cross (e.g., "I step over the river stone," "I open the door with my left hand").
2. Based on their description, set **Position** (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate).
3. Apply the effect from the table below. If the player showed respect (offering, announced name, proper etiquette), improve Position by one step.
4. Optionally, spend SB to escalate (see **SB Spend Opportunity** column).

Threshold Effects Table

Threshold Type	Typical Effect	SB Spend Opportunity	Respectful Crossing
Doorway (unwarded)	Position worsens one step (attention from spirits).	1 SB: door leads to wrong room.	Knock first; announce your name.
Doorway (warded)	Resolve test (DV 3) or mark 1 Fatigue.	2 SB: ward triggers (Harm 1).	Offer a coin or a hair.
Crossroads	GM asks a "choice" question; answer becomes true for the scene.	3 SB: a stranger appears with a bargain.	Leave a stone at the centre.
Riverbank	Roll Spirit + Survival (DV 3); success gives a vague omen.	2 SB: spirit from the water surfaces.	Pour a libation before drinking.
Bridge	Player must state a memory aloud; the bridge "remembers" it.	3 SB: bridge demands a toll (1 Fatigue).	Walk at the centre; do not run.
Sleep/waking edge	Player narrates a dream fragment; GM gains 1 SB.	4 SB: dream becomes real for one exchange.	Sleep with a red thread on the wrist.
Forest path	Navigate test (DV 3) or lose 1 segment of travel progress.	2 SB: trees shift; path loops back.	Tie a thread to a branch before entering.
Threshold of a home	First social roll inside gains +1 Position (guest-right).	1 SB: a portrait watches you.	Remove your shoes; wait to be invited.
Graveyard gate	Spirit + Resolve (DV 3) or feel a cold hand on your shoulder.	3 SB: an Echo manifests and asks a question.	Leave a coin on the nearest grave.

Threshold Clocks

For a location that is heavily liminal (a haunted manor, a fey crossing, a dungeon built on a ley line), start a **Threshold Instability [4–6]** clock. Tick it each time a player crosses a threshold without proper respect (no offering, no announced name, no etiquette). When the clock fills:

- Doors open to the wrong rooms.
- The dead walk for one scene.
- The party is lost in a mirror realm and must find their way out (treat as a Travel Clock [6]).

Player-Driven Thresholds

When a player says "I act at the threshold," encourage them to be specific. The GM uses that fiction to set Position:

- **Respectful crossing** (removing boots, pouring a libation, speaking a name) → Position starts one step higher (e.g., Controlled → Dominant).
- **Brazen crossing** (kicking the door open, stepping over without acknowledgment) → Position starts one step lower (e.g., Controlled → Desperate).

Example

The party stands before a moss-covered door in the Mistlands. **Player:** "I knock three times, then say 'guest seeking shelter'." **GM (respectful crossing):** "Dominant Position. Roll Spirit + Sway (DV 2) to see if the house welcomes you."

If the player had kicked the door, the GM would set Desperate Position and tick the *Threshold Instability* clock.

Chapter 3

Managing Resources

Philosophy of Resources

Resources are not there to hoard – they are tools to create drama.

- **Spend Boons freely.** Hoarding them for XP conversion starves the table of tension and robs players of their safety net.
- **Let Fatigue build.** Fatigue is not punishment; it is the rising tide that forces hard choices and heroic comebacks.
- **Obligation is plot, not punishment.** When a Patron calls in a debt, a story hook arrives. Embrace it.

The most memorable sessions come from characters spending their last Boon on a desperate re-roll, staggering forward under three Fatigue, or accepting a Patron's demand that changes everything.

In **Fate's Edge**, resources are narrative levers, not inventory lists. From the last sip of water in sun-scorched wastes to the fragile loyalty of a Ykrul war-band, every resource tells a story, and every story demands its price. As GM, you are the keeper of these threads—the weaver of scarcity and abundance. This chapter shows how to manage the systems that fuel mortal ambitions and epic campaigns.

3.1 Supply Clock: The Pulse of Survival

The **Supply Clock** tracks the party's access to essentials: food, water, gear, and logistical support. It is a shared party resource—a narrative lever that tightens tension when characters are isolated, pursued, or cut off from civilization.

3.1.1 Supply Clock States

Supply Clock Conditions

Segments Filled	Narrative Effects
0 (Full)	Well-equipped and prepared; no penalty.
1 (Low)	Minor complications: bland rations, damaged arrows, thinning waterskins.
2 (Dangerous)	Each character gains Fatigue 1 as scarcity takes its toll.
3 (Empty)	Severe penalties: starvation, dehydration, equipment failure imminent.

3.1.2 When to Advance the Supply Clock

The Supply Clock advances when the world turns against the party's preparations:

- Extended travel through hostile lands without proper provisioning (see **Travel Framework**, Chapter 9 of the Player's Guide or SRD Section 41).
- The GM spends **2+ Story Beats** on logistics failures or environmental hardships.
- The party chooses to travel light for speed or stealth.
- Failed **Survival** or **Craft** rolls related to hunting, foraging, or repair.

3.1.3 Clearing Supply Segments

The clock recedes when the party finds respite:

- Reaching civilization resets the clock to *Full*.
- A group **Survival** check (Wits + Survival, DV 2) in favorable conditions clears 1 segment.
- Downtime spent in relative safety removes 1 segment.
- Successful provisioning (a good hunt, a discovered cache) can reduce segments.

Example. A week-long sea passage with uncertain winds. A failed **Navigation** roll causes the GM to spend 2 SB – filling two segments as supplies spoil. The party is now at *Low Supply*. A second failed roll fills another segment – *Dangerously Low*. Fatigue sets in. The sea gnaws at their endurance.

3.2 Fatigue: The Weight of the World

Fatigue represents the cumulative toll of journeying through a world that rarely offers comfort: exhaustion that seeps into bones, hunger that hollows cheeks, strain that clouds judgment.

The Roller-Coaster Effect

Taking Harm clears Fatigue temporarily – the shock of a wound can jolt a character back into action. This creates a natural "roller coaster" of tension:

Example: Kael is at Fatigue 3 (Desperate, –2 dice). A goblin stabs him for Harm 1. The Harm conversion procedure: first convert Harm → Fatigue (none, light armor), then apply remaining Harm – which clears all Fatigue. Kael's Fatigue drops to 0, but his Harm increases to 1. He is wounded but suddenly clear-headed, ready to fight back.

Use this effect to create dramatic swings: a character near collapse who takes a wound and finds a second wind. It keeps combat unpredictable and rewards players who embrace risk.

3.2.1 Fatigue Effects

Each point of Fatigue worsens the character's **Position** by one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate). If already Desperate, each additional Fatigue instead imposes a **–1 die penalty** on all rolls. Penalties from Fatigue and Harm **stack**.

Fatigue Progression

Fatigue Level	Effect
1	Position worsens one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate)
2	If already Desperate, –1 die; otherwise Position worsens
3	–2 dice (if already Desperate from Fatigue)
4+	Collapse, KO, or spiritual break (incapacitated)

3.2.2 Clearing Fatigue

Recovery requires genuine respite:

- A **short rest** (quiet watch, food/water) removes **2 Fatigue**.
- A **full night's rest** in safety removes **all Fatigue**.
- Fatigue cannot be removed while the party is at *Dangerous* or *Empty Supply*.
- Medical attention (**Presence** + **Medicine**, DV 2) during downtime can remove an additional 1 Fatigue.

Narrative note: Fatigue is not only physical – it can reflect mental strain, grief, or spiritual exhaustion. A failed ritual might leave a caster at Fatigue 2 from metaphysical backlash alone.

3.2.3 Fatigue → Harm Conversion

Each character has a Fatigue track equal to their **Body** attribute. When the track fills:

1. Increase **Harm** by one level (0→Harm 1, Harm 1→Harm 2, Harm 2→Harm 3).
2. Clear all Fatigue.

This conversion can occur multiple times in a scene. (See the *Player's Guide* for full Harm rules.)

3.3 Boons: The Currency of Resilience

Boons are narrative tokens earned by embracing risk. They reward *failure with opportunity* – the silver lining in clouds of defeat.

Why You Should Spend Boons – The Math of Fun

Hoarding Boons for XP conversion leads to less engagement and lower fun scores.

Every Boon you hold is a dramatic moment waiting to happen:

- Re-rolling a critical failure turns despair into triumph.
- Improving Position before a risky roll turns a Desperate gamble into a Controlled chance.
- Activating an Asset brings your character's network into the story.

XP from Boons is a trickle (max 2 per session). The real reward is *agency*. The player who spends Boons shapes the story; the player who hoards them watches from the sidelines.

As GM, remind players: "You have 3 Boons. What will you spend them on?" When a player sits on 5 Boons, gently suggest they use one before the scene ends. A spent Boon is a moment of player power. An unspent Boon is wasted potential.

3.3.1 Earning Boons (GM Reminders)

- On a **Partial** (1 Boon) or **Miss** (2 Boons) with meaningful consequences.
- Through clever or risky roleplay that drives the story.
- Via bond-driven actions with intricate descriptions.
- At GM discretion for exceptional collaborative play.

Limit: At most **2 Boons** from failures per character per scene. Repetition of the same approach with the same stakes does not award additional Boons.

3.3.2 Boon Economy (Quick Reference)

- **Holding cap:** Maximum 5 Boons.
- **Carryover:** At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2 (excess lost).
- **Conversion:** Once per session during downtime, convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (max 2 XP per session via conversion).

3.3.3 Spending Boons (Player Options)

Players may spend 1 Boon to:

- Re-roll a single die (after seeing the pool).
- Activate an on-screen Asset.
- Improve Position by one step before a roll.
- Power certain Rites or abilities as described in their text.

Substituting Fatigue for Boons (Optional) If a player has no Boons remaining, they may substitute **1 Fatigue** for 1 Boon *once per scene*. This represents pushing through exhaustion for a last chance. The GM may veto if the fiction does not support it.

3.3.4 Anti-Fishing Measures (GM Guidance)

- **Once/Scene Cap:** At most 2 Boons from failures per character per scene.
- **Repetition Rule:** Same approach + same stakes in the same scene cannot award another Boon.
- **Position Gate:** *Dominant* tests with trivial fallout do not award Boons.

Design note: Boons reward narrative risk, not repeated failure.

3.4 Followers and Assets: Power Beyond the Self

Players can invest XP in **Followers** (on-screen allies) and **Assets** (off-screen resources). These are story agents with their own motivations and risks.

3.4.1 Followers: On-Screen Allies

Followers are bought with XP and tracked by a **Cap** (maximum assist bonus). Cost = Cap² XP; downtime 1–3 days to recruit.

Assisting in Scenes

- Assist dice equal min(Cap, helper's relevant Skill).
- Total assist from all sources capped at **+3 dice** (the *Exceptional Coordination* talent allows +4 from one follower).
- Only one follower may assist a given action.

Follower Independent Actions Once per scene, **one** follower may take a small independent action (the party can use this ability only once per scene, not per follower). Examples:

- **Scout & Signal** – Change an ally’s next action to *Dominant*.
- **Distract & Draw** – Reduce a threat/hunt/escape clock by 1 tick.
- **Fetch & Carry** – Move a small object through danger.

Cost: Mark **Exposure** +1 or **Harm** 1 on that follower.

Followers as Successors A Follower is not just a helper – they can become a **successor** if the player’s main character retires, dies, or ascends. This is the core of the Legacy Engine (see ?? in the full GM Guide). When a player’s character reaches a narrative endpoint, a trusted Follower (Cap 3+) can step into the spotlight with inherited Bonds, Assets, and a reduced XP cost.

When to Invest in Followers (GM Guidance)

When to Invest in Followers	
Player Archetype	Investment Advice
Solo	Minimal followers (Cap 1–2). Use for specific utility (scout, healer).
Mixed	One Cap 2–3 follower. The sweet spot for most players.
Mastermind	Cap 3–5 followers. Build a network. Accept that they will be endangered.

Follower Upkeep and Risk

- Each downtime, pay XP equal to Cap **or** spend a scene tending the relationship.
- Neglect → follower becomes *Wary* (or *Seized* if already *Wary*).
- If the GM spends **2+ SB** on an action you take with assistance, they may mark Exposure or Harm on the follower instead of other consequences (fiction first).
- **Off-Screen Capability:** Once per downtime, a Cap 3+ follower can solve a significant problem but generates **1 SB** for the party (the GM describes the resulting complication).

Follower Conditions Followers track two meters:

Exposure

- Attention, stress, narrative pressure.

Harm

- Injury, trauma, damage.

State: *Maintained* (full) → *Neglected* (–1 die) → *Compromised* (unavailable).

3.4.2 Assets: Off-Screen Influence

Assets are titles, safehouses, spy rings, charters. They do not act in scenes directly but change the fiction between sessions.

Asset Tiers

Tier	Cost and Examples
Minor	4 XP (1 day) – safehouse, small shop, local contact.
Standard	8 XP (1 week) – noble title, spy ring, workshop.
Major	12 XP (1 month) – city license, fortress lease, regional network.

Using Assets

- **Off-Screen Effect:** Use once per session for free (the quiet work between adventures).
- **On-Screen Activation:** Spend 1 Boon to use the asset dramatically in a scene.
- **Downtime Activation:** Pay 2 XP or 1 Boon to activate an asset at campaign start or during downtime.
- The asset must have plausible scope for the intended effect.

Asset Upkeep Each downtime:

- **Efficient (higher XP, less time):** Cost = $\max(1, \frac{\text{Acquisition XP}}{3})$. Minimal effort.
- **Intensive (lower XP, more time):** Cost = 1 XP. Requires a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- Failure to pay → asset becomes *Neglected* (or *Compromised* if already *Neglected*).

Asset Condition

Maintained

- Full capability.

Neglected

- –1 die when used; requires attention.

Compromised

- Unavailable until repaired or recovered.

3.5 Terrestrial Patrons: Favours and Debts

Not every patron is a cosmic entity. Powerful mortals—nobles, crime lords, generals, merchant princes—can act as **terrestrial patrons**. They offer tangible aid (escorts, legal protection, supplies, even ongoing Assets like a trade route or a safehouse) in exchange for favours.

Assets Without XP Cost, With Obligation

A terrestrial patron can provide the same benefits as a Minor or Standard Asset (see ??), but the party does not pay XP for it. Instead, they accept a **Debt Clock [4]** (or larger, for major favours) and track Obligation to the patron just as they would to a supernatural Patron (see ??). The patron's "Rites" are favours; the "Obligation" is the growing weight of what the party owes.

Asset or Patron? A GM's Shortcut

If the party needs a recurring advantage (a warehouse, a guild contact, a ship) and you want to avoid bookkeeping, offer it through a **terrestrial patron** instead of an XP-cost Asset. The party gets the benefit immediately; the price is story fuel (Obligation). If the players prefer to own the Asset outright and handle its upkeep themselves, they can purchase it with XP as usual. Both paths are valid – choose the one that generates the most interesting complications for your table.

3.5.1 How Terrestrial Patrons Work

When a character accepts a favor from a terrestrial patron, start a **Debt Clock** with the patron's name (e.g., "Prefect Marcellus's Favor [4]"). Mark one segment each time the character accepts a significant favor (e.g., a bribe, a military escort, access to a restricted archive). When the clock fills, the patron calls in the debt – a mission to be performed, a political favor, or a direct demand.

The party also tracks a separate **Obligation** tally for each terrestrial patron, exactly as they would for a supernatural Patron (see ??). Each accepted favor typically adds +1 Obligation. When Obligation exceeds the character's (or party's) capacity, they mark Fatigue and the patron may send a reminder – a messenger, a withdrawn favor, or a public hint that the debt is due.

Refusing to honour the debt turns the patron into an enemy (or at least a reliable antagonist). The GM may advance associated *Crisis* clocks or introduce complications from the patron's faction.

Use Debt Clocks Aggressively

Debt clocks are story fuel. Every time a player accepts a favor, they are inviting future conflict. Don't let debts linger – call them in at the worst possible moment:

- **Early (1–2 segments):** A messenger arrives with a "reminder." The patron asks for a small favor (deliver a package, spread a rumour).
- **Mid (3–4 segments):** The patron demands a significant service (escort a caravan through dangerous territory, provide alibis for a crime).
- **Full (5–6 segments):** The patron calls in the debt at a critical moment – during a negotiation, a battle, or a ritual. Refusal means the patron becomes an enemy.

Debts that are never called are wasted potential. Be bold.

3.5.2 Examples of Terrestrial Patron Debts

Sample Terrestrial Patrons	
Patron	Typical Favours and Debt Trigger
Prefect Marcellus (Ecktorian commander)	Grants safe passage, food, and a squad of guards. Debt: demand a dangerous mission behind enemy lines.
Censor Cassia (judicial authority)	Offers legal immunity, archive access. Debt: require the party to expose a political rival.
Khatun Sarnai (Ykrul chieftain)	Provides remounts, safe camp, steppe guides. Debt: demand a blood-price or a raid on a rival clan.
Tema (Vilikari merchant)	Smuggles goods, offers black market contacts. Debt: require the party to protect a secret caravan.
Additional Examples	
Mistress Ilvar (Silkstrand crime lord)	Grants access to the Black Bazaar and a crew of cutpurses. Debt: demand a public assassination during the Exchange opening.
Abbot Valerius (Thepyrgos Synod)	Provides sanctuary for fugitives and letters of indulgence. Debt: demand the party retrieve a "heretical" text from a sealed archive – without being caught.
Salt-Prince Kor (Zakov)	Gives a letter of marque and a fast cutter. Debt: demand the party act as decoys to draw away a rival's fleet.

3.5.3 Running Terrestrial Patrons

- Track each patron's Debt Clock and the party's Obligation to them on a visible handout.
- When a player asks for a favor, tell them the cost: "Marcellus will give you the keys to the armory, but that's worth one segment and +1 Obligation. Are you willing?"
- When a Debt Clock fills, the favor is due. Give the players a hook that fits the patron's personality and resources.
- If the party refuses, tick the associated *Crisis* clock or introduce a complication (e.g., loss of safe passage, arrest warrant, hired thugs). The patron may also demand immediate payment of the Obligation in the form of a significant sacrifice or a public apology.

3.5.4 Optional: Terrestrial Patron Reputation

Some campaigns may track a separate **Reputation Track** for each patron. High reputation grants better terms (more favours before the debt clock fills). Low reputation may cause the patron to

demand immediate payment before offering any help. Reputation can be advanced by completing the patron’s tasks on time or by publicly supporting their cause.

3.5.5 Clearing Terrestrial Obligation

Obligation to a terrestrial patron is cleared the same way as Obligation to a supernatural Patron: by performing an Act of Service (see ??) during downtime. The service must be concrete – repaying a loan, performing a public favor, or delivering a rival’s secret. The GM sets the scope: a small favor clears 1–2 segments; a major undertaking may clear the entire clock.

3.5.6 Cross-Reference

- For player-facing rules on terrestrial patrons, see ?? (Player’s Guide).
- For Asset upkeep and the XP alternative, see ?? and ??.
- For Obligation mechanics, see ??.

3.5.7 Milestones

At the end of a major story arc:

- +8–12 XP to all players.
- +2 XP bonus to one player for a signature moment of the arc.

3.6 Campaign Resources: Mandate and Crisis

Two campaign-level clocks track the party’s influence and the world’s resistance.

3.6.1 Mandate Clock (0–6)

Tracks the party’s public legitimacy.

- **High Mandate:** Allies seek them out, resources flow, doors open.
- **Low Mandate:** Suspicion, bureaucratic obstacles, support withers.

Advance the clock when the party gains renown (clean victories, public accolades) or loses face (scandals, broken oaths).

3.6.2 Crisis Clock (0–6)

Tracks the opposition’s growing strength.

- **Rising Crisis:** Complications escalate, enemies grow bolder.

- **Managed Crisis:** Breathing room, opportunities to strike back.

Advance the clock when the party fails key objectives, ignores looming threats, or the GM spends SB on faction escalation.

Example. If the party brokers a peace treaty, advance *Mandate* by 1. If they assassinate a rival leader but leave evidence, advance *Crisis* by 1. When either clock reaches 6, trigger a major faction response (a summons, an assassination attempt, a public trial).

3.7 Combat Resource Management

In combat, resource management takes on desperate urgency.

3.7.1 Supply in Combat

- **Intense Combat:** GM may spend 1 SB to fill 1 Supply segment (arrows break, waterskins puncture).
- **Prolonged Engagement:** Each hour of sustained combat adds 1 Supply segment.
- **Ammunition Depletion:** Ranged weapons may run low, requiring scavenging actions (e.g., **Craft** roll to recover arrows).

3.7.2 Fatigue in Combat

- Characters apply Fatigue penalties as described in 3.2.
- Reaching Fatigue level 4+ during combat causes immediate collapse (incapacitated).
- Fatigue cannot be cleared during active combat.

3.7.3 Follower Combat Integration

- Followers assist using their Cap (see 3.4.1).
- Spending **2+ SB** in combat can endanger an assisting follower (mark Exposure or Harm).
- Followers can take combat-relevant independent actions (cost: Exposure +1 or Harm 1).
- After a follower acts twice in a high-risk combat scene, mark Exposure +1.

3.7.4 Tactical Clocks

Tactical clocks represent persistent combat conditions that drain party resources.

Tactical Clock Effects

Clock	Resource Drain
Mob Overwhelm [6]	Accelerates Supply depletion and Fatigue.
Fatigue Spiral [4]	Accelerates existing Fatigue, makes each action harder.
Morale Collapse [6]	Generates SB, reduces effectiveness.
Environmental Collapse [8]	Creates new Supply and safety concerns.

3.7.5 Over-Stack Trigger

- If the party **enters** a scene with ≥ 3 **structural advantages**, the GM *may* apply Over-Stack once for that scene.
- Choose: start one obstacle at +1 DV, **or** bank +1 SB for the first Deck Twist.
- Over-Stack applies only to advantages held at scene framing, not those generated through play.

Examples of Structural Advantages Active buffs, favourable terrain (high ground, chokepoint), unused Follower Initiative, on-screen Asset activation, enemy disadvantage (surprised, trapped, outnumbered), ritual preparation that applies to the scene.

3.8 Narrative First: The Fiction Is the Ledger

In Fate's Edge, arrows, rations, and waterskins are tracked only in the fiction that surrounds them. Mechanics engage only when those resources become scarce enough to matter. The focus remains always on **narrative tension** – the gnawing hunger, the fading light, the last arrow – not sterile bookkeeping.

Abstracting Coin and Time. Routine expenses and petty bribes are handled narratively ("You have enough coin from past jobs to cover a week's stay"). For major expenses (bribing a corrupt official, outfitting an expedition, buying a rare magical component), players may spend **XP** in place of coin (1 XP = a substantial sum). Use the "XP as currency" rule sparingly; it should feel like a meaningful sacrifice, not a tax.

GM Reminder. When a player asks "Do I have enough arrows?" the answer is almost always "yes" until it becomes dramatically interesting to say "no." Similarly, track Supply only when the party is isolated, pursued, or in a hostile environment. Let the world breathe with its own needs and abundances. And when the dice say the world pushes back against mortal plans – **listen to what they tell you about the price of ambition.**

Chapter 4

Running a Currency-Free Economy

GM's Note: The Ledger Is Fiction

"You don't need to track every copper. Track what matters: the safehouse the players bled for, the oath they swore to the pirate queen, the favor they owe the fox spirit. That's the real economy."

This chapter provides guidance for running the currency-free economy described in the Player's Guide (??). As the GM, your role is to translate player investments—XP, barter, Strings, Obligation, and Trusts—into meaningful story outcomes. You are not an accountant; you are a curator of consequence.

4.1 Core Principles for the GM

1. **Hand-wave the trivial.** If a player asks for something small and sensible (a meal, a horse, a basic tool), say yes. Scarcity is a tool, not a default.
2. **Significant gains cost significant resources.** Use the XP cost table (??) as a baseline, but be flexible: barter, Strings, or Obligation are equally valid.
3. **Debt is a story engine.** When players accept a Debt Clock, they are inviting future complications. Don't let debts linger – call them in at dramatically appropriate moments.
4. **Trusts are player-driven factions.** Encourage players to form Trusts, then use them to generate missions, rivals, and hard choices.
5. **XP spent is XP remembered.** When a player spends XP on an asset or a follower, make that asset matter in the fiction. A safehouse should be threatened; a follower should have opinions.

4.2 Adjudicating Barter and Strings

4.2.1 When to Allow Barter

Barter is appropriate when the player character has something the other party genuinely wants. Ask yourself:

- Does the PC possess a unique item, secret, or service?
- Does the NPC have a clear motivation (greed, fear, ambition)?
- Is the exchange roughly equal in narrative weight?

If the answer to all three is yes, allow barter. If not, the NPC may demand XP, Obligation, or a String instead.

Example: Sera offers a stolen Ashaani spirit-lamp to a Sidhi smuggler in exchange for passage on her ship. The smuggler wants the lamp (it can hide her cargo from inspectors). The exchange is balanced. No roll is needed unless the GM wants to introduce tension (e.g., a Deception roll to hide the lamp's curse).

4.2.2 Rolling for Barter

For contentious or high-stakes barter, call for a roll:

- **Skill:** Presence+Sway (negotiation), Wits+Streetwise (knowing the right price), or Spirit+Lore (appealing to shared customs).
- **DV:** 2 (friendly counterparty) to 5 (desperate or hostile counterparty).
- **Position:** Controlled for fair trade; Desperate if the PC is under pressure.

On a **Clean Success**, the barter succeeds as proposed. On a **Success with SB**, the trade happens but the GM gains 1 SB to spend on a complication (e.g., the item is stolen goods, the NPC will betray them later). On a **Partial**, the trade happens but the PC must add a sweetener (a small favor, a promise, 1 XP). On a **Miss**, the NPC refuses; the GM may offer a Devil's Bargain (accept a Debt Clock to salvage the deal).

4.2.3 Spending Strings

When a player wants to spend a String (see ??), ask:

- **Is the String relevant?** A "Minor String" from a grain inspector won't help negotiate with a pirate queen. If the String is a poor fit, the player can still spend it, but reduce its effective value by one tier (e.g., Minor → trivial, only a +1 die bonus).
- **Does the String need a roll?** Usually not – a String represents an established relationship. However, if the NPC is hostile or the request is extreme, call for a roll (Presence+Sway, DV 3). On a failure, the String is still consumed, but the NPC demands something extra.

- **What happens when a String is spent?** The narrative permission is used up. The NPC may say "We're even now." The String is removed from the player's sheet. If the player wants a similar favor later, they must earn a new String.

4.2.4 Introducing New Strings

Strings are a great reward for roleplaying. Award a Minor String when a player:

- Saves an NPC's life or reputation.
- Completes a significant side quest for a faction.
- Reveals a secret that benefits the NPC.
- Pays a Debt Clock segment through service (see 4.3).

Award a Standard or Major String for campaign-level deeds: brokering a peace treaty, exposing a conspiracy, or retrieving a legendary artifact.

4.3 Managing Debt Clocks

Debt Clocks are the currency-free equivalent of loans with interest. They are story engines, not punishments.

4.3.1 Creating a Debt Clock

When a player accepts a Debt Clock (e.g., in exchange for an asset or a favor), create a visible clock (4, 6, or 8 segments) with a clear label: *"Debt to the Vermilion Cord [6]"* or *"Oath to the Fox Spirit [4]"*.

4.3.2 Ticking the Debt Clock

Advance the clock by 1 segment when:

- The player fails a roll related to the debt (e.g., failing to deliver cargo on time).
- The GM spends 2 Story Beats (SB) on a complication tied to the debt.
- A session ends without the player making progress toward repayment (tick once per session).

When the clock reaches its final segment, the debt is **due**. The creditor makes a demand. The demand should be significant but not impossible:

- A dangerous mission (steal from a rival, assassinate a target).
- A public declaration of loyalty (which may alienate another faction).
- A sacrifice of equal value (a personal Asset, a magical item, a String).

If the player refuses, the creditor becomes an enemy (advance the Crisis clock, start a new Rival clock, or send enforcers).

4.3.3 Clearing Debt Clock Segments

Players can clear segments by:

- Spending 2 XP per segment (treat as buying off the debt with hard work).
- Performing a service (GM discretion – usually a scene or a roll clears 1–2 segments).
- Offering an equivalent String or Asset to the creditor.

4.3.4 Debt as a Reward

Do not treat Debt Clocks as purely negative. They give players access to resources they couldn't otherwise afford. A party that accepts a Debt Clock [6] for a ship gains a powerful asset immediately – the clock is the price of adventure. Make the eventual demand exciting, not punitive.

4.4 Running Trusts (Player-Owned Patrons)

Trusts are player-led factions. They give players a sense of ownership and generate endless plot hooks.

4.4.1 Helping Players Form a Trust

When players express interest in forming a Trust (see 4.4.1), guide them through:

- **Naming the Trust** – should reflect purpose and tone.
- **Defining its Seat** – a physical headquarters (warehouse, guild hall, ship).
- **Choosing a Purpose** – smuggling, trade, information, mercenary work, etc.
- **Establishing an initial Debt Clock** – the cost of founding. Clear it through a short introductory mission.

Require the party to contribute 10 XP from their pool (see ??). If they don't have enough, let them work toward it over a few sessions.

4.4.2 Trust Obligation

Members incur Obligation to the Trust when they ask for its help (borrowing an Asset, requesting a Follower, etc.). Track this separately from other Obligation. When a member's Obligation exceeds their Spirit+Presence, the Trust demands a task. This is your chance to introduce a mission that advances the Trust's goals – and puts the party in conflict with other factions.

Sample Trust Demands:

- "The Silkhand League needs you to eliminate a rival merchant's shipment."
- "Our spy network has gone silent in Port Shed. Investigate."

- "The harbor master is squeezing our dues. Find leverage on him."
- "One of our own has been kidnapped by the Veiled Sisters. Rescue them."

If a player refuses a Trust demand, they are expelled and lose all Trust benefits. Expulsion should be a major story beat – the character becomes a pariah among their own creation.

4.4.3 Growing the Trust

As players invest more XP into the Trust (see ??), expand its capabilities and its enemies. A Trust with a spy network (Standard Asset) attracts the attention of rival intelligence agencies. A Trust with a fortress (Major Asset) becomes a target for sieges or political intrigue. Use the Trust's growth to escalate the campaign.

4.4.4 Trusts as Antagonists

A Trust can also be an enemy – a rival guild, a corrupt merchant house, or a fanatical cult. Treat it as a faction with its own clocks (see 7.3) and Strings. Players might infiltrate it, steal from it, or try to destroy it. The rules for Trusts are symmetrical: you can run an NPC Trust using the same mechanics.

4.5 Handling Common Player Behaviors

4.5.1 Hoarding XP

Players may be reluctant to spend XP on non-personal advancement. Remind them:

- XP spent on assets and Trusts is not lost – it creates durable story elements that benefit the whole party.
- Unspent XP does nothing. A safehouse or a follower is tangible power.
- The game's pacing assumes some XP will go toward external resources. If players hoard, they may lack leverage in faction-level conflicts.

If hoarding persists, introduce situations where personal power alone is insufficient: a locked vault that requires a spy network (Asset), a siege that needs a safehouse, a negotiation that demands a Trust's backing.

4.5.2 Farming Boons for XP Conversion

In the currency-free economy, players can still convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (see 3.3). If they try to farm Boons by intentionally failing trivial rolls, invoke the anti-fishing measures (3.3.4): no Boons from safe, repetitive, or stakes-free actions. Remind them that Boons are for dramatic moments, not XP grinding.

4.5.3 Abusing Strings

If players try to use the same String repeatedly ("I call in the grain inspector's favor again"), rule that a String is exhausted after one meaningful use. The NPC may say "We're even now." Players can earn a new String by doing another favor.

4.5.4 Overloading the Party Pool

If players contribute all their XP to the party pool and neglect personal advancement, they may become underpowered in direct challenges. Warn them gently: "Your character hasn't improved their combat skills in a while – are you sure you want to put everything into the Trust?" Offer a session or two of personal advancement before the next big mission.

4.6 Integrating with Existing Systems

4.6.1 Supply Clock

The Supply Clock (see 3.1) represents scarcity of mundane resources. Use it when the party is isolated, pursued, or in a hostile environment. Do not use it to nickel-and-dime players over everyday costs – that defeats the purpose of the currency-free system.

4.6.2 Assets and Followers

The XP costs for Assets and Followers remain unchanged. The only difference is that players never pay coin for upkeep – only XP or downtime actions (see ??). If a player wants to "buy" an Asset with barter or Strings, use the equivalencies in ??.

4.6.3 Terrestrial Patrons

A terrestrial patron (see 3.5) is a natural fit for the currency-free economy. Instead of paying coin for a patron's favor, the party accepts a Debt Clock. The patron's demands become adventure hooks. Treat Trusts as a special case of terrestrial patron – one controlled by the players themselves.

4.6.4 Magic and Components

Magical components (rare herbs, spirit dust, etc.) should be treated as barter goods or Strings, not coin. A player might acquire a "dragon's tooth" (String value: Major) by completing a quest, then use it to power a High Rite without spending XP. Alternatively, they can spend XP directly to represent the effort of finding or crafting the component.

4.7 GM Tools and Quick Reference

4.7.1 At-a-Glance: When to Charge What

| Player wants... | Charge... | |—————|—————| | A meal, a horse, a basic tool | Nothing (hand-wave) | | A safehouse, a spy network, a workshop | XP (4–12) or barter/String of equal value | | A follower (Cap 1–5) | XP (Cap²) or Debt Clock | | A one-time ship passage | Nothing (if routine) or a String/Debt Clock (if dramatic) | | A magical item (single use) | 2–4 XP or barter/String | | A permanent magical item | 6–10 XP + quest | | A favor from an NPC | String (if already earned) or Debt Clock (if new) | | To clear a Debt Clock segment | 2 XP or a service scene |

4.7.2 SB Menu for Currency Complications

Spend Story Beats (see 2.4) to introduce economic complications:

- **1 SB:** A promised barter item is slightly damaged or cursed; the NPC demands a small extra favor.
- **2 SB:** A Debt Clock ticks unexpectedly (a creditor grows impatient). A String is discovered to be counterfeit.
- **3 SB:** A Trust Asset is threatened (rival faction sabotages the safehouse). A major barter deal falls through; the party loses a potential String.
- **4+ SB:** A Trust schism occurs; the party must mediate or lose half their members. A Debt Clock is called in early, at the worst possible moment.

4.7.3 Sample Trust Advancement Track

Present this to players as a menu for spending XP on their Trust:

Investment (XP)	Unlock
4	Increase Trust Debt Clock capacity by 2
6	Add a Minor Asset (e.g., a contact network in one port)
8	Upgrade an Asset from Minor to Standard
10	Add a Cap 3 Follower (a trusted lieutenant)
12	Gain a permanent Standard String (a faction owes the Trust a favor)
15	Trust becomes a Major Terrestrial Patron (can grant its own Rites)

4.8 Final Advice

The currency-free economy is designed to reduce bookkeeping and increase drama. Embrace its flexibility. When in doubt, ask yourself: *"What would make the story more interesting right now?"*

- If a player wants something trivial, give it freely.

- If they want something significant, ask for XP, a String, or a Debt Clock.
- If they want something monumental, make it the focus of an entire session (or arc).

Remember: The players' XP and Strings are not just resources – they are maps of what your players care about. A player who spends XP on a spy network wants intrigue. A player who accepts a Debt Clock for a ship wants nautical adventure. A player who founds a Trust wants to build a legacy. Give them what they paid for.

The Gray Wanderer's Ledger

"I have seen a kingdom bought with a whispered secret and a war started with a broken scale. Coin is for counting what is already dead. XP, Strings, and debts – those are for counting what is still alive. Spend them well."

Chapter 5

Magic and Backlash

In **Fate's Edge**, magic is not a clean art practiced in sterile towers. It is a **dangerous negotiation with forces beyond mortal comprehension**. As the GM, your role is to make magic **feel weighty, thematic, and alive with risk**. This chapter provides tools for adjudicating magical actions, managing consequences, and keeping the story at the forefront.

*For player-facing rules (spellcasting, Rites, Invoker symbols, Cantor songs, etc.), see the **Player's Guide**. This chapter focuses on your role as GM.*

5.1 The Role of Magic in Your Game

Magic in Fate's Edge is:

- **Consequential** – Every spell changes the fiction, for good or ill.
- **Risky** – Even success may generate Story Beats (SB) that you spend to complicate the moment.
- **Thematic** – Backlash should reflect the elements and Patrons involved.
- **Creative** – Reward inventive uses, but keep scope within the players' tier.

Your primary job is not to block magic, but to **frame costs, apply consequences, and escalate drama**. When a player wants to cast a spell, ask:

- What do they want to achieve?
- Which elements or Patrons are involved?
- What is at stake if it goes wrong?

5.1.1 Patron as Co-Star

Patrons are not just sources of power – they are **co-stars** in the story. How you deploy them depends on your campaign's length and tone.

Passive Patrons (Long Campaigns) In campaigns that run 20+ sessions, let the players accrue Obligation slowly. The GM narrates consequences only when thresholds are breached (e.g., reaching capacity, triggering a Patron Intrusion). The Patron remains a distant, ominous presence – a slow boiler.

Active Patrons (Short Campaigns / One-Shots) In short arcs (3–6 sessions) or one-shots, the GM should look for hooks aggressively. Offer bargains, push the Obligation spiral, and have the Patron appear in dreams, omens, or via intermediaries **every session**. The goal is to make the price of power immediate and visible.

Use this table to calibrate Patron involvement:

Campaign Length	Patron Style	How Often They Interfere
One-shot (1–2 sessions)	Hyperactive	Every scene, via SB spends or direct demands
Short arc (3–6 sessions)	Active	Once per session, often as a Devil's Bargain
Mid arc (7–15 sessions)	Pacing	Every 2–3 sessions; Obligation builds slowly
Long campaign (16+ sessions)	Passive	Only at thresholds or major story beats

The Simulation Insight Players enjoy being **tempted, not forced**. Offer a Patron's aid as a choice: "You can succeed automatically, but your Patron will ask for something later. Do you accept?" This turns Obligation from a punishment into a dramatic lever.

5.2 Adjudicating Magic at the Table

Setting Difficulty Value (DV) and Position

Use the standard DV ladder (2–5+), but consider magical specifics:

DV for Magic	
DV	When to Use
2	Routine cantrip, minor sensory effect, no opposition.
3	Standard combat spell, small environmental change, contested but fair.
4	Complex working, area effect, strong opposition, dangerous ritual.
5+	Legendary magic, rewriting reality, binding a major Outsider.

Position for Magic

- **Dominant:** Caster has ritual preparation, rare components, or surprise.
- **Controlled:** Standard casting under normal conditions.
- **Desperate:** Caster is wounded, rushed, or in an anti-magic zone.

Position affects the severity of backlash (see 5.3).

Quick Reference Table: DV by Spell Scope

Scope	Example	DV
Cantrip	Light a candle, sense magic	2
Combat	Fire bolt, force shield	3
Ritual (small)	Find a lost object, speak with a spirit	4
Ritual (large)	Summon a storm, teleport across a region	5+
Epic	Raise a dead army, rewrite a law of reality	6+ (with quest)

Range Bands for Magic

Spells and effects have natural range limits based on their tags and fiction. Use these guidelines:

Range Band	Typical Spells
Close	Touch, personal aura, short cone.
Near	Same room/zone, thrown magics, most combat spells.
Far	Across a battlefield, line of sight without obstacles.
Absent	Ritual scrying, long-distance teleportation (requires setup).

Adjusting Range: A spell can be extended one band by increasing DV by 1, adding a SB, or requiring an extra action. Extreme range (e.g., scrying a distant city) should be a ritual, not a single roll.

Handling Creative Player Ideas

When a player tries something unexpected:

1. Listen to the description. What do they want to achieve?
2. Ask for the tags or elements involved. If none, help them add one.
3. Set DV and Position based on scope and risk (see 5.2).
4. Clearly state the stakes: “If you fail, the spell will backfire and also alert the guards.”
5. Let the dice decide, then spend SB to make the outcome interesting.

When in Doubt

A spell’s power is not measured by how many dice it rolls, but by **how much it changes the story**. Use this rule of thumb:

- **Minor change (1 TAG):** The player’s intent affects only themselves or a single object. Examples: **Light**, **HEAL**, **Veil** (self only). DV 2–3.
- **Moderate change (2 TAGS):** The spell affects a whole zone, creates a significant advantage, or bypasses a notable obstacle. Examples: **Area + Force**, **Barrier** across a

doorway. DV 3–4.

- **Major change (3+ TAGS):** The spell rewrites the situation, solves a major problem outright, or introduces a new faction/ally/threat. Examples: **Teleport** across a city, **Summon** a Cap 3 spirit, **Transform** a person into a beast. DV 5+ and often a ritual.

If the player's description would *skip over a scene* (e.g., "I teleport us past the entire fortress"), that's a major change – require components, a clock, or a steep cost. If it would only *add flavor* (e.g., "I make my eyes glow red"), that's free. Let the fiction guide the DV, not a pre-computed formula.

GM Ruling: Healing Magic

Dangerous TAGS – When Magic Rewrites the Story

Some spell effects are so profound that they cannot be treated as ordinary TAGS. They ****break the normal physics of the scene****, ****skip over significant narrative obstacles****, or ****permanently alter characters or the world****. These are ****dangerous TAGS**** and they incur ****+2 DV**** instead of the usual +1.

Why Are Some TAGS Dangerous?

- **Narrative Bypass:** A single roll should not invalidate an entire scene or challenge. **Teleport** past a castle wall, **Gate** to another continent, or **Transform** a boss into a mouse – these erase established fiction.
- **Lasting Consequences:** Effects that create permanent changes (resurrection, true polymorph, rewriting memory) demand a higher price.
- **Reality Strain:** The Weave (or whatever magical substrate you use) resists extreme manipulation. Dangerous tags represent that resistance.
- **Patron Attention:** Acts of cosmic magnitude attract the notice of powerful entities – a cost reflected in the higher DV.

Common Dangerous TAGS (Non-exhaustive)

Table 5.1: Dangerous TAGS and Why They Are Dangerous

TAG	Category	Why Dangerous (Narrative Impact)
Leap	Space/Motion	Teleports a person or object across range bands (Near → Far) without traversing the space. Can bypass walls, guards, or entire obstacles if line of sight exists.
Fold	Space/Motion	Short-range teleport that can ignore physical barriers (e.g., through a locked door).
Gate	Space/Motion	Creates a two-way portal between distant locations. Can bypass entire adventures.

Gravity	Space/Motion	Alters local gravity – flight, crushing weight, or throwing enemies into the sky. Scene-rewriting.
Create	Creation	Brings a permanent (or long-lasting) object into existence from nothing. Circumvents resource scarcity.
Summon	Creation	Calls a creature (Cap 3+) that can fight, scout, or solve problems independently. Adds a new actor to the scene.
Transmute	Transformation	Changes one substance into another (lead → gold, stone → flesh). Economic or structural game-changer.
Animate	Transformation / Creation	Gives life to inanimate objects – a statue that fights, a rope that ties itself. Adds a persistent minion.
Transform	Transformation	Changes a creature’s form permanently (or for a long duration). Polymorph, petrification, lycanthropy.
Dominate	Mind	Takes total control of a sapient creature’s actions. Removes player/NPC agency.
Rewind	Time	Reverses time locally – undoes an action, a death, or a scene. Extreme narrative power.
Resurrect	Life/Death	Brings a dead character back to life. Undermines mortal stakes.

How to Decide If a Player's TAG Is Dangerous

When a player proposes a spell, ask yourself three questions:

1. **Does this effect skip over a significant obstacle or scene?** If the spell would allow the party to bypass a challenge that you intended to be a whole scene (e.g., "I teleport us into the vault" instead of "I pick the lock, evade the guard, and disable the trap"), it is ****dangerous****.
2. **Does this effect permanently change the character, a major NPC, or the setting?** If the change is not easily reversible by mundane means (e.g., turning a guard into a frog, erasing a memory, raising a corpse), it is ****dangerous****.
3. **Does this effect introduce a new major asset or remove a major threat with a single roll?** If the spell would instantly defeat a boss ("I transform Garrick into a mouse"), destroy a fortress ("I collapse the mountain"), or create a powerful ally ("I summon a dragon"), it is ****dangerous**** – and likely requires a ritual, not a single action.

Edge Cases

- **Leap** used to jump a chasm that would otherwise require an Athletics roll – ****not dangerous**** (that's a minor bypass).
- **Leap** used to teleport past a locked gate, a patrol, and a guard post – ****dangerous**** (bypasses multiple obstacles).
- **Summon** calling a Cap 1 rat to scout a room – ****not dangerous**** (minor utility).
- **Summon** calling a Cap 3 demon to fight a boss – ****dangerous**** (adds a major combatant).

GM Principle When in doubt, ****rule in favor of the story****. A dangerous tag is not a prohibition – it is a ****higher cost****. Tell the player:

> "That effect is powerful enough to reshape the scene. It's a dangerous tag, so the DV will be +2 higher than usual. On a failure, the backlash will be severe. Are you sure you want to try?"

This keeps player creativity alive while ensuring magic feels weighty and consequential.

HEAL restores Fatigue, not Harm. When a player uses a cantrip with only HEAL, it removes 1 Fatigue. This is safe, fast, and low-risk.

Healing Harm costs more. To restore 1 level of Harm, the player must either:

- accept a **+2 DV modifier** on the spell, or
- use HEAL with another tag (e.g., Purify, Strengthen).

The injury's severity can raise DV further (e.g., Harm 2 → +1 DV on top). Requiring a second tag also makes healing a full two-action spell (Weave + Cast) unless the caster has a talent that compresses casting.

GM Tools: When a player heals Harm, you may spend any Story Beats generated by the roll to introduce thematic complications (e.g., the wound leaves a scar, the healing draws supernatural attention, or the patient feels a strange hunger). This keeps magical healing dramatic, not trivial.

Healing Magic (GM Ruling)

Healing in **Fate's Edge** is deliberately gated. **HEAL** restores **Fatigue** quickly and safely; restoring **Harm** requires more power, more risk, and often a narrative price. This keeps injuries meaningful while still allowing magical support.

HEAL Restores Fatigue, Not Harm. When a player uses a cantrip (or a free-form casting) with only the [HEAL] tag, it removes **1 Fatigue** from the caster or a touched ally.

- **DV:** 2 (cantrip speed)
- **Action:** 1 action
- **Risk:** None inherent – the GM may still spend Story Beats (from any 1s on the roll) for thematic colour (e.g., a scar that tingles, faint spiritual attention).

This is the "bandage and breath" of magical healing – reliable, fast, and low-risk.

Healing Harm Costs More. To restore **1 level of Harm** (e.g., Harm 1 → 0, or Harm 2 → 1), the player must either:

1. Accept a **+2 DV modifier** on the spell, or
2. Use [HEAL] together with **at least one other appropriate tag**, such as:
 - [PURIFY] – for poison, disease, or corruption
 - [STRENGTHEN] – for broken bones or torn muscles
 - [CLEANSE] – for curses or magical wounds

The GM may increase the DV further for exceptionally severe injuries:

Wound Severity	DV Adjustment
Minor Harm (level 1)	no extra
Serious Harm (level 2)	+1 DV
Critical Harm (level 3)	+2 DV (often requires a full ritual)

Requiring a second tag also makes healing a **full two-action spell** (Weave then Cast) unless the caster has a talent that compresses casting (e.g., *Effortless Casting*).

Complications – Story Beats as Narrative Cost. When a player rolls to heal Harm, any 1s on the roll generate Story Beats (SB) for you. Spend these SB to introduce **thematic complications** – the healing works, but the world pushes back.

Spend SB on Healing Complications

SB Cost	Example Complication
1 SB	The wound leaves a visible scar; the patient feels a strange hunger for a day.
2 SB	A minor spirit of injury is attracted – it watches the patient for a scene.
3 SB	The healing draws a Patron's curiosity: mark +1 Obligation or advance a Corruption clock.
4+ SB	A nearby corpse briefly animates, or the patient remembers a forgotten trauma.

These complications **do not undo the healing**. They add story. A scar is a memory; a Patron's interest is a future hook. Healing in Fate's Edge is never trivial.

Non-Magical Healing – Quick Reference. Even without magic, characters can recover:

- **First Aid (Wits + Medicine, DV 3):** Stabilises a dying character (prevents Harm progression). Does not heal Harm.
- **Short Rest (1 hour):** Clears 1 Fatigue.
- **Full Night's Rest (safe haven):** Clears all Fatigue and, with medical care, may restore 1 Harm per day of rest.

Design Note for GMs.

- **Fatigue is common, Harm is rare.** Keep the party moving by letting them clear Fatigue easily. Harm should feel earned and expensive to remove.
- **Let the cleric (or healer) shine.** A Runekeeper of the Oath of Flame or a Cantor with healing songs should be able to heal Harm – at a cost that makes the table pause.
- **Use the SB menu above as inspiration, not a straitjacket.** A scar that aches in cold weather, a debt to a spirit of mercy, or a public miracle that attracts unwanted attention – all are fair game.

Example in play:

Marcus (Harm 1) asks Kestra to heal him. Kestra uses [HEAL] + [PURIFY] and accepts the +2 DV, rolling against DV 5. She succeeds, but rolls two 1s. The GM spends 2 SB: "The wound closes, but a faint scar remains – and you feel a pair of cold eyes watching from the shadows. Something in the fog took notice."

5.3 Story Beats and Backlash (GM Tools)

Every time a player rolls a 1 on a magical action, you gain Story Beats (SB) as described in 2.2. Spend them to create backlash – complications that fit the magic's element and the fiction.

SB Spend Menu for Magic

Spend SB on Magical Complications	
SB Cost	Example Backlash
1 SB	Minor flare, eerie sound, brief sensory distortion, gear lightly scorched.
2 SB	Backlash harms an ally (Fatigue 1), spell draws attention, caster loses balance (Position -1).
3 SB	Patron omen, secondary target affected, magical feedback (Harm 1 to caster).
4+ SB	Reality warps – zone gains a temporary tag, Patron manifests a demand, a new threat appears.

Creating a Choice with SB

One of the most powerful GM moves is to spend SB to offer a **hard choice** – not just a consequence.

Example: The player succeeds on a ritual to divine an enemy's location. The roll generates 2 SB. The GM spends them:

"You see the enemy's camp clearly – but your Patron's symbol glows hot on your hand. **You can have the vision for free, or you can let the spell fizzle and keep your Obligation unchanged.** If you accept the vision, mark +2 Obligation and your Patron will demand a task. What do you choose?"

This turns a success into a narrative fork, not a punishment.

Elemental Backlash Examples

Use these to color your complications:

Element	Sample Backlash
Fire	Smoke, heat exhaustion, small secondary fire, blinding flare.
Water	Flooding, slippery footing, emotional surge, dampness ruining supplies.
Earth	Tremor, dust cloud, immobilising stone grip, cracked floor.
Air	Sudden gust, deafening thunder, scatters important items, voice lost.
Fate	Prophetic nightmare, doors close, a crucial option disappears.
Luck	Allied misfortune, fragile success, random complication.
Life	Overgrowth, healing surge on enemy, parasitic plants.
Death	Ghostly whisper, chill, memory loss, premature decay.

Backlash Severity by Position

Position	Backlash Severity on Partial/Miss
Dominant	Minor – one SB complication, manageable cost.
Controlled	Moderate – 1–2 SB complication, temporary setback.
Desperate	Severe – 2–3 SB complication, lasting consequences or Harm.

5.4 Managing Obligation and Corruption

Players track their own Obligation and Corruption as described in 2.6. **Your job is to enforce thresholds and frame Patron intrusions as story hooks, not punishments.**

Obligation Overflow and Patron Intrusions

When a character exceeds their Obligation Capacity (Spirit + Presence):

- For each segment over capacity, mark 1 Fatigue (player does this).
- If they exceed **double capacity**, clear all Fatigue, mark Harm 1, and trigger a **Patron Intrusion** – a narrative demand or complication from the Patron.

Examples of Patron Intrusions

- The Patron appears in a dream: “Do this task for me, or else.”
- A rival servant of the same Patron arrives to collect a debt.
- The Patron’s mark becomes visible on the character’s skin, causing social trouble.
- A faction aligned with the Patron forcibly recruits the character.

Corruption as a Narrative Track

Corruption (Cantors, Pact-Whisperers) fills from pushes, resonant rites, and your SB spends. When the clock fills (see 2.6.5):

- Apply the Patron’s “benefit and burden” (see Patron tables in the **Player’s Guide**).
- Reset the clock to the character’s Tier minimum.
- If the player chooses **Embrace Corruption**, give them a permanent thematic quirk (not a pure penalty).

5.5 Summoning (GM-Facing)

For full summoning mechanics, see the **Player’s Guide** (Pact-Whisperer). Here are your key responsibilities.

What to Watch For

- **Leash ticking:** Tick the Leash whenever the spirit takes Harm, acts against its nature, the summoner splits focus, or the spirit crosses a [WARD] (test DV = Cap).
- **Boon Finesse:** Players may spend 1 Boon once per round to clear 1 tick (before the Leash fills).
- **Quick Commands:** Simple orders (attack nearest, hold, fetch) do not cost the summoner's action. Complex commands do.

When the Spirit Acts on Its Own

On a Miss, or when the Leash fills, the spirit acts once according to its nature before departing (or turning hostile). The spirit's independent action should be **interesting** – not just damage. Use the table below for inspiration.

d6 Spirit Whims Table

d6	Spirit's Independent Action
1	Reveal a Secret: The spirit blurts out a hidden fact about a PC or NPC – true, embarrassing, or dangerous.
2	Break Something: The spirit shatters a mundane object (a lantern, a rope bridge, a crucial tool).
3	Lead Astray: The spirit moves a short distance and creates a false trail, forcing the party to waste time.
4	Call for Help: The spirit summons a minor ally (a rat swarm, a will-o'-wisp, a lesser elemental).
5	Curse a PC: The spirit leaves a lingering mark (–1 die on one skill until the next sunrise).
6	Bargain: The spirit offers a deal: "Release me now, and I'll tell you where the treasure is hidden."

Spirit Specializations (Quick Reference)

If a player develops a bonded spirit, you may grant one specialization from this list:

- **Combat:** +1 Harm melee, ignore first Harm on attacks.
- **Scout:** Stealthy; Cap 1 carries 2 kg, Cap 3 carries 10 kg.
- **Utility:** Simple tasks (carrying, opening doors).
- **Shield:** Interpose; convert Harm to Fatigue.

5.6 Cantors and Corruption (GM Guidance)

Cantors use Songs (Low Rites) with a Corruption Clock. Your main tasks:

- Track the Corruption Clock only when the player marks it (they manage it per 2.6).
- On a fill, impose the last Patron's benefit & burden (from Patron tables in the **Player's Guide**). Remember that the player then **sets their current Corruption segments to**

their Tier (minimum 1). This means high-Tier Cantors always carry a trace of past blooms – use that as a story hook.

- Spend SB to represent social fallout, Patron omens, or magical residue from their performances. For example, a Cantor who Pushes a song in a crowded tavern might generate a rumor clock or attract the attention of a witch-hunter.

Inspire Chorus

Once per scene, a Cantor can shift all allies' Position +1 for one exchange. If they use it again in the same scene, they mark toward Corruption accumulation (usually 1 segment). This is a non-stacking aura; only the best shift applies.

Chorus Cults (Optional)

If a Cantor performs a **Resonant Rite** (a Song performed with dramatic intent, witnessed by 10+ people, and dedicated to a specific Patron) they may found a **Chorus**. This grants a minor follower benefit (see 2.10.3), but they must mark Obligation to the Cult's Patron (the patron of the Resonant Rite sung) each session they use it.

Managing a Chorus Cult:

- Define the benefit concretely with the player. Good examples: +1 die to Performance once/session, a single rumour per session, or +1 Boon when singing in public.
- Track the cult's health with a **Schism Clock** [4]. Tick it when the player ignores the cult (no contact, refuses a request) or when the cult's demands go unmet. On a full clock, introduce a fracture: a rival sect, false rumours, or alliance with a Patron's enemy.
- Use the Obligation to the Patron as a debt. When it fills, the Patron may demand a service that involves the cult – such as a ritual performance, a pilgrimage, or silencing a troublesome follower.
- When the Cantor experiences a Corruption bloom, have the cult react. They may be inspired (temporary benefit upgrade) or terrified (temporary penalty). This makes the bloom matter to the faction, not just the character.

Corruption Blooms as Narrative Levers

A Corruption bloom is not a punishment – it is a **character metamorphosis**. Use the Patron's benefit and burden to create roleplaying moments:

- The burden (e.g., "cannot refuse a request for a song") should complicate the Cantor's life in interesting ways. Enforce it gently but consistently.
- Let the benefit be genuinely useful (e.g., +1 die to resist fear or a new thematic sense). This encourages players to embrace blooms rather than fear them.
- After a bloom, ask the player to describe a physical or behavioral change (feathers in hair, a second shadow, a musical tic). Record it on the character sheet. These changes accumulate, making high-Tier Cantors visibly strange.

Patron's Dedication (Cantor)

Prerequisite: Cantor's Path.

Cost: 4 XP.

Effect: You bind your voice to a single Patron (choose one when you take this talent). Your Corruption clock is always keyed to that Patron – it never resets to a different Patron's table when you bloom. Whenever you would gain Corruption from any source, you mark it on this same clock.

Downside (Rivalry): Singing a Song (Low or Standard Rite) of any other Patron is treacherous. When you do so, your Position for that song is worsened by one step (Dominant → Controlled, Controlled → Desperate). This penalty applies even if the song would otherwise be instant or free.

Note: This talent does not prevent you from learning or knowing Rites of other Patrons – it merely reflects the jealousy of your chosen Patron and the strain of divided loyalty.

Resonant Rites – Ruling Guidelines

A player may attempt a Resonant Rite to found a cult or simply as a powerful performance. Use these guidelines:

- The performance requires at least 10 witnesses who are actively paying attention (not just passing by).
- The player must describe the performance in at least moderate detail – what they sing, how they move, what Patron they invoke.
- On a successful Lore + Performance roll (DV 3, Position Controlled), the rite is resonant. On a failure, the crowd is unimpressed; the GM may impose a social complication (e.g., heckling, a rival performer).
- A Resonant Rite always advances the Corruption Clock (mark 1 segment). If the clock fills, the bloom occurs during the performance – describe the Patron's touch manifesting in front of the audience.

Song Weaver and Compatibility

When a player with Song Weaver wants to combine two Songs, you decide compatibility. Use these heuristics:

- **Thematically compatible:** both songs affect healing, both affect movement, both target spirits, etc.
- **Same Patron:** songs from the same Patron are always compatible (they share a thematic resonance).
- **Player justification:** If the player can give a compelling narrative reason why two songs work together, allow it.

When combined, the player makes a single Lore + Performance roll. If successful, both Song effects occur with +1 Effect (e.g., longer duration, larger area, or +1 die to a related roll). If the roll fails, neither Song takes effect, and the GM gains 1 SB (the discordant notes draw unwanted attention).

High Cantor and Instant Standard Rites

High Cantor is a powerful talent. Keep these points in mind:

- A Cantor with High Cantor can sing a Standard Rite (from any Patron they have learned) as an instant action. No delay. This does not require a Push unless they want an extra effect.
- They may still Push the instant Song for +1 Effect at the usual cost (1 Fatigue, mark Corruption). This means a High Cantor can, for example, cast Lay on Hands instantly and also Push it to heal an extra point of Fatigue.
- Because Standard Rites often cost Obligation for Runekeepers, the Cantor bypasses that cost entirely. This is intentional – their cost is Corruption and potential social fallout. Let them enjoy the power, but remind them that public displays of potent magic attract attention.

Steady Voice (Optional Talent)

The **Steady Voice** talent (2 XP, Player's Guide) allows a Cantor to Push a Song by marking 1 additional Fatigue instead of a Corruption segment (once per scene). This is a safety valve for low-Spirit Cantors. Use it to let a player avoid an untimely bloom, but then apply pressure through Fatigue management (e.g., they are now Fatigued 2 and must rest).

Final Advice

The Cantor's power is **flexibility and speed**. Their weakness is **Corruption accumulation and social visibility**. Lean into both:

- Give them opportunities to sing for crowds, but also introduce hecklers, rivals, or inquisitors who take notes.
- Let Corruption blooms change their relationships – old allies may become wary; new contacts may seek them out as oracles.
- Use Chorus Cults to tie the Cantor to a community that needs protection, guidance, or rescue. Cults are story engines, not just free bonuses.

> *"The Cantor's voice is a candle in the dark. It illuminates, but it also draws the eye of things that hunt by light. Let them sing. Let them bloom. Let their chorus become legend – or a warning."* >
— The Gray Wanderer, *The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire*

Rival Factions: A neglected Chorus can become a rival faction (see Section 9, *Advanced GM Techniques*). They may split into a competing sect, spread false rumors about the Cantor, or even ally with a Patron's enemy. Use this to generate long-term plot hooks.

5.7 Ritual Magic (GM Advice)

Rituals are powerful but slow. Use them for effects that are too big for a single roll.

Setting DV for Rituals

- **Low Ritual (DV 3–4):** 10–15 minutes, affects a room or small area.
- **Standard Ritual (DV 4–5):** 30 minutes, affects a building or a scene.
- **High Ritual (DV 5+):** Hours, affects a district or narrative turning point.

Using Helpers

Helpers can reduce DV by 1 each (max –2) or absorb 1 SB of backlash. They must have relevant skills (Arcana, Lore, etc.). Interrupting a helper may disrupt the ritual.

Pacing and Interruption

If a ritual is interrupted, treat as a Miss on the casting roll (see 2.2). You may also:

- Advance a doomsday clock.
- Summon an unexpected entity.
- Damage a needed component.

Components as Devotion (Even with a Symbol/Codex/Thiasos)

A common player question: "I already have a Patron's Symbol / Codex / Thiasos – why should I hunt for rare components?"

Answer: Because components are **offerings**. They show the Patron that you are willing to invest time, resources, and risk. Even when a Symbol or Codex technically allows a ritual without physical materials, **acquiring components voluntarily can reduce Obligation or earn the Patron's favor**.

Use this rule of thumb:

- **Ritual with no components (just Symbol/Codex):** Normal DV, normal Obligation cost.
- **Ritual with common components (herbs, salt, a candle):** Reduce Obligation by 1 (minimum 0).
- **Ritual with rare or dangerous components (a phoenix feather, a drop of troll blood, a whispered secret):** Reduce DV by 1 **and** clear 1 segment of existing Obligation to that Patron (once per session max).
- **Ritual with a truly legendary component (the crown of a dead king, a tear from a goddess):** The Patron may waive all Obligation for that ritual – and even grant a free Boon.

This gives players a meaningful choice: use the easy, costly path (Symbol/Codex) or invest legwork to earn the Patron's good will. It also turns component hunting into adventure hooks.

5.8 Psionics (Optional) – GM Sidebar

Adjudicating Psionics

Psionics is power without intermediaries – no Patrons, no symbols. As GM, ensure it feels precise yet costly.

Core Principles:

- Set DV by precision, not raw power. Clear intent = lower DV.
- **Generate SB frequently** – mental strain, sensory bleed, NPC suspicion. Psionics generates SB quickly; be prepared to spend them on interesting complications.
- Respect consent: unwilling minds always resist.
- On Partial, offer hard choices: surface thoughts only, emotional truth without context.
- Distinguish from spellcraft: psionics excels at direct influence, not environmental change.

Example Backlash: headache, nosebleed, fleeting vision, target becomes aware of intrusion, caster loses focus (Fatigue 1).

5.9 Quick Reference Tables (GM Only)

Spend SB for Magical Complications

SB	Effect
1	Minor flare, noise, caster off-balance (–1 die next action).
2	Backlash harms an ally (Fatigue 1), draws attention, Position –1.
3	Patron omen, magical feedback (Harm 1), new clock (e.g., “Leaking Energy”).
4+	Reality warp, Patron manifestation, scene shifts (fire, flood, etc.).

Elemental Backlash Quick Picks

Element	Minor (1–2 SB)	Major (3+ SB)
Fire	Smoke, sparks	Uncontrolled fire, explosion
Water	Slick floor, damp	Flooding, emotional storm
Earth	Dust, tremor	Collapse, binding
Air	Gust, ringing ears	Hurricane, deafness
Fate	Option closes	Prophecy becomes fixed
Luck	Small misfortune	A friend suffers the failure
Life	Overgrowth	Parasite, fever
Death	Chill whispers	A ghost manifests

Patron Intrusion Examples

Patron Type	Sample Intrusion
Everflame (Oath)	“Prove your purity – destroy that heretical text.”
The Traveler	“You must guide a lost soul to their destination.”
Inquisitor Prime	“Report any unsanctioned magic you witness.”
Malachai	“Curse someone weaker than you before dawn.”

Final GM Reminder

Magic is a narrative engine. Use Story Beats to create drama, not to punish. When in doubt, let the spell work and complicate the result. The world should react – but always in a way that keeps the story moving.

“Set the DV low. Spend SB to make the cost visible. Let the fiction lead.”

Chapter 6

Example Play and GM Survival Guide

This chapter provides two practical resources:

1. A complete, annotated example session of **Fate's Edge** (Tier I–II).
2. A short **GM Survival Guide** – quick, actionable advice for common table situations.

All other GM guidance (session zero, safety tools, scene framing, clocks, etc.) is covered in other chapters. This chapter focuses on **seeing the system in action** and **handling the unexpected** – while keeping you, the GM, as a fellow player at the table.

6.1 The GM as Player: A Quick Refresher

Before diving into the example, remember: you are not a referee or a narrator robot. You are a **co-creator of drama**, entitled to surprise, delight, and even a little mischief. Your tools (SB, clocks, Threat Pool) are not punishments – they are your way of playing the game. When you spend a Story Beat to tick a clock, you are making a move. When you describe a guard's suspicious glance, you are adding tension. Enjoy it.

6.2 Example Session: The Heist at Lord Silas's Manor

This walkthrough follows three characters as they attempt to steal a sealed charter from a rival merchant prince. It demonstrates how scenes are framed, how pressure escalates, and how success, failure, Boons, and Story Beats work together – all while the GM plays an active, engaged role.

The Table

- **Valerius** — Ecktorian ex-legionary (Body 3, Warfare 2)
- **Elara** — Vhasian agent and negotiator (Wits 3, Sway 2)
- **Kael** — Dwarven geomancer (Lore 3, Geomancy 2)

- **GM** – Prepared to be surprised, to spend SB creatively, and to enjoy the ride.

The GM has prepared no fixed plot — only factions, motives, and clocks.

Campaign Context

The group seeks a sealed charter proving their patron's claim to a trade route. The charter is held by **Lord Silas**, a rival merchant prince.

- Silas is politically insulated.
- His manor is guarded but discreet.
- Exposure is as dangerous as failure.

Scene 1: Information Gathering

GM frames: "You are in Silkstrand's lower markets at dusk. Silas's manor rises above you. Guards are visible, but relaxed." (The GM enjoys setting the atmospheric hook.)

Stakes: Success = identify an entry vector; Failure = guard suspicion escalates. **Clock introduced:** *Manor Alert* [4]

Action. Elara scouts using **Wits** + **Subterfuge**. Position: Controlled. She rolls 2 Successes vs DV 3 → **Partial Success**.

Resolution. GM rules:

- Elara identifies a servant gate (progress achieved).
- GM advances *Manor Alert* by 1 (cost).
- Elara gains **1 Boon**.

The fiction advances; pressure is visible. The GM is happy – a Partial is the most interesting outcome.

Scene 2: Entry

The group scales the outer wall at night. Position: Desperate. **Stakes:** Success = inside undetected; Failure = immediate pursuit.

Action. Valerius rolls **Body** + **Athletics**. He rolls 4 Successes including a 10 → **Clean Success with flourish**.

Resolution.

- The group enters cleanly.

- GM reduces future Position penalties inside.
- No Story Beat is spent.

Strong rolls relieve pressure without removing future danger. The GM celebrates the player's cool moment.

Scene 3: Complication Inside

Kael attunes to the stone to locate the vault. Position: Controlled. Kael rolls 0 Successes → **Miss**.

Resolution.

- Kael gains **2 Boons**.
- GM spends 1 SB to introduce a servant unexpectedly entering.
- GM advances *Manor Alert* by 1.

The failure creates momentum rather than stalling play. The GM smiles – now they get to describe the servant's wide eyes.

Scene 4: Social Pivot

Elara calms the servant. Position: Risky. New clock: *Servant Panic* [4]. She rolls a **Success with SB**.

Resolution.

- The servant is convinced.
- GM spends SB to advance *Servant Panic* by 2.
- The group now operates under time pressure.

The GM is now thinking: "Will they make it before the servant screams?"

Scene Cut

The GM cuts immediately: "You have the vault location. You also hear boots on marble." This prevents overplaying and preserves tension. The GM enjoys the players' anxious glances.

Scene 5: The Vault

The vault is magically reinforced. Clock: *Vault Integrity* [6]. Kael attempts a geomantic bypass. He rolls Partial (2 Successes vs DV 4).

Resolution. GM chooses proportional progress:

- *Vault Integrity* advances by 2.
- GM takes a Story Beat instead of increasing Alert.
- Kael gains 1 Boon.

Partials are *GM-shaped outcomes*. The GM feels creative.

Scene 6: Extraction

The vault opens as guards arrive. *Manor Alert* at 3/4. Valerius creates a distraction while Elara escapes with the charter. The final roll succeeds — but the GM fills *Manor Alert* as the cost.

Outcome.

- Charter secured.
- Silas knows he was robbed.
- New faction clock begins: *Silas's Retaliation* [6].

The GM is already planning the next session's opening scene.

Session Close

End-of-session review:

- Boons generated primarily from Partials and Misses.
- Story Beats spent to escalate, not negate success.
- New clocks seeded future conflict.

The session ends with a clear win, lasting consequences, and visible momentum. The GM is satisfied — they were surprised, they played, and the table had fun.

6.3 Example Session: The Rival's Gambit

This Tier I session introduces a **rival party** — the Ashen Cord — and demonstrates negotiation over combat, Boons spent on social actions, Patron intrusions, and failing forward.

The Table

Same party: Valerius, Elara, Kael (now Tier I, 30–40 XP). The GM introduces a rival group: **The Ashen Cord** — Vesper (leader, shadow mage, serves Ikasha), Tallow (berserker, serves Malachai), Ember (cantor, serves Palinode), Cinder (scout, no Patron).

Campaign Context

Both parties seek the same lost relic: a **Stone of Echoes** hidden in a ruined watchtower on the Acasian border. The relic is said to whisper secrets to those who attune to it.

Scene 1: The Approach

GM frames: "The watchtower rises from the fog. You see another group approaching from the east – four figures, one carrying a wolf-standard. They've seen you."

Position: Controlled. No clock yet – this is a social opening.

Action. Elara steps forward to negotiate. "We don't need to shed blood over this." She spends **1 Boon** to improve her Position to Dominant before the roll.

Roll: Presence + Sway (5 dice) vs DV 3. She rolls 3 Successes – Clean Success.

Resolution. GM: "Vesper, the leader, agrees to parley. She offers a deal: "Whoever reaches the relic chamber first decides its fate. No backstabbing – word of honour."" The rival party's *Cord's Agenda* [6] clock is created but not advanced. The GM enjoys the tension of a fragile truce.

Scene 2: The Climb

Both parties race up the tower's crumbling stairs. The GM introduces a hazard: a collapsed section requiring an Athletics roll.

Action. Valerius helps Kael across. Kael rolls Body + Athletics (4 dice) – Miss. Gains 2 Boons.

Resolution. GM spends 1 SB: "Kael slips, but Valerius catches him. Kael's pack tears open – a healing potion shatters. Mark 1 Supply segment lost." The GM spends another 1 SB: "The noise alerts the Ashen Cord above – they gain a head start." Advance *Cord's Agenda* by 1.

Failing forward: progress (they both cross) but costs and rival advantage.

Scene 3: The Relic Chamber

Both parties arrive at the same time. The relic sits on a stone plinth. Vesper turns to the PCs: "Or we could settle this by rite – not blades. Each of us offers a secret. The one whose secret the stone accepts claims it."

Social encounter. The GM sets a *Convince the Cord* [4] clock. Each successful social roll (Sway, Lore, or ritual) ticks the clock.

Action. Elara tries to persuade Vesper to share first (Wits + Sway, DV 3). Partial (1 success vs DV 3). Gains 1 Boon. GM advances *Cord's Agenda* by 1 as Vesper's patience thins.

Action. Kael uses a geomantic reading (Spirit + Lore, DV 3). Clean Success. The GM ticks *Convince the Cord* by 2. Kael's Patron (The Sealed Gate) sends a small omen: a stone glows briefly.

Scene 4: Patron Intrusion

Tallow (Malachai's berserker) loses patience. He attacks the PCs – but Vesper shouts, "No!" The GM spends 2 SB: "Tallow's axe swings wide, but Malachai's mark on his hand flares. He stumbles back, cursing."

Patron intrusion: Malachai whispers to Tallow: "*Break your word, and I'll take your strength.*" Tallow is forced to abide by the truce.

Player response. Elara spends 1 Boon to invoke her Bond with Kael ("We survived the heist together") and gains +1 die on her next roll. She seals the deal: "We'll share the stone's first whisper – both parties benefit."

Roll: Presence + Sway (now +1 die = 6 dice) vs DV 3 – Clean Success. The *Convince the Cord* clock fills.

Scene 5: Resolution

Vesper agrees. Both parties touch the stone together. It whispers a location – a hidden vault beneath Silkstrand – and crumbles to dust.

Outcome.

- No combat. Boons spent on social actions, not blades.
- The Ashen Cord is not defeated but becomes a recurring rival (their *Cord's Agenda* is at 2/6).
- A new clock: *Silkstrand Vault Race* [6] – both parties will race to the vault next session.

The GM ends the session on a cliffhanger: "As you leave, you see Cinder (the Cord's scout) slip away in the opposite direction – perhaps to beat you to the vault."

Session Close Takeaways

- Negotiation over combat saved resources and created a more interesting relationship.
- Boons spent on social actions were as impactful as combat re-rolls.
- Patron intrusions (Malachai) created tension without a fight.
- The rival party's clock provides long-term pressure.

6.4 High-Tier Play in Brief (Tier IV–V)

At Tier IV–V, the core mechanics remain the same, but the context shifts. Here are the key differences, illustrated by a brief scenario.

What Changes

- **Larger dice pools** → more automatic successes, fewer Misses.
- **Fewer Boons earned** → Boons become precious, strategic currency.
- **Failure has wider consequences** – a missed roll can shift faction clocks or expose an asset.
- **Bonds and Assets** become the primary sources of Boons.

Example: House Morrenn Conflict

A Tier IV party leads a regional faction against House Morrenn. Campaign clocks: *Morrenn Ascendancy* [6] and *Faction Stability* [6].

Scene: Council Confrontation. Elara spends her only Boon on a Tier IV talent, succeeds, but the GM spends a Story Beat to mark her as a personal enemy – creating a new clock *Targeted Retaliation* [4].

Scene: Asset Pressure. Assassins strike the safehouse. No Boons remain, so Valerius accepts Harm and a worse Position to protect NPCs. *Faction Stability* advances by 1 – people saw leadership under fire.

Scene: Risky Ritual. Kael attempts a geomantic collapse to delay troops. He rolls a Miss, gains 2 Boons, but *Morrenn Ascendancy* advances and long-term fallout (destabilised ley fault) appears.

Result. The party ends with 1–2 Boons, strained assets, and multiple clocks near resolution. No DV inflation was needed – the stakes and resource scarcity did the work.

Key Takeaway

At high tier, power comes from reach, not safety. Boons are for decisive moments, not routine re-rolls. Failure is often chosen to regain leverage.

6.5 GM Survival Guide

This section offers quick, actionable advice for the most common GM challenges. It assumes you have read the core rules and other chapters – this is the "cheat sheet" for the table.

When Players Go Off the Rails

- Do not panic. Ask: "What is your goal?" (not "How do you do that?").
- Name the simplest obstacle in their way – then set Position and DV.
- If they ignore the obvious, let the world react. A missed roll means the guard they bypassed earlier shows up.
- Use **leading questions** to steer: "Are you trying to sneak past or create a distraction?" instead of "What do you do?"
- **GM as player:** Enjoy their creativity. Your job is to say "yes, but" and "no, but" – not to block them.

When Players Hoard Boons

- Remind them of the **Session 0 contract**: "Boons are not XP tokens – they are dramatic fuel. Spend them to shape the story."
- Introduce **time pressure** that forces spending. "The ritual completes in three exchanges. You have 2 Boons – do you re-roll that failed defense or save them?"
- Use the environment: a collapsing bridge, a spreading fire, a closing gate. "You can improve your Position to Dominant for 1 Boon – or risk a fall."
- Offer a **Devil's Bargain**: "Spend 1 Boon now to automatically succeed, but the rival will get a head start."
- **GM as player:** Don't punish hoarding – make spending tempting and visible.

How to Make Patrons Feel Present Without Overwhelming

- Use **omens** before direct demands. A flickering candle, a dropped cup, a sudden chill.
- Send **dreams** or visions during rest. "You dream of a bell that tolls eight times – and then silence."
- Have Patrons act through **small favors** that cost the players little but build relationship. "The Traveler clears the fog – but you feel a faint tug on your heel, a reminder that roads remember footsteps."
- Escalate slowly: first a whisper, then a request, then a demand, then a reckoning.
- **GM as player:** Patrons are your co-stars. Give them personality – a lisp, a favourite phrase, a sense of humour.

Handling Rival Parties

- Keep rivals active **off-screen**. Tick their Agenda clock when the PCs dally or fail.
- Use **rumours** and **found scenes** to show their progress. A burned camp, a dead informant, a signature left behind.

- Bring them back when players least expect it – during a tense negotiation, at the climax of a heist, or as unexpected allies against a greater threat.
- Give rivals their own **Patrons** and **resources**. They should evolve just like PCs.
- **GM as player:** Rivals are your recurring NPC party. Enjoy running them – they are your chance to play, too.

When a Scene Stalls

- Ask a leading question: "Who are you trying to impress?" or "What are you afraid of here?"
- Tick a clock. "While you argue, the fire spreads – *Collapse* [4] advances 1."
- Cut to another player. Shift spotlight.
- **GM as player:** A stalled scene is your signal to introduce a new element. Have fun with it.

When You Don't Know a Rule

- Make a ruling that keeps the story moving. Say: "We'll do it this way for now; look it up later."
- Default to DV 3, Controlled Position, and a consequence that feels right.
- Trust your gut. The system is robust.
- **GM as player:** Uncertainty is part of the game. Embrace it – the dice will surprise you.

How to Say "No" (Without Firing the Player)

- "No, but..." – offer a harder path, a cost, or a requirement.
- "Yes, but..." – let them succeed, then add a complication.
- "Let's find out" – call for a roll with high DV and Desperate Position. The dice decide.
- **GM as player:** Saying "no" is boring. Saying "no, but" is a gift to the story.

Using Clocks Effectively

- Name clocks clearly: *Alarm Raised* [4], not "Bad Stuff [6]".
- Only keep 1–3 clocks active per scene. More than that is noise.
- Tick a clock on a Miss or a Partial – even if the player otherwise succeeds.
- **GM as player:** Clocks are your visible toys. Tick them with relish.

Managing Player Spotlight

- Rotate by environment: scholar in the library, fighter on the wall.
- Use Bonds to pass focus: "You owe Rina – what do you do to protect her?"
- Quick check-in: "While that happens, what is your character doing?"
- **GM as player:** Giving everyone a moment means you get to see different parts of the story.

When You Feel Burnt Out

- Call a break. Even five minutes resets the table.
- Ask players to recap – they will remind you of forgotten details.
- End the session early if needed. No game is better than a bad game.
- Use a published adventure or a random generator for one week. Give yourself a rest.
- **GM as player:** Your fun matters. If you are not enjoying it, talk to your group.

Final Survival Mantra

Set the DV low. Make the world react honestly. Let the pressure do the work. And remember – you are playing too.

— The Fate's Edge GM Mantra

If the table feels engaged, tense, and safe – you are running the game correctly. If you are also having fun, you are running it brilliantly.

6.6 Session Zero Checklist (Handout)

Use this checklist during your Session Zero. Write down the answers where everyone can see them.

Session Zero Checklist

1. **Lines & Veils** – What content is off-limits (Lines) or only implied (Veils)?
2. **Tone** – Cinematic action? Grim survival? Political intrigue? Dark horror? Mix of several?
3. **Campaign length** – One-shot, short arc (3–6 sessions), or long campaign (12+ sessions)?
4. **Character hooks** – Each player shares one goal and one fear for their character.
5. **Patron interest** – Which Patrons (if any) are already watching the party?
6. **Starting situation** – Where does the story begin? (Use the Crown Spread or a simple opener.)

7. **House rules** – Any optional subsystems (Threat Pool, Deck of Consequences, etc.) you plan to use?
8. **Scheduling & attendance** – How often do you meet? What happens if a player misses a session?
9. **Player-GM contract** – Remind the table: "We are co-creators, not adversaries."
10. **Resource mindset** – "Boons are not XP tokens. Spend them. Embrace failure."

6.7 Session Walkthrough – From the GM’s Perspective

This walkthrough follows a single session of a Tier II game set in Silkstrand. The party consists of three characters: Kael (a Guardian), Lyra (a Free Caster), and Riley (a Psion). The campaign’s **Crown Spread** is already in play: Mira Venn (Rival), the Rust (Pressure), the Tithing Bridge (Site), the Weeping Oracle (Leverage), and the Drowned Man (Wild).

6.7.1 Before the Session (Prep)

- Review clocks: *Mira’s Consolidation* [6] (3/6), *The Rust Spreads* [8] (2/8), *Oracle’s Safety* [6] (1/6), *Drowned Man’s Attention* [4] (0/4).
- Note last session’s cliffhanger: “You’ve tracked a stolen dye shipment to a warehouse on the canal. The water is bubbling. A Scarlets patrol is approaching.”
- Prepare one opening line and two possible complications (spend 1–2 SB immediately if needed).

6.7.2 Opening Hook (5 minutes)

“The warehouse door is ajar. Inside, you see crates marked with Mira’s seal – a red spider. The canal behind you bubbles louder. The patrol will be here in moments. What do you do?”

GM note: No roll yet. Frame the pressure visibly. Players declare intent.

6.7.3 Scene 1 – Infiltrating the Warehouse (15 minutes)

Player (Kael): “I sneak to the side window and peer inside. How many guards?”

GM: “Roll Wits + Stealth, Controlled, DV 3 to get a clear view without being seen.”

Kael rolls: 1 success (needs 3) → Miss. Gains 2 Boons. GM gains 2 SB.

GM (spends 1 SB immediately): “You see two guards – but as you lean, a loose board creaks. One guard looks toward the window. Tick the *Patrol Alert* clock [4] by 1. You have one beat to hide or act.”

GM (banks 1 SB for later): “Riley, you sense a cold thought – something in the canal is watching the warehouse. It feels patient.”

GM note: Use the Miss to introduce tension, not failure. The player gained Boons; the scene escalates.

6.7.4 Scene 2 – Confrontation with the Scarlets (20 minutes)

Lyra decides to create a distraction. “I cast a small [WIND] [STRIKE] to knock over a stack of crates behind the guards.”

GM: “Controlled, DV 3. Roll Wits + Arcana.”

Lyra rolls: 3 successes (DV 3) but rolls a 1 → Success with SB. GM gains 1 SB (now banked 2).

GM: “The crates crash. Both guards spin around. Kael, you’re now in Dominant Position to slip inside. Lyra, the magical wind also stirs the canal water – the Drowned Man’s Attention clock ticks to 1/4. You see a pale hand grip the dock.”

GM (spends 1 SB): “One guard shouts, ‘It’s the witch! Get her!’ – he draws a crossbow. What do you do?”

6.7.5 Scene 3 – The Drowned Man Enters (10 minutes)

Riley: “I try to calm the Drowned Man with a telepathic image of still water. I want him to attack the Scarlets, not us.”

GM: “Desperate Position (he’s a wild spirit), DV 4. Roll Spirit + Psionics. Mark 1 Mental Fatigue.”

Riley rolls: 2 successes (Partial) → gains 1 Boon. GM gains 1 SB (now banked 3).

GM: “The Drowned Man hesitates – his rage focuses on the guards. He climbs onto the dock and roars. The guards flee. However, your mental image leaves a residue. You now see the Drowned Man’s last memory: a woman in a red coat pushing him into the canal. Her face is Mira’s. You have 1 Mental Fatigue left.”

GM note: Partial success gives information and progress but costs resources. The SB is banked for the climax.

6.7.6 Scene 4 – The Oracle’s Chamber (25 minutes)

The party finds the Weeping Oracle in a flooded basement. She speaks in riddles. The player must offer a memory to gain her knowledge.

Kael: “I offer the memory of the day my father disowned me.”

GM: “No roll. She drinks the memory and whispers: ‘The Rust is not a curse. It is Mira’s dye – she poisons the water to make her red cloth unique. To stop it, you must burn her workshop on the Tithing Bridge. But the bridge is where she drowned her rival. He will not let you pass without a price.’”

GM note: No dice here – this is a narrative reward for reaching the leverage. But now a new

obstacle is introduced (the Drowned Man on the bridge).

6.7.7 Scene 5 – The Tithing Bridge Climax (30 minutes)

The party arrives at the bridge. The Drowned Man waits. The patrol has regrouped behind them. Two clocks are visible: *Drowned Man’s Attention* (now 1/4) and *Patrol Arrives* [6] (3/6).

GM: “You’re caught between. To burn the workshop, someone must cross the bridge and face the Drowned Man. Others must hold off the patrol. Who does what?”

The players split. Kael holds the bridge approach, Lyra and Riley cross.

Riley: “I use my last Mental Fatigue to telepathically show the Drowned Man that Mira is the woman in the red coat. I want him to let us pass.”

GM: “Desperate, DV 5 (convincing a spirit). Roll Spirit + Psionics.”

Riley rolls: 4 successes (Clean Success, no 1s). He spends 1 Boon to improve Position? No – already Clean.

GM: “The Drowned Man steps aside. ‘Go. Burn her work. Then I will rest.’ Mark 1 XP for a pivotal success.”

Meanwhile, Kael fights the patrol. He uses his remaining Boons to re-roll a failed defense and succeeds with a Partial. The GM spends the banked 3 SB to describe: “You drive them back, but a crossbow bolt grazes your arm – mark Harm 1. The patrol retreats, but one wounded guard screams that Mira will hear of this. Tick *Mira’s Consolidation* to 4/6.”

6.7.8 Closing the Session (5 minutes)

The party torches the workshop. The Drowned Man sinks into the canal, nodding. The Rust’s clock stops advancing (players can reduce it next session). The Oracle’s Safety clock remains at 1/6 – she is safe for now.

GM: “As the fire lights the night sky, you see a silhouette on a distant rooftop – a woman in a red coat. Mira has seen you. She turns and vanishes. End of session.”

GM after-session notes:

- Award XP: 6 base + 2 major objective + 1 discovery (the Drowned Man’s memory) + 1 hard choice (Kael’s memory) = 10 XP each.
- Update clocks: *Mira’s Consolidation* 4/6, *Rust Spreads* still 2/8, *Oracle’s Safety* 1/6, *Drowned Man’s Attention* reset to 0 (he is at peace – remove the clock).
- Note new hook: Mira saw them. Next session, she will send assassins.

6.7.9 Key Takeaways for GMs

1. **Spend SB early and often.** The guard’s creaking board and the Drowned Man’s appearance turned a Miss into a memorable complication.

2. **Clocks are promises.** Players saw the Patrol Alert clock tick and felt pressure without you saying “you have three rounds.”
3. **Let the fiction reward without dice.** The Oracle’s memory exchange had no roll – it was a narrative payoff for reaching the leverage.
4. **Partial successes keep momentum.** Riley’s Partial gave him the vision of Mira’s face, not just a “you fail to convince.”
5. **End on a cliffhanger.** Mira’s silhouette sets up the next session immediately.

This walkthrough uses the exact tools described in this guide: Position, DV, Boons, SB, Clocks, Crown Spread, and player-managed resources. The session took about 90 minutes of active play. Every roll changed the fiction, and the GM had as much fun as the players.

6.8 Faction Turn Cheat Sheet

Between sessions (or at the start of a session), you can run a quick ****faction turn**** to keep the world alive. A faction turn takes 5–10 minutes and answers: ****“What have the major powers done while the party was busy?”****

6.8.1 When to Run a Faction Turn

- At the end of a session, after players declare their next destination.
- At the beginning of a session, as a “news from the world” recap.
- During a long downtime (several weeks or months).

6.8.2 Procedure – 5 Minutes

1. **List active factions.** Keep no more than 3–5 that directly interact with the party.
2. **For each faction, roll 1d6.** Use the table below to determine their progress.
3. **Advance or retreat their Agenda Clock.** Each faction has a visible clock (6–10 segments) representing their goal.
4. **Note one concrete change.** Write one sentence per faction (e.g., “The Scarlets seized the river docks.”).
5. **Read the changes aloud** at the start of the next session.

Faction Progress Roll (d6)

Roll	Progress	Agenda Clock Change
1–2	Setback	–1 segment (min 0)
3–4	Stalled	No change
5–6	Advance	+1 segment

6.8.3 Optional: Faction Conflict Roll

If two factions are directly opposed (e.g., the Scarlets and the Grey Circle), roll opposed d6. Higher roll wins; lower roll loses 1 segment. Ties mean a stalemate – both lose 1 segment.

6.8.4 Example Faction Turn

Factions:

- Mira’s Scarlets – Agenda Clock: *Control the Dye Trade* [8] (currently 3/8)
- Church of the Everflame – Agenda Clock: *Suppress Heresy* [6] (currently 2/6)
- The Drowned Man (not a faction, but a wildcard) – no clock

Rolls:

- Scarlets: 5 → Advance → now 4/8.
- Everflame: 2 → Setback → now 1/6.

One-sentence changes:

- *Scarlets:* “Mira’s agents have bought the loyalty of the harbour master.”
- *Everflame:* “An inquisitor was found murdered; the Church retreats to its cathedral.”
- *Drowned Man:* (GM fiat) “The Drowned Man dragged two Scarlets into the canal. Rumours spread.”

Next session opener: “You wake to news that the harbour master has doubled tariffs – and that a body was pulled from the water wearing a Scarlets’ token.”

6.8.5 Using Faction Clocks in Play

- **When a clock fills**, the faction achieves its goal. The party must react (or suffer the consequences).
- Players can **affect faction clocks** during adventures: a successful sabotage mission might tick a clock backwards; a public failure might tick it forward.
- Keep faction clocks **visible** (on an index card or whiteboard). Players should see the pressure building.

6.8.6 Lightweight Faction Standing (Optional)

For factions that are not pursuing a single agenda but merely have an attitude toward the party, track a simple **-3 to +3 scale**:

- **-3:** Enemy – actively works against the party.
- **0:** Neutral – indifferent.
- **+3:** Ally – will sacrifice for the party.

Shift standing by ± 1 after major interactions (saving a faction's leader, betraying them, etc.). No dice needed – just fiction.

6.8.7 GM Quick Cues

- **Don't overdo it.** One faction turn per 1–2 sessions is plenty.
- **Tie changes to player actions.** If the party ignored a threat, tick that faction's clock for free.
- **Use the turn to generate rumours.** “The Grey Circle is digging a new well – some say they found bones.”

Chapter 7

Campaigns, Clocks, and Consequences

In **Fate's Edge**, campaigns are not a sequence of disconnected adventures—they are **pressure systems**. Every choice the players make pushes on something: a faction, a threat, a relationship, a belief. Over time, those pressures accumulate, shift, and eventually *break*.

Your job as GM is not to hide this pressure—it is to **shape it, reveal it, and let the players decide where it lands**.

This chapter presents the core tools for doing that work: **Clocks, Fronts, the Crown Spread**, and long-term campaign structures. Used well, they create momentum without railroading and stakes without arbitrary escalation.

Session Zero Worksheet (GM)

Before the Session

Use this worksheet to capture the table's decisions. Keep it visible for the campaign.

1. Safety & Tone

Lines (hard no): _____
Veils (fade to black): _____
Tone (circle): Cinematic / Folk Horror / Political / Grim Survival / Swash-buckling

2. Crown Spread (draw 5 cards)

Spade (Site): _____
Heart (Rival): _____
Club (Pressure): _____
Diamond (Leverage): _____
Wild (Hidden): _____

Interpret suits by regional flavour. Write one sentence per card.

3. Campaign Clocks (visible)

Mandate [6] (party's public legitimacy):
Crisis [6] (opposition's growing strength):
Rival's Agenda [6]: _____ (name of rival party or faction)

4. Character Hooks (one per player)

Player: _____
 Character goal: _____
 Character fear / debt: _____
 Which Crown element are they tied to? _____

5. Patron Interest (if any)

Patron(s) watching the party:
 Obligation style: _____ Passive (long campaign) / Active (short arc)

6. First Scene Framing

Write an in media res opening line that ties to the Crown Spread:

“ _____ ”

7. House Rules & Optional Systems

Deck of Consequences?	Y / N
Threat Pool?	Y / N
Popcorn initiative?	Y / N
Psionics allowed?	Y / N
Other:	

7.1 Crown Spread Cheat Sheet

The Crown Spread is a five-card (or six-card) oracular tool for seeding a campaign’s major elements. Use it during Session Zero or at the start of a new arc. It creates a web of relationships, not a railroad.

7.1.1 What You Need

- A standard 52-card deck (jokers optional).
- A table or whiteboard to record the spread.
- 15–20 minutes of quiet thinking.

7.1.2 The Spread Positions

Draw one card for each position. Lay them in a semicircle (the “Crown”).

Position	Card Drawn	What It Represents
Spade	(e.g., 5)	The Crown Site – where destiny is decided.
Heart	(e.g., Q)	The Crown Rival – who stands between the party and their goals.
Club	(e.g., 9)	The Crown Pressure – the relentless force that prevents complacency.
Diamond	(e.g., A)	The Crown Leverage – the advantage that can turn the tide.
Wild (draw a 6th card)	(e.g., K)	The Hidden Force – the unexpected element.

7.1.3 Interpreting the Cards

Use the suit to determine the nature of the element, then interpret the rank to refine it.

Quick Interpretation Guide

Spade (Site)

- A place: ruin, bridge, forest, tower, cave, city district, crossroads.

Heart (Rival)

- A person with emotional ties: family, former ally, rival, spurned lover, grieving widow.

Club (Pressure)

- A resource or systemic threat: famine, plague, debt, war tax, blight, curse.

Diamond (Leverage)

- An object or secret: a lost letter, a relic, a true name, a hidden passage, a witness.

Wild (Hidden)

- Anything: a monster, a traitor, a natural disaster, a forgotten god, a second faction.

Rank guidance:

- **Ace – 3:** Minor scale, personal stakes.
- **4 – 6:** Moderate scale, affects a community.
- **7 – 10:** Major scale, threatens a region.
- **Jack – King:** Face cards suggest a named individual with personality and agenda.

7.1.4 Worked Example (Silkstrand Campaign)

Draws:

- Spade: 5 → Tithing Bridge (a small, working-class bridge in the dye district).
- Heart: J → Mira Venn, the Guildmistress's daughter, who once threw a rival off that bridge.
- Club: 9 → The Rust – a magical blight poisoning the dye vats.
- Diamond: A → The Weeping Oracle, an ancient witness who knows the truth about the new red dye.
- Wild: K → The Drowned Man, a cursed dyer who haunts the canals.

7.1.5 Connecting the Elements

After the draw, ask yourself:

1. How does the Rival relate to the Site? (Mira's first kill was on the Tithing Bridge.)
2. How does the Pressure affect the Site or Rival? (The Rust is poisoning the canal below the bridge; Mira needs the Rust to continue to control the dye market.)
3. How can the Leverage help against the Pressure or Rival? (The Oracle knows the Rust's source and the true cost of Mira's dye.)
4. What does the Hidden Force want, and how does it complicate the others? (The Drowned Man kills polluters – he is a wildcard enemy and potential ally.)

Draw a simple relationship map. You now have a campaign skeleton.

7.1.6 Clocks for the Crown Spread

Create one visible clock for each element that will take time to resolve. Use these defaults:

Element	Sample Clock
Rival's Agenda	<i>Mira's Consolidation</i> [6]
Pressure	<i>The Rust Spreads</i> [8]
Leverage (if it can be lost)	<i>The Oracle's Safety</i> [6]
Hidden Force (if it escalates)	<i>The Drowned Man's Attention</i> [4]

Tick these clocks during play when players fail relevant rolls or ignore the element. When a clock fills, that element’s situation worsens dramatically.

7.1.7 Seasonal Evolution (Optional)

For longer campaigns, evolve the Crown Spread through seasons:

Winter (Establishment)

- Introduce elements as rumours or distant threats.

Spring (Growth)

- Elements become active; the Rival makes a move.

Summer (Climax)

- Confrontation at the Crown Site.

Autumn (Harvest)

- Consequences manifest; the party’s choices become legacy.

7.1.8 GM Quick Cues

- **Don’t over-plan.** The spread is a seed, not a script. Let players discover connections through play.
- **Be flexible.** If a better idea emerges, replace an element – the cards are oracles, not chains.
- **Use the Wild card for surprise.** Even you don’t have to know what it is until it appears.
- **Tie every character to at least one element.** During Session Zero, ask each player: “How do you know about the Rival?” or “Why does the Pressure affect you personally?”

7.1.9 Crown Spread at a Glance – Ritual Card

For a quick reference, print the following card and keep it behind your GM screen:

Crown Spread – One-Card Ritual

1. Name your campaign theme.
2. Shuffle, draw 5 cards (6 for Wild).
3. Layout: Spade (Site) | Heart (Rival) | Club (Pressure) | Diamond (Leverage) | (Wild)
4. Interpret suit: Place, Person, Scarcity, Secret, Twist.
5. Connect: How does each relate to the others?
6. Create 4 clocks (4-8 segments).
7. Play to find out.

7.2 A Framework, Not a Prescription

Before you build your campaign, internalise this truth: **You own the game. The game does not own you.**

Fate's Edge provides a library of tools – clocks, fronts, travel procedures, faction turns, the Crown Spread, and many more. You are not expected to use all of them. In fact, you are encouraged to use only what your table needs *right now*.

The 10% Rule (from the Appendix)

As the Gray Wanderer says: *"A single page, well-used, is worth more than a library of unopened tomes. Pick one thing from one expansion. Use it tonight."*

The same applies to this chapter. Start with:

- **Clocks** – always useful.
- **The Crown Spread** – for session zero.
- **One front** – to give the world a pulse.

Ignore faction turns, legacy bonds, and travel sub-systems until they become relevant. Add them when you feel ready, not because the book says they exist.

Discard what doesn't serve your table. Your campaign will not collapse if you never use the "Clock Relationships" section. It will not break if you skip the faction turn. The rules are here to serve you – not the other way around.

For the full philosophy, see Appendix ?? (*Using Expansions: A Guide for the Overwhelmed GM*).

7.3 Clocks: Visible Pressure, Meaningful Choice

Clocks are the primary way Fate's Edge tracks narrative pressure over time. They are not secret timers or surprise punishments—they are **shared context** that tells the table what is at risk and what is coming.

A clock answers one of three questions:

- **What is building?**
- **What happens if it completes?**
- **Who can affect it?**

If a clock does not clearly answer at least one of these, it is probably unnecessary.

GM Mindset: Story Beats Are Your Friend

Harder is not better. A higher DV or a worse Position does not guarantee a more interesting scene – it just makes failure more likely. And a clean Miss? Often a letdown.

What you actually want: *Success with SB*. That's the sweet spot. The players achieve their goal, and you get Story Beats to spend on complications. The story moves forward *and*

gains texture.

Compare:

- *Partial* (player gains 1 Boon, no SB for you): progress, but the situation drags. The table waits.
- *Success with SB* (player succeeds, you get SB): the door opens – and a guard turns the corner. Instant momentum.

Misses are no fun. They give the player 2 Boons, but they stall the fiction. Use them sparingly. When a Miss happens, spend those SB immediately to *escalate*, not to punish. Turn a "you fail" into "you fail, but now the fire spreads – what do you do?"

Your job is not to make the game hard – it's to make the game *alive*. Let the players succeed. Then give them the bill.

7.3.1 The Three-Clock Guideline (Per Scene)

As a rule of thumb, a scene rarely needs more than **three active clocks**:

- **1 Immediate Clock** — What is about to go wrong *right now* (e.g., *Alarm Raised* [4], *Ritual Collapse* [6])
- **1 Situational Clock** — The pressure shaping player decisions (e.g., *Crowd Turns Hostile* [4], *Structural Failure* [6])
- **1 Long-Term Clock** — How this scene echoes forward (e.g., *Faction Retaliation* [8], *Corruption Advances* [6])

More clocks do not create more tension—they create **noise**. If players cannot name the clocks they are pushing against, they cannot make meaningful choices.

Concrete Example: The Heist at Lord Silas's Manor

Immediate Clock: *Guards Alerted* [4] – ticks each time the party makes noise or leaves evidence.

Situational Clock: *Patrol Pattern* [6] – ticks when the party delays; when full, a patrol arrives.

Long-Term Clock: *Silas's Retaliation* [8] – ticks each time the party is identified; when full, Silas hires bounty hunters.

The players see all three clocks. They decide to rush the vault (risking *Patrol Pattern*) rather than pick every lock carefully (which would tick *Guards Alerted*). Their choice is informed and tense.

7.3.2 The "Why This Clock?" Test

Before adding a clock to a scene, run it through these four questions:

1. **What is the concrete, observable threat?** (e.g., "Guards are searching the building," not "Something bad might happen.")

2. **What happens when it fills – in one sentence?** (e.g., "The alarm bell rings and the building is sealed.")
3. **Can the players see it tick?** If not, why not? (Hidden clocks are almost never worth it – see 7.3.3.)
4. **Does this clock create a choice?** If it only ticks inevitably, it's a timer, not a pressure system. Give players ways to slow, stop, or redirect it.

If you cannot answer all four, reconsider the clock.

7.3.3 Why Hidden Clocks Rarely Pay Off

Hidden clocks often feel clever—but in practice, they weaken play.

- Players cannot meaningfully react to pressure they cannot see.
- Surprise escalation feels arbitrary rather than earned.
- The GM ends up carrying tension alone instead of sharing it.

If a clock matters, **show it**. If it must remain unknown, foreshadow it through visible effects, rumors, or consequences—then reveal it as soon as the players can interact with it.

Exception: Short-lived hidden clocks (e.g., *Ambush Trigger [2]*) can work well; long-term hidden clocks almost never do.

7.3.4 Clocks Are Promises

Every clock you place on the table is a promise:

- When it fills, *something will happen*.
- That outcome will be *consistent with what the players saw coming*.
- The players had *opportunities to change the outcome*.

Clocks do not exist to punish failure—they exist to **make consequences legible**. When players choose to ignore a clock, that choice should feel informed, intentional, and costly.

More Segments = More Rolls = More Story Beats

Lots of small clocks are better than one long challenge.

A single 8-segment clock that ticks once per scene creates *one* moment of tension. But splitting that threat into two 4-segment clocks (e.g., *Patrol Closes [4]* and *Ritual Nears Completion [4]*) gives players *two* levers to pull – and twice as many opportunities for the dice to generate Story Beats.

Why this works: Each clock tick comes from a roll. More clocks mean more rolls. More rolls mean more 1s. More 1s mean more SB for you to spend. And SB are how you make the story *alive*.

Design rule of thumb: Prefer 3–4 clocks of 4–6 segments over 1–2 clocks of 8–10 segments.

Your players will thank you, and your SB pool will never run dry.

7.3.5 Mandate and Crisis (Campaign Clocks)

Two campaign-level clocks track the party's influence and the world's resistance:

Mandate (0–6) represents the party's public legitimacy and reputation. High Mandate means doors open; low Mandate means suspicion and obstacles.

Crisis (0–6) tracks the opposition's rising pressure. High Crisis means enemies strike boldly and clocks tick faster.

Advance these clocks at the end of major scenes based on:

- Clean loss or public cost paid → increase Crisis.
- Major victory or public recognition → increase Mandate.
- Asset neglect or scandal → affect both.

7.3.6 Clock Relationships and Fronts

Clocks rarely exist in isolation. They form **fronts** – clusters of related clocks, NPCs, and threats that represent a faction's long-term agenda.

What is a Front?

A **front** is a named pressure system with:

- An **Agenda Clock** (8–10 segments) – what the front ultimately wants.
- 2–3 **supporting clocks** (4–6 segments each) – milestones along the way.
- **Key NPCs** and **stakes** (what happens if the front succeeds).

Example Front: *The Cult of Eternal Night*

- Agenda: *Ritual Completion* [8] – when filled, the sun dims permanently.
- Supporting: *Cult Influence* [6] (spreads in the city), *Hunter's Tracking* [4] (PCs are pursued).
- Stakes: A world of eternal twilight; crops fail, undead rise.

Clocks within a front can relate in three ways:

Supporting

One clock's progress helps another (*Plague Spread* → *Resource Scarcity*).

Opposing

One clock's progress hinders another (*Public Support* ↓ *Crime Rate* ↑).

Cascade

One clock's resolution triggers another (*War Ends* → *Reconstruction Begins*).

7.3.7 Clock Evolution

Campaign clocks should evolve as player actions change the world. Common progression:

1. **Introduction** (0–2 segments): Threat becomes known.
2. **Escalation** (3–4 segments): Threat gains momentum.
3. **Crisis** (5–6 segments): Immediate danger to players/campaign.
4. **Resolution** (7+ segments): Confrontation or transformation.

7.4 Factions and Rivals

A faction is any organised group with goals that intersect the party's. A rival party is a special kind of faction – a small group of NPC adventurers who mirror the PCs.

7.4.1 Faction Sheet (Quick Template)

Faction Template

Name:
Agenda Clock: [] (what they want to achieve)
Key NPCs: (2–3 names and roles)
Resources: (what they can bring to bear)
Ticking conditions: (when does their clock advance?)
Visible tracks: (list clocks players can see)

7.4.2 Rival Parties

A rival party is a faction of 3–5 NPCs with their own Patrons, assets, and a visible **Rival Agenda clock** (6–8 segments). Tick their clock when the PCs ignore them or the GM spends SB on their off-screen activities. When the clock fills, the rivals achieve a major milestone. Reveal their progress through rumours, discovered scenes, or direct confrontation.

For a full template and example (The Ashen Cord), see the GM's Appendix ??.

7.5 Faction Turn Cheat Sheet

Between sessions (or at the start of a session), you can run a quick ****faction turn**** to keep the world alive. A faction turn takes 5–10 minutes and answers: ****“What have the major powers done while the party was busy?”****

7.5.1 When to Run a Faction Turn

- At the end of a session, after players declare their next destination.
- At the beginning of a session, as a “news from the world” recap.
- During a long downtime (several weeks or months).

7.5.2 Procedure – 5 Minutes

1. **List active factions.** Keep no more than 3–5 that directly interact with the party.
2. **For each faction, roll 1d6.** Use the table below to determine their progress.
3. **Advance or retreat their Agenda Clock.** Each faction has a visible clock (6–10 segments) representing their goal.
4. **Note one concrete change.** Write one sentence per faction (e.g., “The Scarlets seized the river docks.”).
5. **Read the changes aloud** at the start of the next session.

Faction Progress Roll (d6)

Roll	Progress	Agenda Clock Change
1–2	Setback	–1 segment (min 0)
3–4	Stalled	No change
5–6	Advance	+1 segment

7.5.3 Optional: Faction Conflict Roll

If two factions are directly opposed (e.g., the Scarlets and the Grey Circle), roll opposed d6. Higher roll wins; lower roll loses 1 segment. Ties mean a stalemate – both lose 1 segment.

7.5.4 Example Faction Turn

Factions:

- Mira’s Scarlets – Agenda Clock: *Control the Dye Trade* [8] (currently 3/8)
- Church of the Everflame – Agenda Clock: *Suppress Heresy* [6] (currently 2/6)
- The Drowned Man (not a faction, but a wildcard) – no clock

Rolls:

- Scarlets: 5 → Advance → now 4/8.
- Everflame: 2 → Setback → now 1/6.

One-sentence changes:

- ***Scarlets:*** “Mira’s agents have bought the loyalty of the harbour master.”
- ***Everflame:*** “An inquisitor was found murdered; the Church retreats to its cathedral.”
- ***Drowned Man:*** (GM fiat) “The Drowned Man dragged two Scarlets into the canal. Rumours spread.”

Next session opener: “You wake to news that the harbour master has doubled tariffs – and that a body was pulled from the water wearing a Scarlets’ token.”

7.5.5 Using Faction Clocks in Play

- **When a clock fills**, the faction achieves its goal. The party must react (or suffer the consequences).
- Players can **affect faction clocks** during adventures: a successful sabotage mission might tick a clock backwards; a public failure might tick it forward.
- Keep faction clocks **visible** (on an index card or whiteboard). Players should see the pressure building.

7.5.6 Lightweight Faction Standing (Optional)

For factions that are not pursuing a single agenda but merely have an attitude toward the party, track a simple **-3 to +3 scale**:

- **-3:** Enemy – actively works against the party.
- **0:** Neutral – indifferent.
- **+3:** Ally – will sacrifice for the party.

Shift standing by ± 1 after major interactions (saving a faction’s leader, betraying them, etc.). No dice needed – just fiction.

7.5.7 GM Quick Cues

- **Don’t overdo it.** One faction turn per 1–2 sessions is plenty.
- **Tie changes to player actions.** If the party ignored a threat, tick that faction’s clock for free.
- **Use the turn to generate rumours.** “The Grey Circle is digging a new well – some say they found bones.”

7.6 The Crown Spread: Seeding Your Campaign

At **Session Zero**, draw the **Crown Spread**—a five-card ritual that seeds the campaign’s deepest themes, most dangerous rivals, and the very conditions of its ultimate resolution. This is not random chance but **oracular guidance** for the story to come.

7.6.1 Drawing the Spread

Draw one card for each of the five fundamental aspects of your campaign:

- **Spade** – The **Crown Site**: where destiny will be decided.
- **Heart** – The **Crown Rival**: who stands between the party and their goals.
- **Club** – The **Crown Pressure**: the relentless force that prevents complacency.
- **Diamond** – The **Crown Leverage**: the advantage that can turn the tide.
- **Wild** (draw a sixth card, or use the highest remaining card) – The **Hidden Force**: the unexpected element that will emerge when least expected.

7.6.2 Interpreting the Spread

Crown Spread Interpretation Guide

Position	Examples and Questions
Spade (Site)	A ruined watchtower? A shrine built on forgotten truths? A battlefield where history repeats?
Heart (Rival)	A grieving widow with allies? A cult leader with apocalyptic visions? A spirit with ancient grievances?
Club (Pressure)	A spreading famine? An escalating curfew? A resource shortage that turns allies into competitors?
Diamond (Leverage)	A hidden letter exposing a noble's treason? A seasonal endorsement from powerful factions?
Wild (Hidden)	A sympathetic deserter who knows secret passages? A Patron who steps from shadows? The site itself becomes a 10-clock challenge?

Worked Example: The Bell at Blackwood Tower

A GM draws:

- **7 Spades** → A ruined watchtower on a contested border, with a single bell that rings without wind.
- **Q Hearts** → A grieving widow who blames the party for her husband's death.
- **9 Clubs** → A spreading famine; supplies dwindle, the militia conscripts farmers.
- **A Diamonds** → A hidden cache of pre-Empire artifacts, including a sealed letter that exposes a noble's treason.
- **K Spades (Wild)** → A deserter turned bandit who knows the watchtower's secret passages and wants the artifacts for himself.

The GM now has: a location, a rival, a pressure, a secret advantage, and a wildcard. That is enough to run a 2–3 session adventure without further prep.

7.6.3 Seasonal Evolution of the Spread

The Crown Spread elements should evolve through seasonal phases:

Winter (Establishment)

Root themes take hold, initial conflicts emerge. The watchtower is a rumour; the widow is a grieving quest-giver.

Spring (Growth)

New elements sprout, alliances form. The watchtower becomes a bandit stronghold. The widow allies with the deserter.

Summer (Climax)

Peak conflicts, major revelations. The watchtower's bell awakens a spirit. The widow's grief transforms into vengeance.

Autumn (Harvest)

Consequences manifest, legacies established. The artifacts inside become the key to a regional peace – or war.

As the campaign progresses, deepen each element: add layers, introduce variations, connect to other Crown aspects, and evolve the stakes.

7.6.4 Expanding Drawn Elements

When a Crown card's theme becomes central to your campaign:

1. **Deepen the Concept:** Add layers to the initial interpretation.
2. **Introduce Variations:** Create related but distinct elements.
3. **Connect to Other Elements:** Tie it to other Crown aspects.
4. **Evolve the Stakes:** Raise the personal and cosmic implications.

7.7 Running Travel as a Medieval Trek (Abridged)

Travel in Fate's Edge is not a line on a map. It is a **medieval journey** – uncertain, weather-beaten, dependent on local guides, hospitality, and the kindness (or cruelty) of strangers. For full procedures (weather tables, road condition dice, regional decks), see the *Travel Guide* and *Player's Guide* Chapter 10. This section gives you the GM principles.

7.7.1 Lead with Weather, Not Distance

Open each leg with a weather description, then set Position based on that weather (e.g., Desperate for navigation in fog, Controlled for stealth in rain). The weather *is* the terrain.

7.7.2 Maps Are Lies; Guides Are Truth

Require a **Guide** role for each leg (PC or hired NPC). The Guide's roll (Wits + Survival or Lore) determines if they find the safe route, the short route, or the one that leads to a cultist ambush.

7.7.3 Hospitality as a Resource

When the party seeks shelter, draw a **Heart** from the regional deck – that's the host. Their attitude affects what they offer. Spending a **String** (e.g., "I helped this village last year") can improve the outcome.

7.7.4 Road Conditions Change Daily

At the start of each leg, choose or roll a Road Condition (see the *Travel Guide* for the full d6 table). Apply its effect for the entire leg.

7.7.5 The Travel Clock as Mood Tracker

Do not just tick the clock on successes. Use it to track the *feeling* of the journey (Optimism → Fatigue → Desperation → The Edge). When the clock fills, describe the arrival – mud-caked and grateful.

7.7.6 Genre Shifts Through Borders

When the party crosses from one region to another, the dominant fantasy subgenre shifts. Use the travel deck to introduce the new region's flavour immediately (e.g., from Ecktoria's political intrigue to the Mistlands' folk horror: the road grows silent, fog rolls in, a bell tolls without wind).

7.7.7 Travelling Without a Map

Fate's Edge does not use hex crawls. Travel is abstracted into **legs**, each with a Travel Clock (4, 6, 8, or 10 segments). You need only know how many **meaningful scenes** stand between two locations – not the miles.

7.8 Pacing and Arc Structure

A well-paced campaign follows a natural rhythm. Use these guidelines for session and arc structure.

7.8.1 Session Energy Management

Aim for three "beats" per session:

1. **Opening hook** (5–10 minutes): Re-establish stakes, remind of clocks.

2. **Rising action** (60–90 minutes): 2–3 scenes with escalating tension.
3. **Climax or cliffhanger** (20–30 minutes): A major roll, a clock filling, or a hard choice.

7.8.2 Arc Length by Tier

- **Tier I–II (0–90 XP)**: 3–5 session arcs. Local scope, personal stakes.
- **Tier III (91–150 XP)**: 6–10 session arcs. Regional influence, branching paths.
- **Tiers IV–V (151+ XP)**: 15+ session arcs. Continental scope, world-shaping consequences.

7.8.3 Between Sessions: The GM’s Sacred Trust

Between sessions, update clocks, track complication debt, and prepare scenes. Use the *Between-Session Checklist* in the GM’s Appendix. Remember: your preparation is the quiet magic that transforms random encounters into meaningful episodes.

7.9 Calling or Forcing the Crown

The campaign reaches its crescendo when one of two thresholds is met—the moment when accumulated influence and mounting pressure collide in a final reckoning.

Finale Triggers and Conditions

Finale Type	Conditions and Narrative Implications
Player-Called	Mandate ≥ 6 and Crisis ≤ 3 – the party has earned the right to choose their moment of triumph.
Forced Finale	Crisis ≥ 6 regardless of Mandate – the world forces a confrontation that can no longer be avoided.
Balanced Finale	Both dials at 4–5 – a tense equilibrium where victory and defeat hang in perfect balance.

7.9.1 The Finale Procedure

When the Crown is called, run the three-beat finale:

1. **Reckoning**: Defend or sanctify the record of accomplishments. Draw upon the Rival’s established motives. Place the Pressure rail that will drive the scene forward.
2. **Crossing**: Stage the kinetic rail (Escape/Hunt/Hazard) that threatens to end the scene prematurely if not managed carefully.
3. **Coronation**: Use the Diamond Leverage to sign, seal, or swear the oath that cements the campaign’s legacy.

7.9.2 Twist Collision (Finale Clause)

Exactly once, when the Rival's Spade Twist contradicts their Club Belief, the table chooses:

- GM gains +1 SB to complicate matters, or
- Players reduce two ticks total across the active rails, gaining breathing room.

Twist Collision Example

The Rival's Spade Twist: "The bell tower collapses, killing the rival's lieutenant." *The Rival's Club Belief:* "No more bloodshed – I will end this peacefully." **Contradiction:** The rival now has no reason to hold back. **Table chooses:**

- GM gains +1 SB (the rival blames the PCs for the death), or
- Players reduce two ticks on the Collapse clock (they pull the rival from the rubble, saving a life).

7.10 Legacy Conversion: Epilogue

After the Finale, each PC draws 2 cards and answers epilogue prompts by suit. Then convert campaign elements into lasting legacy:

- **Major Asset** → **Institution** (12 XP): A safehouse becomes a school, a spy ring becomes an intelligence service.
- **Seasonal Endorsement** → **Doctrine Rider** (4 XP): Temporary support becomes permanent policy.
- **Follower (Cap 3+)** → **Stationed NPC** (0 XP): Loyal companions become custodians of the new order.
- **Rival** → **Fixture**: Surviving adversaries become recurring elements of the setting's fabric.

7.10.1 The Legacy Bond

When a PC retires or dies, their successor (a follower or a new character) inherits a **Legacy Bond**. This bond represents the predecessor's enduring influence. Once per session, the player may invoke the Legacy Bond to gain **1 Boon** when acting to uphold the predecessor's values or complete their unfinished business.

Sample Legacy Bonds:

- "I carry Kael's sword. I will not let it rust in peace."
- "Grandmother's garden still grows. I protect it as she did."
- "The oath we swore – I will see it fulfilled."

7.10.2 Character Arc Management

Help players develop meaningful character growth through the legacy process:

1. **Establishment:** Define the character's current state and potential conflicts.
2. **Development:** Create opportunities for growth and choice.
3. **Crisis:** Present challenges that test the character's core beliefs.
4. **Resolution:** Allow meaningful transformation based on choices.

Arcs Generate Obligation and Patron Interest

A character's personal arc should not exist in a vacuum. Tie it directly to the game's resource systems:

- **Internal arcs** (fear, doubt, guilt) are perfect sources of *Corruption* or *Obligation*. A character struggling with guilt might be tempted by Malachai. A character seeking redemption might attract the attention of the Gallow's Bell.
- **External arcs** (revenge, ambition, love) create *Debt Clocks* with terrestrial patrons or generate *Crisis* when they interfere with faction plans.
- **Whenever a player advances their arc, mark +1 Obligation to a relevant Patron or tick a Patron's Interest clock.** The arc becomes a source of complications, not just backstory.

Example: Sven wants to avenge his murdered brother. The GM notes that his brother was killed by a cult of Malachai. Each time Sven pursues a clue or confronts a cultist, the GM ticks *Malachai's Interest* [6]. When the clock fills, Malachai appears in a dream and offers Sven the power to find the killer – for a price.

7.11 Quick Start Campaigns

7.11.1 The Sunstone Gambit (Tier I–II, 4–6 sessions)

A medium-difficulty introduction to Fate's Edge set in Acasia. **Premise:** A scholar hires the party to retrieve a sunstone from a ruined tower before a rival adventuring company does. **Key NPCs:** Scholar Mira (quest-giver), Captain Voss (rival leader), the Tower's Guardian (ancient spirit). **Clocks:** *Rival Progress* [6], *Tower Collapse* [8], *Spirit Wakening* [4]. **Session breakdown:** Commission → Travel (mountain leg) → Exploration (tower rooms) → Confrontation (rival team) → Climax (the Guardian) → Aftermath.

7.11.2 The Dying Sun (Tier III–IV, 6–8 sessions)

A regional crisis campaign. The sun-spirit is fading; a cult of eternal night seeks to extinguish it permanently. **Premise:** The party must rally factions, recover a lost ritual, and confront the cult before the winter solstice. **Key NPCs:** High Priestess of the Sun, Cult Shadow-bound, Reluctant

Ykrul Chieftain. **Clocks:** *Sun's Fading* [10] (ticks each session), *Cult Influence* [6], *Alliance of the Dawn* [8]. **Acts:** Investigate the cult → Gather allies → Raid the cult's lair → Final confrontation.

7.11.3 Tier-Appropriate Design

- **Tier I–II (0–90 XP):** Local scope, personal stakes, 3–5 session arcs.
- **Tier III (91–150 XP):** Regional influence, branching arcs, 6–10 sessions.
- **Tiers IV–V (151+ XP):** Continental scope, world-shaping consequences, multi-arc campaigns (15+ sessions).

For deeper guidance on high-tier campaigns, see Chapter 8 (*Tier IV and V: Running Epic Adventures*).

7.12 Campaign Worksheet

Use this one-page worksheet to capture your campaign's key elements.

Campaign Worksheet	
Campaign Name: _____	
Starting Tier: _____	Estimated Sessions: _____
Crown Spread:	
Spade (Site):	Factions (name, agenda clock, key NPCs):
Heart (Rival):	
Club (Pressure):	
Diamond (Leverage):	
Wild (Hidden):	
Fronts (name, agenda clock, supporting clocks, stakes):	
Mandate: 0/6 Crisis: 0/6	
Notes: _____	

7.13 Narrative First: The World Remembers

Campaign design in Fate's Edge is not about railroading players along predetermined paths—it's about **responding to player choices** with consequences that accumulate like stones in a river, gradually shaping the flow of the narrative itself. Let the world shift in response to their actions. Let factions rise and fall based on their allegiances. Let the dice sing the song of a universe that reacts.

And when the Crown is finally crowned—when the last card is played and the final clock ticks to completion—let the echo of that moment be heard across the entire Amaranthine, a testament to

stories well-lived and consequences fully earned.

Remember: Your preparation between sessions is the quiet magic that transforms random encounters into meaningful episodes and mechanical challenges into memorable stories. The investment in this sacred trust pays dividends in player engagement, narrative coherence, and the creation of campaigns that will be remembered long after the final dice have been rolled.

Chapter 8

Tier IV and V: Running Epic Adventures

As characters reach Tier IV and V, the game changes. The scope expands from local concerns to regional, national, or world-shaking events. This chapter focuses on how to run these epic tiers effectively, with special attention to how the game **naturally scales** through Boon scarcity – not inflated Difficulty Values.

8.1 What Changes at Tier IV–V

- **Scope:** Actions affect cities, nations, or the entire known world.
- **Consequences:** Failure can shift political borders, end bloodlines, or awaken ancient horrors.
- **Time:** Campaigns often span months or years, with downtime becoming a major phase.
- **Legacy:** Characters become legends – their deeds echo for generations.

The core mechanics remain the same. The difference is **weight** – every success and every failure reshapes the fiction in larger, more permanent ways.

8.2 Natural Scaling: The Boon Economy Does the Work

One of Fate’s Edge’s most elegant features is how it automatically scales difficulty without inflating numbers. At high tiers, characters have large dice pools (often 8–10 dice). They succeed more often and generate fewer Misses and Partial – the primary sources of Boons.

Boon Generation Basics (Reminder)

- **Miss (0 successes):** Gain 2 Boons.
- **Partial ($0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$):** Gain 1 Boon.
- **Clean Success ($\text{successes} \geq \text{DV}$, $\text{SB} = 0$):** No Boons.
- **Success with SB ($\text{successes} \geq \text{DV}$, $\text{SB} > 0$):** No Boons.

Boons do not come from winning. They come from *struggling*.

Boon Availability by Tier (Typical)

Tier	Avg. Boons earned per scene	Typical use
I (0–40 XP)	2–3	Re-rolls, minor advantages
II (41–90 XP)	1–2	Re-rolls, asset activation
III (91–150 XP)	1	Critical rerolls, story shifts
IV (151–220 XP)	0–1	Rare, decisive actions
V (221+ XP)	0–1 (often 0)	Mythic choices only

Why This Works

- **Low-tier characters need the help.** Their small pools produce unreliable results; Boons give them a cushion.
- **High-tier characters must rely on skill, not luck.** With huge pools and reliable success, they no longer have a safety net.
- **The scarcity creates strategic depth.** At high levels, spending a Boon on a re-roll means you cannot activate your spy network later. Every Boon is a meaningful choice.

Why Brittleness is Good

At high tiers, your power comes from skill, not luck. Fewer Boons mean every roll matters. This is intentional – embrace the tension.

The simulation insights show that ****chaos players thrived at high tier**** because they understood this. They did not hoard Boons; they accepted scarcity and adapted by:

- Relying on high Skills and clever positioning.
- Using Bonds to generate Boons when needed.
- Spending Boons only on critical moments.

A "brittle" character – one with few resources but immense competence – is not a flaw. It is the design. It makes every decision weighty and every success earned.

Let the dice fall. Let the Boons be precious. Let the tension sing.

Do Not Increase Boon Awards

Resist the urge to give out extra Boons because players "look cool" or "rolled a 10." The scarcity is intentional. It makes high-tier play feel tense and consequential. If you inject Boons, you remove the resource pressure that defines epic play.

Example: Tier I vs. Tier V

A Tier I rogue picks a lock (DV 3, 5 dice). She rolls a Miss → gains 2 Boons, re-rolls, succeeds. A Tier V master thief picks the same lock (DV 3, 10 dice). He rolls a Clean Success → no Boons. Later, he fails a critical roll to disable a ward – he has only 1 Boon left. He must decide: re-roll this roll, or save it for the escape. The tension is real.

8.3 Do Not Inflate Difficulty Values**Warning: DV Inflation Breaks High-Tier Play**

A higher DV does not mean "more challenging" – it means "fewer Partials, fewer Boons, faster escalation." At high tiers, players have large pools, but raising DV to 5 or 6 will starve them of Boons entirely and make failure feel arbitrary.

Scale Challenge With These Tools Instead:

- **Clocks:** Add a 4–6 segment clock to the scene (*Palace Coup* [4], *Ritual Completion* [6]). Players see it tick.
- **Position:** Worsen Position when the fiction demands danger. A Desperate roll already re-rolls successes – that is plenty.
- **Consequences:** Use SB to add layered costs (see 2.4).
- **Faction Clocks:** Advance long-term threats (*War* [8]) regardless of player success in individual scenes (see 2.9).

When Is a Higher DV Appropriate?

Only when the *fiction* itself demands it: a god's impossible ward, a lock designed by a legendary artisan, a ritual that twists reality. Even then, keep it to DV 5–6 and telegraph clearly: "This is a mythic challenge. Even with your power, it may fail."

8.4 Failure Must Matter

At high tiers, a failed roll should never mean "nothing happens." Instead:

- **A rival gains leverage.** "You cannot open the vault, but you see the Duke's sigil on the lock – he knows someone inside."
- **A secret becomes public.** "Your investigation fails, but the guard captain mentions your name to a reporter."
- **A faction clock advances.** "The ritual continues. *Summoning* [8] ticks +1."
- **An asset is compromised.** "Your safehouse is discovered – it is now *Neglected*."

If failure merely delays action without changing the situation, you are not using the system to its full potential.

8.5 Using Bonds as the Primary Boon Engine

At high tiers, Boons should mainly come from **Bond-driven actions** (see 3.3.1). Encourage players to:

- Call on Bonds in difficult moments: "I owe you – I ask for your help now."
- Expose allies or followers to danger to gain Boons.
- Accept new obligations or narrative fallout in exchange for Boons.

Example: Bonded Allies Transferring Boons

The party faces a mythic guardian. Sariel, the rogue, has 0 Boons left. Kestra, the mage, has 2 Boons but is pinned at range. They share a Bond ("She saved me from the shadow cult").

Kestra: "I spend my action to transfer 2 Boons to Sariel. As I channel, I shout: "Remember the Forge – you owe me!" GM: "The Bond flares. Sariel receives 2 Boons. Spend them wisely."

Sariel uses 1 Boon to re-roll a failed stealth check and 1 Boon to improve her Position to Dominant. She slips past the guardian and disables the trap.

This turns a Bond from backstory into a tactical resource. At high tiers, such exchanges are the difference between victory and defeat.

8.6 Designing High-Tier Scenes

When planning an epic scene, ask:

1. **What changes if the characters succeed?**
2. **What compromises emerge on a Partial success?**
3. **What new dangers arise on a Miss?**

If the answer to "Miss" is "they try again," increase the stakes, not the DV.

Example Scene: The Royal Vote

The party tries to convince the council to declare war on a neighboring realm.

- **Clean Success:** The vote passes; the army marches under their banner.

- **Success with SB:** The vote passes, but a rival is appointed general.
- **Partial:** The vote is delayed; new clock *Council Deadlock [4]* appears.
- **Miss:** The vote fails. The rival declares war anyway – without the party’s leadership.

No DV was inflated. The stakes did the work.

8.7 Pacing and Scope

Embrace Longer Timelines

Time becomes a tool. Use downtime to:

- Advance faction clocks.
- Allow rumors to spread.
- Let players build legacies (fortresses, guilds, schools).

Abstract the Mundane

At high tiers, do not roll for climbing walls or picking common locks. Assume competence. Save rolls for choices that matter.

Let Players Command Armies

Treat armies as high-Cap followers (see 2.10.3). Use **Battle Clocks** (4–6 segments) for skirmishes. Do not resolve each soldier’s attack – abstract with leadership rolls.

8.8 Caveats and Warnings

- **Do not design adventures like Tier I.** Linear dungeons and small-scale fetch quests feel beneath legendary heroes. Instead, give them systemic problems: a curse that erases memory, a political schism, a dying god.
- **Do not hoard Boons.** Spend SB and optional Threat Pool points (see ??) to create memorable moments. Players earned their power – challenge them with creative complications, not starvation.
- **Do not fall into "superhero" mode.** The world should still react believably. A legendary warrior can be assassinated in their sleep. A master mage can be outmaneuvered politically.

8.9 Optional Epic Tools (Brief)

The following are covered in other chapters or appendixes:

- **Boss Generator** – See Appendix F (in the full GM’s Guide) for a card-based tool to create mythic adversaries.
- **Legacy Projects** – See Chapter 3 for long-term clocks that span sessions.
- **Mythic Martial Tags** – Player-facing epic talents for warriors; see Chapter 6 of the *Player’s Guide*.
- **Mass Combat** – See optional rules in Appendix G for battle clocks and army followers.

The Mythic Failure Table (d12)

When a high-tier character fails a pivotal roll, describe a consequence from this table (or invent your own).

d12	Consequence
1	An innocent dies because of your failure.
2	A rival claims the victory instead of you.
3	An artifact shatters, releasing a curse or a new threat.
4	Your reputation is damaged – lose 1 Mandate (if using, see 3.6.1).
5	An ally is captured or turned against you.
6	The problem spreads – a new clock appears (<i>Crisis [4]</i>).
7	A Patron withdraws favor – lose access to one Rite until you atone.
8	A faction declares you an enemy – start a <i>Vendetta [6]</i> clock.
9	The land itself is wounded – a region becomes blighted or uninhabitable.
10	You lose a memory or a cherished belonging (GM chooses).
11	A prophecy twists – your success now serves a dark purpose you cannot yet see.
12	Your failure opens a door – something ancient and hungry awakens.

8.10 Sample High-Tier Scenario: The Dying Sun

Premise: The realm’s patron sun-spirit is fading. Without it, crops fail, undead rise, and the land dies.

Scope: Continental.

Clocks:

- *Sun’s Fading [10]* – ticks each session, faster if neglected.
- *Cult of Eternal Night [6]* – a faction that worships the darkness.
- *Alliance of the Dawn [8]* – political support for a ritual to save the sun.

Success: The party finds a lost relic, performs a ritual, and restores the sun – but must choose a cost (e.g., their own lifespans, a Patron’s demand).

Partial: The sun is saved, but the cult is not destroyed – they will return.

Miss: The sun dies. The party must lead a desperate exodus or accept a dark bargain for a new light.

This scenario cannot be solved by a single roll. It requires investigation, diplomacy, combat, and

sacrifice – perfect for epic tier play.

8.11 Final Thought

At Tier IV and V, your players are no longer adventurers – they are **legends in the making**. Honor their power by giving them problems that require wisdom, sacrifice, and creativity to solve.

The dice still matter. Consequences still flow. But now, every choice echoes across nations and generations.

Make it legendary.

Chapter 9

Advanced GM Techniques

This chapter assumes you have mastered Fate's Edge core rules. It offers tools for GMs running **experienced groups and higher-tier campaigns (Tier III+)**. If you are new to the game, start with earlier chapters.

9.1 Advanced Story Beat Management

Story Beats (SB) are your primary tool for escalating tension. At high tiers, you will have more SB to spend – but also more narrative threads to manage.

You Are Not Limited by SB

SB are a pacing tool, not a budget. If the story needs a complication, introduce it. SB just tells you when players *want* escalation (by rolling 1s) and gives you a reservoir to draw from. Do not hoard SB; spend them freely to keep scenes dynamic.

Example: The party is interrogating a prisoner. Even without a roll, you sense the scene dragging. Spend 1 SB: "The prisoner's eyes dart to the window – a signal. Someone is listening." No roll, no budget – just pacing.

Spending SB Across Multiple Threads

Instead of pouring all SB into one complication, distribute them across several active clocks or fronts (see 2.9). A scene might have:

- *Alarm Raised [4]* – advances from noise or failed stealth.
- *Rival Closing In [6]* – advances from delays or loud magic.
- *Patron Attention [8]* – advances each time a Rite is invoked.

Each Miss or Partial can tick one or two small clocks instead of a single big setback. This keeps pressure distributed and gives players multiple problems to solve.

Using SB to Advance Campaign Fronts

When a scene directly relates to a long-term front (e.g., a war, a spreading curse), spend SB to advance that front's clock – even if the scene is otherwise a "success". Example: The party defeats a cultist cell (clean success), but you spend 2 SB to tick *Cult Influence* [6] – their network still grows elsewhere.

Banked SB from Player Complications

Characters may start sessions with banked SB from unresolved complications (see 2.6). These count toward scene spending limits but should be spent on **thematic complications tied to that character's background or Patron**, not generic setbacks. This makes personal storylines matter.

Example: Cascade Spend

A single Miss generates 2 SB. The GM:

1. Spends 1 SB to advance *Alarm Raised* [4] by 1 (now 2/4 – guards are converging).
2. Spends 1 SB to advance *Rival Closing In* [6] by 1 (now 3/6 – rival scouts are spotted).
3. Both clocks are now half full – the scene's tension doubles without a single "big" complication.

9.2 Mastering the Deck of Consequences

The deck is not just a randomizer; it is a **thematic engine**. Use it to keep complications fresh and unpredictable, even at high tiers.

Shortcut Table: Suit + Rank → Typical Complication

Use this table for fast interpretation at the table.

Suit	Low (2–5)	High (J–A)
Hearts (Emotion/Social)	Awkward social moment, minor suspicion	Betrayal, scandal, broken trust
Spades (Physical/Harm)	Bruise, small gear damage, stumble	Serious injury, structural collapse
Clubs (Resource/Cost)	Minor loss (rations, a few coins)	Major asset destroyed, debt called
Diamonds (Magic/Spiritual)	Omen, eerie noise, minor curse	Patron demand, reality bend

Combining Draws (Suit Synthesis)

Draw up to 3 cards per SB spend (minimum 1, maximum 3). Synthesise a single twist from the combination of suits, not just the highest rank.

- **Hearts + Spades:** Emotional betrayal that leads to physical harm ("Your ally flees, and the portcullis drops on you.")
- **Clubs + Diamonds:** Resource drain with magical backlash ("The ritual consumes your healing herbs and leaves a tainted scar.")
- **Hearts + Clubs + Spades:** Social pressure plus resource loss plus injury – a crowd riots and loots your gear.

Using the Deck for Non-Linear Scenes

Draw a card to inspire flashbacks, montages, or off-screen events. Example: During downtime, draw a Clubs card – "A fire at your safehouse." Instead of playing it, you narrate a short scene of the party arriving to find the aftermath. The deck becomes a prompt generator, not merely a roll-aftermath tool.

Custom Suit Tables

For a specific campaign or region, replace the default suit meanings with custom ones. Example – Shadow Court campaign:

- **Hearts:** Vows and obligations.
- **Spades:** Physical traps and barriers.
- **Clubs:** Political pressure and blackmail.
- **Diamonds:** Oaths and geasa.

This re-flavours the deck without changing its structure.

9.3 Adjudicating Thresholds

Thresholds – doorways, crossroads, riverbanks, the space between waking and sleeping – are where the world's memory is thinnest. When a player announces "I cross the threshold," you need a consistent way to respond.

Common Threshold Types and Their Effects

Use this table as a reference. The effects are narrative nudges, not rigid rules.

Threshold	Typical Effect	SB Spend Opportunity
Doorway (unwarded)	Position worsens one step (attention from spirits)	1 SB: door leads to wrong room
Doorway (warded)	Resolve test (DV 3) or mark Fatigue	2 SB: ward triggers (Harm 1)
Crossroads	GM asks a "choice" question; answer becomes true	3 SB: a stranger appears with a bargain
Riverbank	Roll Spirit + Survival; success gives omen	2 SB: spirit from the water surfaces
Bridge	The bridge "remembers" – ask a past event	3 SB: bridge's toll is a memory
Sleep/waking edge	Player narrates a dream; GM gains 1 SB	4 SB: dream becomes real for a scene

Threshold Clocks

For a location that is heavily liminal (a haunted manor, a fey crossing), start a **Threshold Instability [4–6]** clock. Tick it each time a player crosses a threshold without proper respect (no offering, no announced name). When the clock fills, the threshold inverts: doors open to the wrong places, the dead walk, or the party is lost in a mirror realm.

Player-Driven Thresholds

When a player says "I act at the threshold," encourage them to be specific: "I open the door with my left hand" or "I step over the river stone." Use that fiction to set Position. A respectful crossing (removing boots, pouring a libation) may start Controlled; a brash crossing starts Desperate.

9.4 Faction Grand Strategy

At high tiers, factions act as "campaign engines." Build them with **faction clocks** that advance whether the players intervene or not.

Faction Clock Examples

- **War [8]** – Advances when battles occur or supply lines are cut.
- **Influence [6]** – Advances when allies are won or propaganda spreads.
- **Intrigue [8]** – Advances when secrets are uncovered or betrayals happen.

These clocks are **visible to players** – they see the war brewing, even if they cannot stop it alone.

Player Actions and Faction Clocks

When players act, they can tick a faction clock forward or backward. Example: Sabotaging a siege engine ticks *War* -1 (enemy's clock) and ticks *Their Own Mandate* $+1$ (see 3.6.1). Document these changes openly. The world becomes a reactive board.

Running a "Faction Turn" Between Sessions

For a highly political campaign, between sessions you can:

- Ask players for their faction's orders (e.g., "Send spies to the capital").
- Roll a single die per order (Pass/Fail/Partial) using the faction's relevant Asset (e.g., Spy Ring).
- Advance faction clocks accordingly.
- Start the next session with a brief "news from the front" segment.

This makes factions feel alive without heavy bookkeeping.

Example: Faction Turn with Rivals

The rival party **The Ashen Cord** has their own faction clock: *Cord's Agenda* [6]. During the faction turn:

- The GM rolls for the Cord's order: "Secure the Sunstone fragment."
- The roll is a Partial. The Cord finds the fragment but leaves evidence (tracks, a witness).
- The GM ticks *Cord's Agenda* by 1 and notes: "A merchant in Silkstrand saw a scarred woman matching Vesper's description."
- At the next session, the players hear the rumour. They now have a choice: pursue the Cord or stay on their own path.

9.5 Advanced Clock Design

Clocks become more powerful when they interact. Use the following patterns to create tension that players must actively manage.

Interacting Clocks

Two clocks that affect each other. Example: *Ritual Progress* [6] and *Cult Interference* [4]. Ticking one may automatically tick the other, or players can choose which to slow.

Cascading Clocks

When one clock fills, it creates another. Example: *Security Alert* [4] fills → *Reinforcements Arrive* [6] appears. This models escalating threats without requiring the GM to track everything from the start.

Hidden Consequences Behind Success

Even a clean success can tick a long-term clock. Example: The party assassinates a cult leader (clean success). Off-screen, *Cult of the Martyr* [8] ticks +2 – the death radicalises the remaining followers.

9.6 Designing High-Tier Custom Content

At Tiers IV–V, characters can reshape nations and realities. Custom content should grant **narrative permissions**, not merely bigger numbers.

Epic Talents (12+ XP)

An epic talent might:

- Allow rewriting one line of a Patron's Rite (changing its cost or effect).
- Grant a once-per-session "truth edit" – the GM must accept one factual change to the scene.
- Let a character invoke a Patron's name to retroactively avoid a TPK (once per campaign, with heavy cost).

These are not combat bonuses – they change what kind of story is being told.

Assets for Ruling Nations

A Major Asset (12 XP) might be a kingdom. Its free use could be "order a levy" or "declare a holiday". Its scene surge (1 Boon) could be "call in a noble favor" or "divert a river". Such assets come with obvious upkeep (taxes, succession, rebellions) – and they can be threatened or lost.

Adventures for Demigods

At the highest tiers, stakes should threaten **concepts**, not just lives. Examples:

- A curse that erases the memory of a city.
- A war that will redraw the map for centuries.
- A Patron who will change the fundamental laws of magic.

Victory may not be guaranteed – but even failure should leave a permanent mark on the world.

9.7 Running Mythic Scenarios (Tiers IV–V)

At the apex of power, the game changes. Use these techniques to keep play grounded in choices, not points.

Handling Reality-Altering Magic

When a player attempts something cosmic (e.g., "I wish the volcano had never erupted"), do not say no. Instead, offer a **compromise**:

- "You can do it, but it will cost you your connection to this place – you will never return."
- "It works, but for the remainder of the session, the world is unstable – every roll generates an extra SB."
- "You succeed, but your Patron demands a permanent sacrifice – one of your Talents is erased."

The effect happens, but the price is felt.

Player Agency at Cosmic Scale

At Tier V

Embrace this. Let players narrate what they are saving (or sacrificing) when they act.

Example: "I stop the ritual – but I let the rival escape." That rival becomes a future problem. "I save the city – but I lose my connection to my Patron." Now the player has a new arc: how to regain favor or find a new source of power.

Let the world break. If the climax involves a collapsing reality, the battlefield itself can be a clock. *Example: Reality Fracture [8].* Each time a major event occurs (a spell, a death, an oath), tick the clock. When it fills, the scene shifts – time loops, gravity reverses, or the characters meet themselves from another timeline.

Let the World Break (Clock Example)

Set a visible clock: **Reality Fracture [8]**. Tick it when:

- A character invokes a Patron's name in desperation.
- A major magical effect is attempted.
- A character makes a life-or-death choice.

At 4 segments, strange echoes appear (ghostly duplicates, time slips). At 8 segments, the scene transforms: gravity inverts, doors lead to wrong locations, or the party faces an alternate version of themselves.

9.8 Managing Cross-Patron and Invoker Conflicts

When a character serves multiple Patrons (e.g., an Invoker with several Symbols, or a Runekeeper who also carries a Symbol), their obligations can conflict.

Signs of Cross-Resonance

- A Symbol grows warm when another is used.
- Dreams become fragmented – two Patrons arguing in metaphor.
- Rites from one Patron cost +1 Obligation because the other Patron is "watching."

Resolving Conflicts Mechanically

If a character invokes two conflicting Patrons in the same scene, the GM may:

- Increase the DV of the second Rite by 1 (the Weave resists).
- Tick a *Patron Jealousy [4]* clock. When it fills, one Patron demands the character renounce the other (or pay a heavy price).

- Offer a Devil's Bargain: "You can use both, but mark 2 Fatigue and the GM gains 2 SB."

Narrative Resolution

Encourage players to roleplay the tension. A character who serves both the Traveler and Malachai might struggle with whether to take a shortcut (Traveler) that feeds a cursed addiction (Malachai). Use these moments to advance character arcs, not just punish mechanics.

9.9 Player-Managed Modules at High Tiers

At high tiers, players track more resources: multiple Obligation segments per Patron, Corruption clocks, Asset conditions, and often a Cord or Hollowed. Remind the table of the following responsibilities (see also Section 2.6 of the *GM Guide*):

- **Players declare thresholds.** "My Obligation just hit capacity" triggers an immediate effect. The GM should not have to ask.
- **Players maintain their own Asset states.** If a Safehouse is neglected, the player should note it and inform the GM when it is used.
- **Players track their own Corruption Blooms.** When a Cantor's Corruption Clock fills, the player chooses (or rolls) the new trait and enforces its roleplay cost.

The GM's job is to **spot-check** – occasionally ask "What's your current Obligation to Malachai?" – and to **enforce consequences** when a threshold is crossed. Never hunt for a player's misplaced number. If they forget a resource, assume it is in their favor (they have it) but the story may suffer a small twist.

9.10 Advanced Complex Scenarios

Heists: Player-Designed Plans

Instead of planning the heist for them, ask each player: "How does your character contribute to the plan?" Build a clock (e.g., *Heist Progress [8]*). Each player makes a roll using their chosen method (Stealth, Deception, Arcana, etc.). Success ticks the clock; failure adds complications (alarm, guard alerted). The GM spends SB from misses to introduce obstacles from the security system.

Mass Combat: Unit Clocks

Instead of rolling for every soldier, treat opposing armies as a single *War Clock [8]*. Player actions (command, sabotage, rally) tick the clock. When it fills, that side breaks or routs. Personal combat can happen in the same scene – but the mass conflict is abstracted to a single visible tracker.

Political Intrigue: Reputation as a Resource

Track a *Reputation Clock* [6] for the party in a given court. Social actions (gossip, favours, public deeds) tick it. When it fills, they become "trusted" – they can call in a major favor before the clock resets. But enemies also watch their rise, and may work to degrade the clock.

9.11 When to Say Yes, No, and Yes, But – Advanced Rulings

At high levels, players will attempt things that break normal bounds. Use these frameworks.

Compromise Solutions

Instead of a flat "no", offer a **scaled success** with a cost:

- **Yes, but only for this scene.**
- **Yes, but you must mark a permanent Condition.**
- **Yes, but it will take longer – start a clock.**
- **Yes, but the GM gains 3 SB to spend on that effect.**

This keeps creativity alive while respecting the game's tension economy.

Saying "No" Without Shutting Down

If a plan is impossible (e.g., "I kill the god with a single arrow"), explain why: "The god is not physically present; you would need to unmake its last shrine first." Then offer a path: "If you find the shrine and perform a ritual, you could banish it – you'll need to gather three relics." Turn the "no" into a new arc.

Let the Dice Decide – But Hedge

For a truly impossible request, set an **extreme DV (6+)** and a **Desperate Position**. If they succeed, they get a lesser version of what they wanted, or a temporary victory. This respects the dice while maintaining verisimilitude.

GM Golden Rule for Advanced Play

The mechanics are not a ceiling – they are scaffolding. Build taller stories with them, but never let them crush creativity.

Chapter 10

Enhanced GM Play

You have mastered the core rules. Now it is time to embrace a liberating truth: **you are a player too**. Your role is not to serve as a passive rules engine or an adversarial obstacle. You are a co-creator of drama, a conductor of tension, and – most importantly – someone who deserves to be surprised, delighted, and engaged by the game.

This chapter reframes GMing as an active, playful role. It offers low-overhead techniques to build tension, handle player indecision, adjust difficulty on the fly, and give you a few light "game" elements to play with – all while keeping your own enjoyment at the centre.

10.1 The GM as Player: A Philosophy

Unlike a board game, where the GM enforces fixed rules, FATE's EDGE invites you to **play to find out what happens**. You are not protecting a pre-written plot. You are throwing complications, asking questions, and reacting to player choices with genuine curiosity.

What Makes the GM's Role Fun

- **Surprise:** When players invent a solution you never considered, celebrate it. Let it change the story.
- **Power with Purpose:** Your resources (SB, clocks) are not weapons – they are narrative levers. Using them well feels satisfying.
- **Collaborative Discovery:** You do not know how the scene will end any more than the players do. That uncertainty is the game's heartbeat.

What to Let Go

- The need to be "fair" in every roll: Fairness lives in the fiction, not the dice. It is fair that a desperate roll fails spectacularly.
- The fear of "losing": You cannot lose. Your goal is to make the story memorable, not to defeat the players.

- The obligation to have all answers: Say "I don't know – what do you think?" then build on their answer.

10.2 Playing with Story Beats

Story Beats (SB) are your primary resource. Think of them as **dramatic currency** – spend them to make scenes more interesting for everyone, including you.

Advanced SB Spends (For Your Enjoyment)

- **1 SB:** Ask a leading question – "You notice something odd about the guard's uniform. What is it?" (Let the player invent a detail.)
- **2 SB:** Introduce a minor environmental hazard – a loose floorboard, a dripping pipe, a sudden draft. Describe it vividly.
- **3 SB:** Force a quick decision – "The door is closing. Stay and fight, or dive through?" (Watch them squirm – it is fun.)
- **4+ SB:** Reveal a hidden connection – "The bandit's dagger has your family crest." (Now you are as curious as they are.)

These turn SB from mere setbacks into narrative tools that engage players *and* surprise you.

Optional: The Threat Pool (A Mini-Game for the GM)

Threat Pool – Optional GM Resource

Use this if you want a small, fun resource to "play with". It does not replace Story Beats – it adds spice. The game works perfectly fine without it.

How It Works

- Start each scene with **3 Threat points**.
- Threat points do not carry over between scenes.
- Spend Threat points on the options below. Treat it as your own little bag of tricks.

Threat Pool Spend Options

Cost	Effect
1 Threat	An enemy gains +1 die on its next action.
1 Threat	Introduce a minor environmental detail – creaking floor, flickering light.
2 Threat	An enemy acts immediately (interrupt initiative order once).
2 Threat	Add a minor clock (e.g., <i>Fire Spreading [4]</i>) to the scene.
3 Threat	Introduce a new, weaker enemy (Cap 1–2).
3 Threat	Force a player to re-roll a single die (their choice of which die).

Design Note: Threat points are not a new economy – they are a simple pacing toy. They

give you something to do when you want to escalate without draining your Story Beat budget. Use them or ignore them; the game flows either way.

10.3 The Game Is Boring, Now What?

Sometimes the table loses energy. Players hesitate, nobody rolls 1s, and the scene flatlines. Use these techniques to restart the engine.

Why the Game Stalls

- **Timid players:** They fear failure or don't know what their characters can do.
- **Low SB generation:** Without 1s, you have no fuel for complications. The scene becomes predictable.
- **Unclear stakes:** Players don't know what they are risking, so they default to safe, boring actions.

Seven Ways to Re-ignite the Scene

1. **Ask a leading, character-specific question.** "Kael, you've been quiet. What's your character worried about right now?" This forces investment and often generates a roll.
2. **Introduce a visible, ticking clock.** Draw a 4-segment clock on the table. "The ritual completes in four exchanges. What do you do?" Visible pressure overcomes paralysis.
3. **Offer a Devil's Bargain (with SB as fuel).** "You can succeed automatically, but I gain 2 SB to spend right now – and I'll use them to complicate your escape." This teaches players that failure (or accepting bargains) creates excitement.
4. **Force a hard choice without a roll.** "The bridge is collapsing. You can save the child or the treasure – not both. Which one do you grab?" Choice is drama, even without dice.
5. **Spend your own SB to escalate even on a clean success.** Don't wait for 1s. If the scene is boring, declare: "I'm spending 1 banked SB – the guard you just slipped past turns around. What do you do?" This models that SB are for pacing, not just punishment.
6. **Ask a player to describe a memory or flashback.** "Sariel, you've seen a symbol like this before. Tell us where and what you remember." Narrative prompts cost nothing and build investment.
7. **Call for a roll with no stated DV.** "Roll me something – let's see what happens." Then interpret the result as a complication, a clue, or a new opportunity. Mystery thrills.

When Players Are Afraid to Act

Remind them of the core philosophy: **Partial success gives a Boon, Miss gives two Boons.** Failure is not punishment – it is resource generation. You can even say: "If you roll a Miss, you gain 2 Boons to spend later. Failure will make the story more interesting, not end it."

If a player is truly stuck, offer two explicit options: "Do you want to sneak past the guard or try to bribe him?" Then have them roll. Indecision is a luxury the game cannot afford.

When You Have No Story Beats (SB 0)

- **Still escalate:** You are never limited by SB (see Section ??). If the scene needs a complication, introduce it anyway.
- **Use environmental clocks:** Tick a clock for free if the players have been passive for too long. "While you argue, the fire spreads – *Collapse [4]* advances by 1."
- **Borrow from the future:** Say, "I'll bank a debt – next time someone rolls a 1, I'll spend it twice." This keeps momentum without breaking the economy.

Example: Rescuing a Stalled Heist

The party is trying to break into a manor but has spent ten minutes debating the window versus the door. No one has rolled anything. The GM says:

"While you argue, I'm ticking *Guard Patrol [6]* by 1 (no SB cost – time passes). Also, I'll offer a Devil's Bargain: one of you can already be inside – describe how you got in – but you left your backpack on the fence. Mark 1 Fatigue. Who takes it?"

A player accepts. The scene restarts with a character already inside, visible stakes, and a clock ticking.

10.4 Pacing and Tension Tactics (For GM Enjoyment)

The Three-Beat Scene Structure

For any important scene, aim for three emotional beats:

1. **Setup:** Establish stakes and environment. (Describe something evocative.)
2. **Clash:** Roll dice, spend SB, introduce complications. (This is where you get to be active.)
3. **Aftermath:** Resolve or escalate – but never leave a scene hanging. (Savour the outcome.)

If a scene drags, ask yourself: "What is the main question this scene answers?" Answer it, then move on. Your boredom is a sign to cut.

Using Clocks as Countdowns (Visible Fun)

Instead of saying "you have three rounds", show a clock: *Reinforcements Arrive [4]*. Players see it tick. You get to watch them prioritise under pressure. It is a simple joy.

Ending a Scene Before It Drags

When the main conflict is resolved, cut. Do not play out cleanup unless there is remaining tension. "You defeat the bandits – the rest flee. What do you do next?" Move on. Your energy is precious.

10.5 Handling Player Indecision (Without Frustration)

Offer Two Clear Choices

Never give more than two obvious paths. "Do you sneak past the guard or try to bribe him?" A third option ("or wait") is usually a stall. If they cannot choose, the world decides – the guard notices them. This keeps you from waiting.

Ask Leading Questions

Instead of "What do you do?" ask "Are you rushing in or staying back?" Framed choices keep momentum and reduce your cognitive load.

Use a Ticking Clock

If players hesitate, tick a clock (with or without SB). "While you argue, the fire spreads – *Flood [4]* advances 1." They will act. You will feel the satisfaction of applied pressure.

Offer a Devil's Bargain (Turn Indecision into Engagement)

When players are stuck weighing options, offer a **Devil's Bargain** – success at a cost, and the player chooses the terms.

"You can succeed automatically, but something else goes wrong. What is it?"

Examples:

- "You pick the lock, but your tools break – you won't open another door tonight."
- "You convince the guard to let you pass, but he remembers your face – the next encounter starts with worse Position."
- "You cross the chasm, but you drop one non-essential item of your choice."

The player picks the cost. This keeps them engaged and turns indecision into a dramatic moment.

10.6 Adjusting Difficulty on the Fly (For Smoother Play)

Lower DV Instead of Fudging Dice

If a challenge is too hard, reduce its DV by 1. The players never need to know. This is cleaner than ignoring a bad roll and preserves your credibility.

Offer a Devil's Bargain (See Above)

Add a Clock Instead of Raising DV

If a scene needs more tension, add a 4-segment clock (e.g., *Security Alert*) rather than increasing DV. Players see the clock and feel pressure, but the core roll remains fair. You get the tension without the maths.

10.7 Spotlight Management (Share the Love)

Rotate by Environment

In a quiet library, the scholar shines. On a battlefield, the fighter takes lead. Watch whose skills match the scene and give them first action. This keeps you engaged by varying who you interact with.

Use Bonds to Pass the Spotlight

Say: "You owe Marcus a debt. What do you do to protect him?" This directly engages a bond and moves focus. Bonds are your ally.

Quick Check-Ins

If one player is dominating, ask another: "While that happens, what is your character doing?" A simple question brings them back in. It also gives you a moment to breathe.

10.8 Using Failure to Advance the Plot (Make It Fun for You)

Fail Forward

A failed lockpick does not mean "nothing happens". It means "the lock clicks, but loudly – a guard stirs." The story moves. You get to introduce a new twist.

Failure Reveals Information

"You cannot pick the lock, but you notice the brand of a noble house – someone here has expensive tastes." You just gave them a clue. That is progress.

Offer a Hard Choice Instead of Flat Failure

"You can force the lock, but your pick will break – you will not be able to open another door tonight." Let the player choose. Watching them weigh options is half the fun.

Table: Failure Outcomes That Open Choices

Use this table to turn misses into narrative forks.

Failed Action	Outcome That Opens a Choice
Pick a lock	"You fail – but you notice the guard's patrol pattern. Do you wait for the next shift change or cause a distraction?"
Sneak past a sentry	"You stumble – but you see a loose brick in the wall. Do you hide behind it or cause a diversion?"
Persuade a noble	"They refuse – but they let slip that their rival has the real power. Do you court the rival or expose them?"
Climb a wall	"You fall – but you land near a drainpipe that leads to a basement door. Do you risk the drain or try another route?"
Forage for food	"You find nothing – but you spot fresh game tracks. Do you follow them deeper into the woods or head back?"

Each outcome gives the player a meaningful choice, turning failure from a dead end into a new branch.

10.9 Foreshadowing and Secrets (Reward Your Own Curiosity)

Show, Don't Tell

Instead of "this place is dangerous", describe: a bloody handprint, a cold draft, a whisper that stops when you enter. You are painting a mystery for yourself as much as for them.

Use SB to Plant Clues

Spend 1 SB to add a subtle detail: "You notice a torn piece of cloth on the window latch. It is a livery colour you recognise." Now you have a thread you can pull later.

Reveal Secrets Through Play, Not Exposition

Do not recap lore; let players discover it via rolls, clues, and NPC dialogue. If they miss it, it stays hidden – or they can find it another way. You get to be surprised when they finally uncover it.

10.10 Running Cliffhangers (Your Dramatic Exit)

End a Session After a Miss or Partial

The dice just gave you a perfect cliffhanger. End there: "The door swings open – and you see her." No further description. You get to enjoy the groans of anticipation.

Ask a Compelling Question

"The ritual completes. What happens to the city?" Write down the answer; start the next session with it. You have just outsourced a plot point – and their answer will inspire you.

Write Down the Cliffhanger

Keep a note – "Last thing: the door opened to reveal the queen's double." Read it aloud at the start of the next session. It builds continuity and makes you look organised.

10.11 Recovering from Bad Rulings (Gracefully)

Admit It Quickly

"I ruled that incorrectly. From now on, we will do it this way." Players appreciate honesty. Your ego is not at stake.

Offer a Retroactive Boon

If a bad ruling hurt a player, give them a free Boon. No need to retcon the past. You turn a mistake into a gift.

Only Retcon if the Game Breaks

If the ruling was minor, move on. If it invalidates a major plot point, say "Let's rewind that scene – my mistake." Then replay the last few minutes. Your players will understand.

10.12 Lightweight Faction Loyalty (Optional – For Your Sandbox)

Track faction standing on a simple **–3 to +3 scale**. No dice, no complex tables.

- **–3:** Enemy – actively works against the party.
- **0:** Neutral – indifferent.
- **+3:** Ally – will sacrifice for the party.

Shift loyalty by ± 1 after major interactions (saved the faction, betrayed them, etc.). Display the number openly. That is it. You now have a living world with minimal effort.

10.13 Complication Trading (Player Choice, Your Delight)

When a player fails or partially succeeds, offer them a **choice of complication**:

- "You fail to pick the lock. Does the noise alert a guard, or do you break your tools?"
- "You miss the shot. Does the arrow hit an ally, or do you lose your balance and fall?"

This keeps players engaged even in failure. You get to watch them choose their poison.

10.14 Cross-Cultural Synergy (Creativity Tip)

Encourage players to combine cultural elements from different regions. If they propose a clever mix (e.g., Aeler engineering + Kahfagian sailing = a faster ship), give them a **+1 die** or **reduce DV by 1** for that roll. You reward creativity, and you get to see the world come alive through their ideas.

10.15 Final Thought: You Are Playing Too

Do not forget that you are a player at the table. Use SB to have fun. Laugh at the unexpected outcomes. Be surprised by player choices. Celebrate their successes and your own clever complications.

Your enjoyment is as important as theirs. When you are having fun, the table feels it.

Now go run a memorable scene – and enjoy the ride.

"The best sessions are the ones where the GM walks away thinking, "I had no idea that would happen." "

Chapter 11

The Known World: A Lore Compendium

Using This Compendium

You only need to read the region your campaign is set in. The generators (see the separate *Travel Guide*) will provide the rest.

Quick reference by subgenre and typical conflict:

Region	Fantasy Subgenre	Typical Conflict
Acasia	Low fantasy / mercenary realism	Feuding warlords, mercenary flips, the Curse
Aelaerem	Folk horror / pastoral dark	The Neighbors, clan feuds, harvest famine
Aeler	Industrial / political / survival horror	Resource scarcity, jurisdiction feuds, White Flood
Aelinnel	Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror	Geasa, Thorn Court vs. law, the Green Gate
Black Banners	Military / mercenary warfare	Payday delays, condotta flips, winter campaigns
Ecktoria	Political intrigue / legal drama	Rival claimants, bread riots, Everflame schisms
Linn	Viking / maritime / oath-bound raiding	Feuds, mistland fog, Thing injunctions
Mistlands	Folk horror / gothic	Direwood encroachment, ward-salt shortages
Silkstrand	Urban / mercantile / noir	Guild rivalries, dyewater curses, condotta flips
Theona	Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven	No Ninth taboo, bride-peace feasts, Green Host
Thepyrgos	Byzantine / academic / arcane mystery	Synod edicts, iconoclast riots, witch-hunters
Ubral	Highland clan / reiver / honour culture	Blood feuds, guest-right, dwarf toll roads
Valewood	Fairy tale / dark forest / fey remnant	Phasing ruins, fae courts, imperial echoes
Vhasia	Courtly romance / chivalric / fractured kingdom	Rival dukes, chevauchée, parlement war
Viterra	Legal drama / low fantasy / frontier justice	Border disputes, legal duels, Queen's progress
Ykrul	Steppe nomad / saga	Feuds, hostage strings, white squalls
Zakov	Pirate / noir / crime syndicate	Syndicate wars, tide-driven routes, cursed cargoes

When you read a region entry, look for the **GM Seed** – a one-line hook to spark an adventure – and the **Faction Standing** suggestion. Use the simple –3 to +3 scale to track attitudes, and tie advancements to **Mandate** and **Crisis** clocks (see 3.6.1 and 3.6.2).

This chapter presents a practical overview of the major regions of Fate's Edge. For each area, you will find its dominant **fantasy subgenre**, the **primary conflicts** that drive adventure, and the **key stakeholders** (factions, leaders, and powers) that shape events. Use this as a quick reference when planning sessions or improvising.

11.1 A Note on Subgenres and Travel

Each region is designed as a distinct fantasy subgenre (see §??). When the party travels from one region to another, the genre shifts – a journey from the folk horror of the Mistlands to the political intrigue of Ecktoria should feel like turning the page to a different kind of story. Use the travel rules to blend these genres organically.

11.2 Acasia — "The Broken Province"

Genre: Low fantasy / mercenary realism / border feud.

Primary Conflicts.

- Feuding petty kingdoms and warlords.
- Mercenary companies (the Black Banners) that shift loyalties with coin.
- The lingering "Curse" – a supernatural blight that twists roads and ruins.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Margravine of the Broken March** – The highest authority, half-saint, half-tax-roll.
- **The Lame King** – A traveling pretender who makes law by pointing.
- **Blackwood Matriarchs** – Hedge-witches and feud-keepers.
- **Free Company Captains** – Pike and shot mercenaries between contracts.

Quote.

"In Acasia, every bargain is an echo of a promise once broken, and every drink tastes faintly of debt."

GM Seed.

A broken bridge, a cursed child, and a free company that switches sides.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Margravine secretly funds the Lame King's pretensions to keep the province fractured – unity would threaten her tax base.
- A Blackwood Matriarch knows the true cause of the Curse: a forgotten oath to a powerful spirit, now demanding a child as payment.

Faction Standing. Track attitudes toward the Margravine, the Lame King, and the major free companies on a –3 to +3 scale. Tick *Mandate* up when the party brokers a truce or earns a noble's public endorsement. Tick *Crisis* when a feud spills into their path or a condotta flips.

Lore Note. *The road-judges of Acasia whisper that the Curse is not a blight but a slow accounting – every unpaid tithe, every broken oath, etched into the stone. "Pay what you owe," they say, "or the road will eat the interest."*

11.3 Aelaerem (Halflings) — "Hearth & Hollow"

Genre: Folk horror / pastoral quiet with dark undercurrents.

Primary Conflicts.

- The "Neighbors" – fae or otherworldly powers that demand observance.
- Feuds between clan matriarchs that can last generations.
- Harvest tithes and famine pressure.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Apple-Matron** – Hostess of harvest feasts; power sits where she pours.
- **The Pale Shepherd** – Comes when lambs are born and when people go missing.
- **Mummers" Captain** – Keeps a chest of masks and stricter rules than church.
- **Lantern-Warden** – Trims lamps and knows which shadow is wrong.

Quote.

"Don't cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you've got a silver tooth."

GM Seed.

A harvest feast where the ninth cup is poured, and the Hollow answers.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Apple-Matron knows that the Pale Shepherd is not a single entity – it is a title passed down. The current Shepherd is a desperate woman trying to buy back her son's life.
- The Mummers" Captain's masks are not carved; they are grown from a living barrow. Each mask contains a trapped Neighbor.

Faction Standing. Track relations with the Apple-Matron's hearth, the Lantern-Wardens, and the Pale Shepherd's circuit. Tick *Mandate* when the party honors a taboo or mediates a feud. Tick *Crisis* when a Neighbor is disturbed or a harvest fails.

Lore Note. *A Gray Wanderer's note: "The Alearem pour the ninth cup only for the Hollow. They count to eight, then stop. I have seen a child count nine. The cup did not overflow – but the child's reflection was no longer her own."*

11.4 Aeler (Dwarves) — "Crowns & Under-Vaults"

Genre: Industrial / political / survival horror (underground).

Primary Conflicts.

- Resource scarcity (air, water, light, food) in sealed holds.
- Jurisdictional feuds – bell-code conflicts between crown and basilica.
- The "White Flood" – mountain thaw that becomes a river through routes.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Vault-Queen** – Sovereign above and below.
- **High King Beneath the Peaks** – First among crowns by ancient concord.
- **True Masons** – Wanderers repairing ancient stonework.
- **Edgewalkers** – Prospectors and border scanners.

Quote.

"When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen."

GM Seed.

A ventilation shaft collapses, and the only way out is through a sealed crypt that holds a forgotten king's secret.

Hidden Agendas.

- The High King's health is failing; his advisors are preparing a succession that would shatter the ancient concord.
- The True Masons are not neutral – some factions use them to quietly seal off rival holds.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Vault-Queen, the High King's court, and the True Masons. Tick *Mandate* when the party secures a new trade route or repairs a crucial under-way. Tick *Crisis* when a bell-code dispute escalates or a White Flood warning is ignored.

Lore Note. *Saikou Ira's case files: "An Aeler tunnel-wright once told me, "The mountain does not forget a misplaced keystone. It waits – sometimes a year, sometimes a century – then settles the debt with a collapse." I have never seen a dwarf leave a stone unturned."*

11.5 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — "Stone, Bough, and Bright Things"

Genre: Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror.

Primary Conflicts.

- Geasa and spoken taboos that bind without warning.
- Thorn Court vs. human law – jurisdiction debates.
- The Green Gate – a threshold that demands exact change in truths.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Stone Prince of Aelinnel** – Mortal crown with fae debts properly indexed.
- **Lady of Thorns** – Hawthorn court sovereign; smiles like a snare.
- **Green Knight** – Duelist of paths and proofs.
- **Oath-Carver** – Sets promises in quartz so they can be seen.

Quote.

"The law here flows like water over stone – it finds its own path, and woe to those who try to dam it with paper."

GM Seed.

A missing step, an unsaid name, and a door that only opens when you speak the eighth word.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Stone Prince's ledger is missing a page – a debt owed to the Thorn Court that could collapse his reign if discovered.
- The Green Knight is not a single being; the title passes to whoever wins the last duel. The current Knight is a mortal who refuses to die.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Stone Prince's court, the Lady of Thorns, and the Oath-Carvers. Tick *Mandate* when the party resolves a dispute without breaking geas. Tick *Crisis* when a promise is shattered or the Green Gate opens at the wrong hour.

Lore Note. *From the Grey Wanderer: "An Aelinnel bell-tender once told me, "We do not say "no" to a spirit. We say, "That road is closed for repairs." The spirit nods and leaves. It is not a lie – the road is closed. To spirits."*

11.6 Black Banners — "Condotta & Crowns"

Genre: Military / mercenary / low fantasy warfare.

Primary Conflicts.

- Payday delays and supply shortages.
- Condotta units flipping sides mid-battle.
- Winter campaigns and frozen battlefields.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Banner-Captain** – Griffon standard and a ledger of noble grudges.
- **The Black Colonel** – Legendary commander not seen in months, yet his banner still rides.
- **Clan-Mother** (Ykrul) – Wears war-braids from oath-breakers' hair.
- **Veteran Sergeant** – Counts scars like coins.

Quote.

"A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it."

GM Seed.

Two rival companies encamped on opposite sides of a frozen river; a single bag of coin could end the war or set off a massacre.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Black Colonel is dead; his banner is carried by a mute lieutenant who follows his last orders. No one dares question the legend.
- The Clan-Mother is secretly selling war-braids to both sides, prolonging the conflict for profit.

Faction Standing. Track standing with individual banner captains, the condotta brokers, and the Clan-Mother. Tick *Crisis* when a payday is missed or a condotta flips mid-contract.

Lore Note. *A camp whisper: "The Black Colonel died three winters ago. The banner rides because the company owes him a war. They will not stop until the debt is paid – in blood or gold."*

11.7 Ecktoria — "Marble & Fire"

Genre: Political intrigue / legal drama / fallen empire.

Primary Conflicts.

- Rival dukes, abbesses, and parlements claiming legitimacy.
- Bread riots, grain shortages, and currency devaluation.
- The Everflame orthodoxy vs. reformist sects.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Grand Magistrate** – Guardian of forms, breaker of them when needed.
- **High Priest of the Everflame** – Smiles like law; flame judges truth and debt.
- **Duchess-Regent** – Speaks through cousins, rules through silence.
- **Censor's Clerk** – "Misfiles" careers; knows which names to forget.

Quote.

"The law here is written not in books but in marble and flame."

GM Seed.

A forged will, a missing tax ledger, and a procession that turns into a riot at noon.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Grand Magistrate suspects the High Priest of the Everflame is hiding a heretic in the basilica's crypt – a former Censor who knows too much.
- The Duchess-Regent is not the real ruler; she is a body double. The true duchess died years ago, and her spymaster keeps the secret to control the province.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Grand Magistrate, the Everflame priesthood, and the ducal courts. Tick *Mandate* when the party wins a legal case or brokers a grain deal. Tick *Crisis* when a bread riot ignites or a heretic is burned.

Lore Note. *Saikou Ira notes: "The Everflame's inquisitors burn heretics on the Triumph Stairs. But the ashes are swept into the same crypts as the senators' bones. In Ecktoria, even the dead cannot escape politics."*

11.8 Linn — "Skerries & Storm-Oaths"

Genre: Viking / maritime / oath-bound raiding.

Primary Conflicts.

- Feuds that turn weddings into funerals.
- Mistlands fog and misdirection – channels "move" without warning.
- Thing injunctions that forbid sailing until a grievance is heard.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Sea-Queen** – Crown of hammered silver, eyes for weather and law.
- **High Jarl** – First among raids, last to boast.
- **Volva of the Mist** – Oath-reader whose nod stills surf.
- **Skald** – Verses buy silence, start fights, end them.

Quote.

"The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds."

GM Seed.

A bride stolen, a longship lost in fog, and a skald's verse that names the dead.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Sea-Queen lost an eye to a storm – or to a rival's blade. Her court knows, but no one speaks of it.
- The Volva of the Mist is not Linnic; she is a runaway from the Mistlands who bargained with a spirit for her position.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Sea-Queen's court, the High Jarl's household, and the skaldic circles. Tick *Mandate* when the party resolves a feud at Thing. Tick *Crisis* when a ship is lost in a squall or a wedding turns to blood.

Lore Note. *"A Linn skald's verse: "The Thing-bell rings for the living. The drowned wait for a different bell – one that only sounds when the tide forgets its name.""*

11.9 Mistlands — "Bells, Salt, and Breath"

Genre: Folk horror / gothic / supernatural dread.

Primary Conflicts.

- The Direwood's encroachment – undead and wraiths testing the bell-lines.
- Ward-salt shortages and bell-line failures.
- Aeler protectorate authority vs. local independence.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Legate of the Mists** – Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree.
- **Bell-Warden** – Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay.
- **Salt-Monk** – Blesses pans and keeps ward-measure honest.
- **Mist-Seer** – Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks.

Quote.

"The bells here do more than mark time – they weave the very fabric of reality."

GM Seed.

A bell-line fails at dusk, and something that should not walk steps through the gap.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Legate of the Mists knows that the Direwood is not a natural forest – it is a prison for a forgotten god. The bell-lines are the bars of its cage.
- A faction of Salt-Monks hoards pure salt to sell to desperate villages, letting other wards decay.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Legate's protectorate, the Bell-Wardens, and the Salt-Monks. Tick *Mandate* when the party repairs a bell-line or negotiates a ward-salt shipment. Tick *Crisis* when a wraith breaks through or a village is quarantined.

Lore Note. *A Gray Wanderer's warning: "In the Mistlands, never breathe deeply after the ninth bell. The fog remembers your breath, and one day it will ask for it back."*

11.10 Silkstrand — "City of Bridges & Dyewater"

Genre: Urban / mercantile / noir.

Primary Conflicts.

- Guild rivalries and Exchange cornering.
- The "Curse" – dyewater omens and awakened curses in the canals.
- Condottieri flipping colors mid-contract.

Key Stakeholders.

- **The Matron** – Rules from her palazzo stairs with velvet and iron.
- **Guildmistress of Dyers** – Stained hands, permits tighter than purse strings.
- **Bridge Bailiff** – Rents stalls, sells gossip by the breath.
- **Night-Boat Smuggler ("Ravel")** – Silent oar, louder favors.

Quote.

"In this city, every bridge is a ledger and every current carries coin."

GM Seed.

A dye-permit stamped with a dead notary's seal, and a canal that runs red at midnight.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Matron's velvet gloves hide iron claws: she personally ordered the death of the last Bridge Bailiff who refused to rig a debt auction.
- The Guildmistress of Dyers is slowly poisoning the water to drive out smaller competitors; the "Curse" is a convenient cover.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Matron's office, the Dyers' Guild, and the smuggling networks. Tick *Mandate* when the party brokers a trade deal or exposes a forger. Tick *Crisis* when the Exchange corners a market or a condotta flips.

Lore Note. *Madam Serafine's whisper: "The dye-water never truly washes out. A forger's hands stay stained – not with colour, but with the memory of every seal they broke. You can see it in the way their fingers curl."*

11.11 Theona — "Three Greens, No Ninth"

Genre: Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven.

Primary Conflicts.

- The "No Ninth" taboo – omissions, unspoken names, missing steps.
- Bride-peace feasts that can end or restart feuds.
- The Green Host – spectral riders that appear when customs are broken.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Matron of Wells** – Queen-mother in truth if not name.
- **Three-Isles King** – Elected by moots; whale-bone throne.
- **Lady Beneath** – Unseen queen who bargains in dreams.
- **Taboo-Witness** – Geas-keeper who knows which words ruin deals.

Quote.

"The wells here hold more than water – they hold the dreams and prayers of generations."

GM Seed.

A bride-peace feast where the ninth cup is poured, and the Green Host rides before dawn.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Lady Beneath is not a spirit – she is a mortal exile who learned to walk through dreams. She uses omens to manipulate the Three-Isles King.
- The Taboo-Witness is dying. She is looking for a successor to inherit her geas – and her debts.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Matron of Wells, the Three-Isles King's moot, and the Taboo-Witness. Tick *Mandate* when the party keeps the Ninth silent or brokers a marriage peace. Tick *Crisis* when a taboo is broken or the Green Host is sighted.

Lore Note. *A Gray Wanderer's note: "I attended a moot on Theona. They counted every vote, every step, every cup – but never the ninth. When I asked why, the eldest said, "The ninth is not for us. It is for the ones who will come after. Let them count it.""*

11.12 Thepyrgos — "City of a Thousand Stairs"

Genre: Byzantine / academic / arcane mystery.

Primary Conflicts.

- Synod edicts that proscribe or permit chants and rites.
- Iconoclast riots between competing faiths.
- Witch-hunters and arcane talent conscription.

Key Stakeholders.

- **The Archon** – Elected, entrenched, counting bells.
- **Lighthouse-Patriarch** – Reclusive seer who steers beacons in storms.
- **Nomophylax** – Law-scholar whose citations close mouths.
- **Palkar Captain** – Tower guards; ladder-quick and letter-shy.

Quote.

"Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky."

GM Seed.

A stolen grimoire, a silent bell, and a witch-hunter who refuses to explain her orders.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Lighthouse-Patriarch is not senile; he is hiding a child with forbidden talent in the beacon tower.
- The Archon plans to dissolve the Synod and rule alone. He has already bribed half the Palkar captains.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Archon's office, the Synod, and the Chain-Lantern order. Tick *Mandate* when the party resolves a heresy trial or sponsors a student. Tick *Crisis* when an iconoclast riot erupts or a witch-hunt goes too far.

Lore Note. *Saikou Ira's observation: "Thepyrgos's witch-hunters carry censers of lead, not brass. "Brass is for faith," they say. "Lead is for certainty." I have never seen a lead censer cool."*

11.13 Ubral — "The Stone Between Spears"

Genre: Highland clan / reiver / honour culture.

Primary Conflicts.

- Feuds that last generations, settled by wergild in cattle or blood.
- Guest-right – breaking hospitality stains name worse than breaking a sword.
- Dwarf toll roads and clan independence.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Lady of Tor** – Clan-chief in cloak and mail.
- **Council of Cairns** – Greybeards and granite wills; they do not hurry.
- **Feud-Broker** – Knows the weight of life in cattle and coin.
- **Wergild Counter** – Keeps tallies, ends grudges, starts others.

Quote.

"The stone here remembers every oath sworn upon it and every blood spilled in its shadow."

GM Seed.

A stolen herd, a broken guest-token, and a cairn that adds a new name at dawn.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Lady of Tor is dying without an heir. She plans to name a successor from outside the clan – a move that will trigger a civil war.
- The Council of Cairns is not a council of elders; it is a single shaman wearing many masks, speaking with different voices.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Lady of Tor, the Council of Cairns, and the Khaz-Vurim dwarf wardens. Tick *Mandate* when the party pays a wergild or brokers a truce. Tick *Crisis* when a feud reignites or a guest-right is violated.

Lore Note. *A Gray Wanderer's memory: "An Ubral widow once told me, "My husband's feud cost three cows and a boy's finger. I paid the cows. The finger – that is still owed." She smiled. I did not ask more."*

11.14 Valewood — "Empire Under Leaves"

Genre: Fairy tale / dark forest / fey remnant.

Primary Conflicts.

- Phasing ruins and star-roads that shift between worlds.
- Fae courts (Hazel vs. Alder) competing for influence.
- Imperial echoes – ancient shades still marching patrols.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Hazel Queen** – Lethai-ar sovereign in leaf and law.
- **Alder King** – Twilit Court sovereign in shadow and debt.
- **The Huntsman** – Antlers of moonlight; shortcuts owe him.
- **Pathweaver** – Knots safe routes into cord.

Quote.

"The forest here remembers empires that crumbled to dust, and its laws are older than your kingdoms."

GM Seed.

A star-road that opens at dusk, a fae bargain that demands a voice, and an imperial shade that knows your true name.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Hazel Queen is dying from an old curse. She is looking for a mortal to inherit her crown – and her debt to the Alder King.
- The Huntsman is not loyal to either court; he is a former lover of the Hazel Queen, cursed to hunt her enemies until she lifts the spell.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Hazel Queen, the Alder King, and the Imperial Echo patrols. Tick *Mandate* when the party returns a relic or respects a geas. Tick *Crisis* when a court's patience expires or a star-road realigns dangerously.

Lore Note. *A Lethai-ar whisper: "The Valewood is not a place. It is a process. Every root, every leaf, every fallen emperor – all are being digested into something new. Walk softly, or you will join the meal."*

11.15 Vhasia — "The Fractured Sun"

Genre: Courtly romance / chivalric / fractured kingdom.

Primary Conflicts.

- Rival dukes claiming the Sun-crown.
- Chevauchée – raiding parties that burn loyalty oaths as well as barns.
- Parlement divided – war by paperwork.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Two Crowns** – Rival dukes, each crowned in rival cathedrals.
- **Queen-Mother** – Weaves alliances as if they were dowries.
- **Last Dauphin** – Rumor with a birthmark; armies march for whispers.
- **Marshal-Exile** – Sun-court's hammer, now wielded by whoever pays.

Quote.

"The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains."

GM Seed.

A false Dauphin, a stolen crown, and a chevauchée that burns a village that swore neutrality.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Queen-Mother secretly supports both Crowns; she wants the war to continue until every rival duke is exhausted.
- The Last Dauphin is a commoner recruited by the Marshal-Exile. He believes his own legend.

Faction Standing. Track standing with each of the Two Crowns, the Queen-Mother, and the Parlement clerks. Tick *Mandate* when the party brokers a truce or exposes a forgery. Tick *Crisis* when a chevauchée goes unanswered or a parlement divides.

Lore Note. *The Gray Wanderer: "In Vhasia, every castle flies two banners – one for the king who might return, and one for the lord who actually lives there. The third banner, the one for the truth, is never raised."*

11.16 Viterra — "The Hedge-Law Realm"

Genre: Legal drama / low fantasy / frontier justice.

Primary Conflicts.

- Border disputes over hay-carts and toll rights.
- Legal duels – formal combat to settle property claims.
- The Queen's progress – royal authority moving through semi-autonomous duchies.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Warrior Queen** – Crown on helm, sword at side, patient sums behind gaze.
- **Queen's Justiciar** – Law on road, polite as a noose.
- **Fen Reeve** – Tally-rod; speaks for dike guilds.
- **Master Advocate Halric** – Silver-tongued legal warrior.

Quote.

"Every hedge here marks not just a boundary but a principle – the careful balance between order and freedom."

GM Seed.

A boundary stone moved overnight, a legal duel at dawn, and a charter that was signed in disappearing ink.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Warrior Queen is not a warrior; she is a diplomat who won the crown by out-arguing her rivals. Her sword has never been drawn.
- Master Advocate Halric is a spy for a foreign power, feeding legal secrets to Vhasian exiles.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Queen's court, the Queen's Justiciars, and the Fen Reeves. Tick *Mandate* when the party wins a legal case or settles a border dispute. Tick *Crisis* when a legal duel turns lethal or a charter is voided.

Lore Note. *A Justiciar's saying: "The hedge does not move. The law moves. If you wake to find your boundary stone three feet east, do not curse the neighbour – curse the clerk who slept with the surveyor's wife."*

11.17 Ykrul (Orcs) — "Wolf Standards, Winter Camps"

Genre: Steppe nomad / saga / honour culture.

Primary Conflicts.

- Feuds and blood-price (wergild) in cattle or horses.
- Hostage strings – token kin left to secure treaties.
- White squalls and rasputitsa (spring melt) that seal passes.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Khatun of Ring** – Camp-law and hostage strings.
- **Khagan's Kin** – Sent to bind foedus with a look.
- **Sky-Speaker** – Shaman of storms; shortcuts owe them price.
- **Kon'reh Masters** – Geometry arbiters and teachers.

Quote.

"The steppe remembers every oath sworn beneath its endless sky, and the wolf-standards carry the honor of clans that have outlasted empires."

GM Seed.

A hostage string cut, a white squall that blinds both sides, and a Sky-Speaker who demands a blood-price for the weather.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Khagan's Kin are not blood relatives; they are children of conquered chieftains, trained to be loyal enforcers.
- The Kon'reh Masters secretly manipulate the geometry of oaths to favor certain clans, maintaining a hidden balance of power.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Khatun's camp, the Khagan's court, and the Sky-Speaker's circle. Tick *Mandate* when the party pays a blood-price or secures a hostage exchange. Tick *Crisis* when a white squall isolates a camp or a hostage string is severed.

Lore Note. *A Ykrul bone-singer's whisper: "The wind carries more than snow. It carries the names of the forgotten. When a horse shies at nothing, it is because a name touched its ear. Speak the name, and the horse will calm – or run."*

11.18 Zakov — "Salt & Serpent"

Genre: Pirate / noir / crime syndicate.

Primary Conflicts.

- Syndicate wars and the Salt Prince's levy.
- Tide-driven smuggling routes that shift with the water.
- Cursed cargoes and fae bargains at the Crimson Docks.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Salt Prince** – Nominal ruler; real power in shadows.
- **Pirate Queen** – Rules the Shallows with charm and cutlass.
- **Kraken's Tongue** – Oracle who speaks in riddles and tides.
- **Syndicate Silent** – No names, just favors and faces.

Quote.

"The tide here keeps better ledgers than any scribe, and the reefs remember every secret whispered above their depths."

GM Seed.

A cursed cargo that whispers, a tide that does not rise, and a Syndicate Silent who offers a deal with no visible cost.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Salt Prince is a puppet; the real ruler is the Kraken's Tongue, who uses the oracle's prestige to manipulate every syndicate.
- The Pirate Queen is secretly a spy for a mainland power, sent to destabilize Zakov before an invasion.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Salt Prince's court, the Pirate Queen's flotilla, and the Syndicate Silent. Tick *Crisis* when a syndicate war breaks out or a cursed cargo escapes. (Mandate rarely applies in Zakov – reputation is measured in threats, not legitimacy.)

Lore Note. *Madam Serafine's advice: "In Zakov, a coin that stays warm is a curse. Spend it fast, or throw it into the sea. The Salt Prince's collectors can smell interest from three docks away."*

11.19 Other Regions (Brief)

For completeness, these areas appear in the comprehensive guide but are less central to the core setting:

- **Dungeon** – "**Living Infrastructure**" – A mythic underworld that breathes; genre: dungeon crawl as survival horror.
- **The Ways Between** – "**Spiritways & Veilways**" – Liminal paths between death and dreams; genre: metaphysical / dream-logic.
- **The Wilds** – "**Roads, Ruins, and Weather**" – A reskin palette for any terrain – forest, desert, tundra, coast.
- **Vilikari** – "**Laurels & Longhouses**" – A federated frontier mixing Utaran law with barbarian custom.

11.20 Using This Compendium at the Table

When preparing a session or improvising, consult the region's entry for:

- **Genre** – to set the right mood.
- **Primary conflicts** – to generate immediate stakes.
- **Key stakeholders** – to populate scenes with recognizable NPCs.
- **Quote** – to read aloud as a flavour text.
- **GM Seed** – a one-sentence hook for quick inspiration.
- **Hidden Agendas** – secrets that can become campaign threads.
- **Faction Standing** – track attitudes with the simple -3 to $+3$ scale, and advance *Mandate* or *Crisis* clocks as described.

Remember that travel rules (see §??) allow you to blend these genres as the party moves from one region to another.

Chapter 12

Appendices

This chapter collects quick-reference tables, optional rules, and GM tools into thematic appendices. Use them as needed at the table. For additional player-facing reference, see the *Player's Guide* appendices.

Appendix A: Core Reference Tables

Table 12.1: Outcome Matrix

Case	Name	Guidance
$S \geq DV, C = 0$	Clean Success	Deliver the intent crisply.
$S \geq DV, C > 0$	Success & Cost	Grant intent; spend or bank SB for complications.
$0 < S < DV$	Partial	Progress; award 1 Boon.
$S = 0$	Miss	No progress; award 2 Boons; spend or bank SB.

Story Beat (SB) Spend Menu

- **1 SB:** Minor pressure – noise, trace, +1 segment on a relevant clock.
- **2 SB:** Moderate setback – alarm raised, lose cover or advantage, lesser foe appears.
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble – reinforcements arrive, key gear breaks temporarily, tick a campaign front.
- **4+ SB:** Major turn – trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts dramatically.

Position Descriptions

- **Dominant:** Act on your terms. Consequences are manageable.
- **Controlled:** Normal risk and reward. Failure has a real cost.
- **Desperate:** Odds stacked against you. Failure could be catastrophic.

Table 12.2: Difficulty Ladder

DV	Name	When to Use
2	Routine	Clear intent, modest stakes, controlled environment.
3	Pressured	Time pressure, mild opposition, partial information.
4	Hard	Hostile conditions, active opposition, precise timing.
5+	Extreme	Multiple constraints, high stakes, dramatic failure.

Boon Economy Quick Guide

- **Holding cap:** 5 Boons maximum.
- **Carryover:** At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2.
- **Conversion:** 2 Boons $\rightarrow$ 1 XP, once per session during downtime (max 2 XP per session via conversion).
- **Spending:** Re-roll a die, activate an asset, improve Position, or power certain Rites.

Mechanical Constraints

- **Assist Max:** +3 dice total per roll (Exceptional Coordination allows +4 from one follower).
- **Boon Max:** 5 total; 2→1 XP conversion once per session (max 2 XP via conversion).
- **Follower Independent Action:** Once per scene (party-wide).
- **Over-Stack:** Two or more structural advantages on the same action → start one obstacle at +1 DV or GM banks +1 SB.

Table 12.3: Harm Levels and Effects

Level	SB Generation	Penalty	Recovery
Minor	1 SB (next 2 rolls)	−1 die (related actions)	Rest or basic care
Moderate	1 SB (next roll)	−1 die (most actions)	Medical treatment
Severe	2 SB (next roll)	−2 dice (most actions)	Extended care
Critical	3 SB (next roll)	Incapacitated	Major intervention

Range Bands

Close

Arm's length, grappling distance.

Near

Same room or immediate area.

Far Visible but not immediately reachable.

Absent

Off-screen; requires a scene change.

Movement Actions

- **Move:** Shift one range band (CloseNear or NearFar).
- **Dash:** Shift two bands as your full action.
- **Disengage:** Test to leave an enemy's Close range without provoking an opportunity attack.
- **Charge / Skirmish:** Full-turn actions that move two bands and attack, costing 1 Fatigue.

See 2.8.1 for complete action economy.

Supply Clock States

Full (0 segments)

Well-provisioned, no penalty.

Low (2 segments)

Minor friction – resource checks at –1 die.

Dangerously Low (3 segments)

Each PC gains Fatigue 1.

Empty (4 segments)

Severe penalties – starvation or thirst risk.

Travel Clock Sizes**4 segments**

Short, straightforward leg.

6 segments

Standard leg.

8 segments

Extended or complex journey.

10 segments

Epic or highly dangerous passage.

Table 12.4: XP Costs

Improvement	Cost	Downtime
Attribute increase	new rating $\times$ 3 XP	new rating days
Skill increase	new level $\times$ 2 XP	new level days
On-Screen Follower	Cap ² XP	1–3 days
Minor Asset	4 XP	1 day
Standard Asset	8 XP	1 week
Major Asset	12 XP	1 month

Upkeep (Condensed)

Frequency: Once per downtime period.

- **Efficient (higher XP, less time):** Upkeep XP = $\max(1, \frac{\text{Acquisition XP}}{3})$.
- **Intensive (1 XP, dedicated action):** One full downtime action.
- **Failure to pay:** Follower becomes Wary (or Seized if already Wary); Asset becomes Neglected (or Compromised if already Neglected).

Appendix B: Optional Rules and Tactical Tools

Grid-Based Combat (Optional)

Use a square or hex grid with Zones of Control (ZoC).

ZoC rules:

- Entering an enemy's Zone of Control ends your movement – you are engaged.
- You cannot move through an enemy's ZoC.
- Leaving a ZoC requires the Disengage action (DV 4–6) or spending 1 Boon.
- Flank: +1 die to attack. Rear: +1 die and +1 Effect.

Push-Through: Roll Body + Athletics vs. $DV = 2 + \text{enemy Tier}$. Choose a cost on success: Position worsens by one step, –1 die on the action, or the enemy gets a free opportunity attack.

Detailed Warfare (Mass Combat)

Treat an army as a high-Cap Follower (see 2.10.3) with its own clocks:

- **Supply Clock** (6–8 segments): When empty, the army suffers severe penalties.
- **Morale Clock** (6–8 segments): When full, the army routs.
- **Command rolls** (Presence + Command or Wits + Tactics) advance objective clocks (e.g., *Break Their Line* [6]).
- **Battle's Edge:** Story Beats generated by command rolls can be spent on fog-of-war complications – false orders, broken supply wagons, or a messenger's death.

Hex-Based Exploration

Map a region in 6-mile hexes. Entering a hex requires a Wits + Survival roll (DV set by terrain). Outcomes determine discovery (find a point of interest), danger (ambush, hazard), or becoming lost (add a clock segment to find the way out).

Miniatures Mode — Speed Defaults

Base DV: $DV = \text{Tier} + 2 + \text{Keywords (elevation +1, [WARD] +1, Disengage base DV 4)}$.

Critical Hit (10): Bump Position one step; if already Dominant, Push or Pull the target 1 hex *or* gain +1 automatic success.

Zone of Control (ZoC): Entering or leaving a hex adjacent to an enemy provokes one Reaction (Free Strike or Shove 1 hex).

Heat: On a critical hit, the GM may spend 1 Heat (a resource tracked per scene) to degrade Position or trigger a terrain hazard.

Hex Keywords

Difficult: Costs 2 movement points per hex. **Elevation:** Attacks from lower ground suffer +1 DV. **ZoC:** Provokes a Reaction on crossing.

Altar [WARD]: -1 die to attacks (or attacker may spend 2 Fatigue to ignore).

Incorporeal: Ignores Difficult terrain; can pass through occupied hexes but cannot end movement in one.

Sample NPCs**Encounters (Tier I–II)**

- **Bandit Skirmisher:** Body 2, Wits 2. Melee 2, Stealth 1.
- **Ykrul Rider:** Body 4, Wits 3. Riding 3, Melee 3.
- **Street Bravo:** Presence 3, Body 2. Dueling 3.

Foils & Rivals (Tier II–III)

- **Ambitious Scribe:** Wits 3, Presence 3. Intrigue 3, Lore 2.
- **Mercenary Captain:** Body 4, Spirit 3. Command 3, Melee 4.
- **Flame Preacher:** Presence 4, Spirit 3. Oratory 4, Faith 3.

Prestige NPCs (Tier IV–V)

- **High Elf Loremaster:** Wits 5, Spirit 4. Lore 5, Arcana 4.
- **Dwarven Forge-Patriarch:** Body 5, Spirit 4. Craft 5, Command 4.
- **Ykrul Warglord:** Body 5, Presence 4. Command 4, Melee 5.

Common Rolls (GM Screen Reference)

Athletics: climb (<i>Body</i> +Athletics), time a leap (<i>Wits</i> +Athletics)	Performance: captivate a crowd (<i>Presence</i> +Performance), mimic voice (<i>Wits</i> +Performance)
Stealth: shadow patrol (<i>Wits</i> +Stealth), hold still (<i>Spirit</i> +Stealth)	Subterfuge: talk past a checkpoint (<i>Presence</i> +Subterfuge), case a routine (<i>Wits</i> +Subterfuge)
Endurance: resist cold (<i>Spirit</i> +Endurance), push through pain (<i>Spirit</i> +Endurance)	Streetwise: find a fence (<i>Presence</i> +Streetwise), sift rumors (<i>Wits</i> +Streetwise)
Craft: blueprint (<i>Wits</i> +Craft), brace a door (<i>Body</i> +Craft)	Arcana: read a ward anchor (<i>Wits</i> +Arcana), hold a rite steady (<i>Spirit</i> +Arcana)
Melee: break guard (<i>Body</i> +Melee), bind a blade (<i>Wits</i> +Melee)	Mechanics: diagnose a lock (<i>Wits</i> +Mechanics), field-rig a pump (<i>Body</i> +Mechanics)
Ranged: leading shot (<i>Wits</i> +Ranged), loose in a squall (<i>Spirit</i> +Ranged)	Investigation: reconstruct a scene (<i>Wits</i> +Investigation), interview a witness (<i>Presence</i> +Investigation)
Brawl: grapple (<i>Body</i> +Brawl), feint (<i>Wits</i> +Brawl)	Lore: cite local custom (<i>Presence</i> +Lore), perform a rite (<i>Spirit</i> +Lore)
Tactics: ambush lane (<i>Wits</i> +Tactics), coordinate a retreat (<i>Presence</i> +Tactics)	Nature: read weather (<i>Wits</i> +Nature), calm a mount (<i>Presence</i> +Nature)
Diplomacy: audience (<i>Presence</i> +Diplomacy), draft terms (<i>Wits</i> +Diplomacy)	Medicine: stabilise a wound (<i>Wits</i> +Medicine), cut away rot (<i>Body</i> +Medicine)
Sway: haggle (<i>Presence</i> +Sway), sell a risky plan (<i>Presence</i> +Sway)	Command: rally allies (<i>Presence</i> +Command), hold the line (<i>Spirit</i> +Command)
Deception: lie under scrutiny (<i>Presence</i> +Deception), misdirect guard (<i>Wits</i> +Deception)	

Fast Boundaries:

- **Locks & Traps:** Mechanical = Mechanics + Attribute; Arcane = Arcana + Attribute.
- **People vs. Mechanisms:** Subterfuge for social infiltration; Stealth to avoid detection; Mechanics or Arcana to bypass a physical or magical barrier.
- **Formal vs. Informal:** Diplomacy for courts and treaties; Sway for bargaining and personal persuasion.

Appendix C: Deck and Magic Reference

Deck Types and Meanings

Travel Decks (regional, 52-card)

Spade = Place, Heart = Actor, Club = Pressure, Diamond = Leverage.

Deck of Consequences (scene drama)

Hearts = Social/Emotional, Spades = Harm/Escalation, Clubs = Material Cost, Diamonds = Magical/Spiritual.

Important: Never mix suit meanings across different deck types.

Deck Usage Procedure

After a roll that generates Story Beats:

1. **Direct Spend:** Translate SB into immediate consequences or clock ticks (see Appendix A).
2. **Optional Deck Draw:** Draw up to $\min(\text{SB}, 3)$ cards and synthesise a single narrative twist guided by the suits and the highest rank.

Rank Severity Guide

Ace–3

Minor inconvenience or flavour.

4–6 Moderate setback.

7–9 Significant consequence.

10–King

Major fallout with lasting effects.

Table 12.5: Deck of Consequences Interpretation

Suit	Interpretation
Hearts (Emotional/Social)	Ace–3: awkward social moment; 4–6: relationship strain; 7–9: betrayal; 10–King: exile or shattered alliance.
Spades (Harm/Escalation)	Ace–3: bruise or Fatigue; 4–6: wound or damaged gear; 7–9: severe injury; 10–King: death or permanent loss.
Clubs (Material/Cost)	Ace–3: minor resource loss; 4–6: gear failure or debt; 7–9: major asset lost; 10–King: total ruin.
Diamonds (Magical/Spiritual)	Ace–3: omen or whisper; 4–6: curse or spirit appears; 7–9: arcane backlash; 10–King: reality bends temporarily.

Table 12.6: Magic Paths Comparison

Path	Requirements	Key Feature	Risk Type
Caster (Freeform)	Spellcraft (6 XP)	Improvisational spellcasting	Backlash (5.3)
Runekeeper (Rites)	Thiasos (2 XP) + Codex (4 XP)	Structured Patron Rites	Obligation (5.4)
Invoker (Symbols)	Patron’s Symbol (4 XP each)	Ritual precision, emergency casting	Symbol comprom

DV Reference for Rites

DV = max(ObligationCost – –Spirit, Tier)							
Obligation	Spirit 0	Spirit 1	Spirit 2	Spirit 3–4	Tier 1	Tier 2	Tier 3
1	1	1	1	1	1	2	3
2	2	1	1	1	1	2	3
3	3	2	1	1	1	2	3
4	4	3	2	1	1	2	3
5	5	4	3	2	1	2	3
6	6	5	4	3	1	2	3
7	7	6	5	4	1	2	3

Casting Loop Summary

1. **Channel:** Wits + Arcana to gather magical potential.
2. **Weave:** Wits + Art (or appropriate magical skill) to shape the effect.
3. **Backlash:** The GM spends SB generated during the roll to impose thematic consequences (see 5.3).

Eight Elements of Magic

- Earth**
Solidity, stability, foundation.
- Fire**
Energy, transformation, destruction.
- Air** Movement, speed, freedom.
- Water**
Fluidity, healing, adaptability.
- Fate**
Destiny, inevitability, causality.
- Life** Vitality, creation, growth.
- Luck**
Chance, unpredictability.

Death/Dreams

Endings, thresholds, the subconscious.

Appendix D: Campaign Management

Campaign Clock Examples

- **Mandate Advancement:** Public victories, crisis resolution, recognition by powerful factions (see 3.6.1).
- **Crisis Advancement:** Rival faction gains influence, asset neglect, betrayal, scandal (see 3.6.2).

Follower and Asset Condition States

Maintained

Full capability, no penalties.

Neglected

−1 die penalty; narrative wear and tear.

Compromised

Unavailable until repaired or recovered through downtime.

See 2.10.3 for detailed rules.

Faction Loyalty Scale (Optional)

Track faction standing on a simple −3 to +3 scale.

−3 Enemy

Actively works against the party.

0 Neutral

Indifferent.

+3 Ally

Will sacrifice for the party.

Adjust by ± 1 after major interactions (saving or betraying the faction).

Campaign Pacing (Arc Structure)

1. **Introduction** (1–2 sessions): Establish stakes, hook the players.
2. **Development** (2–4 sessions): Complications multiply, alliances form.
3. **Climax** (1–2 sessions): Major confrontation, critical choices.
4. **Resolution** (1 session): Consequences land, new status quo established.

Appendix E: Safety and Inclusivity

X-Card System

- **X-Card:** "I'm not comfortable – change direction immediately." No explanation required.
- **O-Card:** "I'm excited – lean into this element."
- **N-Card:** "I need a break – pause the scene."

Keep cards visible. Model appropriate use as the GM.

Script Change

Ask at appropriate moments:

- **Pause:** "Are you okay with this content?"
- **Rewind:** "Would you like to go back and change something?"
- **Fast Forward:** "Would you like to skip ahead?"

Inclusive Worldbuilding

- Research real cultures thoroughly when drawing inspiration.
- Avoid stereotypes; build characters with depth and agency.
- Provide character options that do not rely on real-world cultural markers.
- Use high-contrast, readable materials for accessibility.

Conflict Resolution

When conflicts arise at the table:

1. Pause gameplay.
2. Discuss privately if needed.
3. Focus on understanding, not assigning fault.
4. Find collaborative solutions.
5. Document any agreements.

Common solutions: the GM's ruling stands for the session; research the rule later; adjust future play.

Appendix F: Rival Party Generator

Use the following d6 tables to generate a rival party in under 5 minutes. Roll once in each category or choose deliberately.

Rival Party Name

d6	Name	Flavour
1	The Ashen Cord	Echoes, smoke, unbreakable knots.
2	The Brass Legion	Gears, discipline, cold precision.
3	The Thorns of Winter	Ice, silence, patient cruelty.
4	The Gilded Chain	Wealth, obligation, gilded cages.
5	The Salt Pact	Oaths sworn in brine, pirates or pilgrims.
6	The Unfaced	Masks, secrets, stolen identities.

Composition (3–5 members)

d6	Role	Archetype
1	Leader	Shadow mage, war-priest, strategist, or oath-breaker.
2	Muscle	Berserker, knight, duelist, or beast-handler.
3	Mage/Weird	Cantor, free caster, runekeeper, or witch.
4	Scout/Thief	Infiltrator, poisoner, sniper, or ghost.
5	Face/Healer	Negotiator, spy, medic, or confessor.
6	Specialist	Engineer, summoner, trapper, or lore-master.

Patron (roll once per character or once for the party)

d6	Patron	Theme
1	Ikasha (Shadow)	Secrets, thresholds, omens.
2	Malachai (Curse)	Corrupted bargains, venomous gifts.
3	The Traveler (Roads)	Journeys, shortcuts, debts.
4	The Ninth (Knowledge)	Forbidden truths, fractured minds.
5	Khemesh (Depths)	Unstoppable pressure, drowning.
6	Palinode (Performance)	Rapture, encores, hungry fame.

Goal (pressure or obstacle)

d6	Goal	Example
1	Retrieve the same artifact.	Sunstone, charter, relic.
2	Capture/kill a mutual contact.	Witness, defector, rival.
3	Secure a Patron's favor.	Complete a ritual or sacrifice.
4	Eliminate the PCs for a rival.	Bounty, vendetta, jealous patron.
5	Claim a contested site.	Anchorhold, shrine, trade route.
6	Prevent a prophecy.	Stop the PCs from changing fate.

Relationship to PCs

d6	Relationship	Initial Attitude
1	Unexpected rivals	Neutral – will negotiate first.
2	Hunters seeking a bounty	Hostile – will attack if confident.
3	Former allies, now betrayed	Bitter – may accept apology at cost.
4	Pawns of a common enemy	Reluctant allies – temporary truce.
5	Zealous competitors	Competitive – will cheat but not kill.
6	Mysterious	Unreadable – may help or hinder.

Additional Resource (off-screen)

d6	Resource	Effect
1	Hidden safehouse	Can hide from pursuers once.
2	Bribed official	May delay a legal clock once.
3	Spy network	Gains +1 die to gather info.
4	War chest	Can hire temporary muscle.
5	Patron's omen	Once per arc, avoid a Miss.
6	Stolen map	Shortcut to any location once.

Rival Party Clock

Every rival party should have a visible agenda clock, e.g., *Rival Agenda* [6]. Tick it:

- When the party ignores or fails to hinder the rivals.
- When the GM spends 2+ SB on off-screen rival activity.
- When a session ends without contact.

When the clock fills, the rivals achieve a major milestone (steal the relic, secure the Patron's favor, etc.). The GM reveals their progress through rumours, looted sites, or a direct confrontation.

Example Rival Party (Quick Build)

The Ashen Cord (from simulation)

Composition: Vesper (leader, shadow mage, serves Ikasha), Tallow (berserker, serves Malachai), Ember (cantor, serves Palinode), Cinder (scout, no Patron).

Goal: Retrieve the Sunstone fragment before the PCs.

Relationship: Unexpected rivals – will negotiate or betray as needed.

Clock: *Cord's Agenda* [6].

Resource: Hidden safehouse in Silkstrand.

Appendix G: One-Page GM Screen Summary

Fate's Edge – GM Screen	
CORE RESOLUTION	
1. Declare Action	Intent + Attribute + Skill
2. Set DV	2=Routine, 3=Pressured, 4=Hard, 5+=Extreme
3. Set Position	Dominant (re-roll failure), Controlled (normal), Desperate (re-roll success)
4. Roll	Count successes (6+) and 1s (SB for GM)
5. Outcome	Clean Success, Success & Cost, Partial (1 Boon), Miss (2 Boons)
6. Spend SB	1=minor, 2=moderate, 3+=major complication
COMBAT QUICK REF	
Move	Shift one band (CloseNearFar)
Dash	Move two bands, next defense Desperate
Charge/Skirmish	Move two bands + attack, cost 1 Fatigue, requires open ground
Opportunity Attack	Leaving Close without Disengage = free melee attack
Fatigue	Each Fatigue worsens Position; fill → Harm +1, clear Fatigue
Harm	1=–1 die, 2=–2 dice, 3=incapacitated
MAGIC SHORTCUTS	
Free Caster	DV = 1 + number of [TAGS] (dangerous +2); backlash on 1s
Runekeeper	Invoke Rite (1 action) +1 Obligation; Push It: +1 Obligation
Invoker	Ritual (DV+1 rounds) +1 Obligation; Crack the Seal: instant, +2 Obligation, Symbol Compromised
Cantor	Song (1 action, resolves next turn) +Corruption clock; Push: resolve immediately
Summoning	Call (1 action) + Bind (1 Boon or Fatigue); Leash = Cap + Spirit segments
SB SPEND QUICK	

1 SB	Noise, trace, tick a clock +1
2 SB	Alarm raised, lose advantage, lesser foe appears
3 SB	Reinforcements, key gear break, campaign front tick
4+ SB	Trap springs, authority arrives, scene shift

CLOCKS & DIFFICULTY

Clock Size	4=short, 6=standard, 8=long, 10=epic
Default DV	3 (pressured, mild opposition)
DV 2	Routine, trivial stakes
DV 4	Hard, active opposition
DV 5+	Extreme, high drama

Golden Rule: When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving.

Appendix H: Sample Deck Reading (Example)

The GM draws three cards from the Deck of Consequences after a player rolls three 1s on a critical stealth check.

Drawn: Knave of Hearts, 7 of Clubs, Ace of Spades.

Synthesis: The GM combines the suits:

- **Hearts (social) + Spades (harm)** = betrayal with injury.
- **Clubs (resource cost)** = material loss.
- **Ace** = scene-altering twist.

GM narration:

"You slip past the first guard, but your cloak catches on a rusty nail (Clubs – resource drain: your cloak tears, leaving a scrap of fabric behind). Worse, the second guard recognises your face from a wanted poster – she’s your estranged cousin (Hearts – social betrayal). She hesitates for only a heartbeat, then shouts, "Traitor!" (Spades – harm escalates). As she draws her blade, a hidden portcullis drops behind you, sealing off the exit (Ace – scene shift). You're trapped in the courtyard with her and two more guards."

This single three-card draw creates a layered, memorable complication from a single SB spend.

Appendix I: Session Zero Checklist Handout

Session Zero Checklist

Use this checklist during your Session Zero. Write down the answers where everyone can see them.

1. **Lines & Veils** – What content is off-limits (Lines) or only implied (Veils)?
2. **Tone** – Cinematic action? Grim survival? Political intrigue? Dark horror? Mix of several?
3. **Campaign length** – One-shot, short arc (3–6 sessions), or long campaign (12+ sessions)?
4. **Character hooks** – Each player shares one goal and one fear for their character.
5. **Patron interest** – Which Patrons (if any) are already watching the party?
6. **Starting situation** – Where does the story begin? (Use the Crown Spread or a simple opener.)
7. **House rules** – Any optional subsystems (Threat Pool, Deck of Consequences, etc.) you plan to use?
8. **Scheduling & attendance** – How often do you meet? What happens if a player misses a session?
9. **Player-GM contract** – Remind the table: "We are co-creators, not adversaries."
10. **Resource mindset** – "Boons are not XP tokens. Spend them. Embrace failure."
11. **Patron expectation** – "They are allies who demand payment – embrace it."
12. **Flavor is free** – Encourage descriptive narration for all actions, not just magic.

Chapter 13

Using Expansions: A Guide for the Overwhelmed GM

"I bought every expansion. Then I sat at my table with thirty-seven PDFs and a blank look. The players were waiting. The beer was warm. I learned that night: you don't use expansions. You borrow from them." — The Gray Wanderer, from a letter found under a stack of printouts

13.1 The First Rule: You Own the Expansions, They Don't Own You

Every expansion in Fate's Edge is a toolbox, not a syllabus. You are never required to use a single rule, clock, or cultural detail from any expansion. The core game runs perfectly well on its own. Expansions exist to *solve specific problems* or *add specific flavors* when you need them.

13.1.1 The Three Questions to Ask Before Opening Any Expansion

Before you reach for a PDF, ask yourself:

1. **What problem am I solving?** (e.g., "combat feels same-y", "my players want more political intrigue", "we're going to sea")
2. **What is the smallest piece of this expansion that solves it?** (e.g., "just the Seven Bell Court judging table", "just the travel clocks", "just the Lethai-ar witness knots")
3. **Can I explain that piece to my players in one minute?** If not, pick a smaller piece.

13.1.2 The 10% Rule

A typical Fate's Edge expansion is 30-100 pages. In a single session, you will use **at most 10% of any expansion**. The other 90% is background, lore, alternative systems, and optional depth. You are not expected to master all of it.

13.2 A Taxonomy of Expansions (What They're Actually For)

Use this table to quickly identify which expansion to reach for. Expansions are grouped by **purpose**, not by title.

If you want...	Use expansions in this family	Example of a single mechanic to steal
Honorable duels, tournaments, social combat	Seven Bell Court, Vhasia: The Knave's Regret	The Form/Spirit/Intent judging table (3 rows, no dice)
New martial options (no magic)	The Way of the Warrior, Ykrul: Iron & Blood	A single talent chain (e.g., Sentinel, Bladestorm, Pathfinder)
Cultural depth for a specific people	Eastern Realms, Peoples and Cultures, The Frost Ledger	One etiquette hook and one String (e.g., "Aelinnel never ring the ninth bell")
Investigation	The Salt Ledger, The Wandering Ledger, Saikou Ira's Compendium	One clue type (e.g., "a silver coin in the mouth = ferryman's toll")
Sea travel, naval combat, port intrigue	The Amaranthine Sea	Travel clocks [4-8] and the Inspection procedure
Folk horror, psychological tension	Horror Campaigns, The Frost Ledger, Mistslands expansion	The Dread Clock (4-8 segments)
Witchcraft, curses, bargains	Witches of Fate's Edge, Daughters of the Unbroken Cord	One working type (e.g., Chord Working, Promise Clock, Cord of Flesh)
Patron-heavy campaigns	The Gray Wanderer's Grimoire, Malachai, The Chained Angel	One new Patron with its Rites and Obligation flavor
Dungeon crawling, ancient lairs	Dragon's Lair, The Book of Air, Mist, Alder, Thorn, and Mirror	Lair moves (3-4 per scene)
Political intrigue	Political Intrigue framework, Vhasia, Viterra expansions	Faction clocks (Influence/Stability/Exposure)
Caravans, travel, trade	Caravans: The Way of Silk, The Wandering Ledger	Travel intent dial (Speed/Stealth/Show/Tribute)

13.3 The Hybrid Adventure: How to Cook with Leftovers

The most successful way to use expansions is to build a **hybrid adventure**: one core story (often from a free adventure or your own imagination) with mechanics borrowed from 2-4 expansions.

13.3.1 Example: The Tournament of the Broken Crown

The GM wanted:

- A tournament (so players could fight without dying).
- A murder mystery (so non-combat characters had something to do).
- Cultural flavor (so the world felt lived-in).

They borrowed:

- **Judging table** from *Seven Bell Court* (3 rows: Form, Spirit, Intent).
- **Unbuckled gorget clue** from *Vhasia: The Knave's Regret* (mercy as a theme).
- **Bell-tending** and **witness knots** from *Eastern Realms* (investigation hooks).
- **Martial talents** from *The Way of the Warrior* (Disciplined Body, Shield Bearer, Flurry).

Prep time: 90 minutes. **Pages read:** 15 total across four expansions. **Result:** A 3-hour session that felt fresh, deep, and manageable.

13.3.2 The Hybrid Recipe

1. Pick a **core activity** (tournament, heist, travel, investigation).
2. Identify **one gap** in the core rules that an expansion fills (e.g., "combat lacks stakes beyond HP" → *Seven Bell Court*).
3. Read **only the first 5-10 pages** of that expansion until you find a mechanic you understand.
4. Add **one cultural hook** from a lore expansion (e.g., "in this city, knights unbuckle their gorgets to show mercy").
5. Add **one talent** from a player-options expansion (e.g., give an NPC a talent from *The Way of the Warrior*).
6. Run the session. **Ignore every other rule** from the expansions.

13.4 Managing Player Expectations

When players know you own expansions, they will ask to use things. This is a gift, not a burden.

13.4.1 The "Yes, But Later" Rule

When a player asks "Can I use the Shadow Step talent from *Witches of Fate's Edge*?"

- **Yes:** "Yes, but you'll need to earn it through roleplay. Find a hag or a Lethai-ar teacher in the next town."

- **No, but:** "No, but you can take a different talent from the core book that works similarly, and we'll reskin it."
- **Later:** "Not this session, but tell me about it during downtime and we'll build it into your character's arc."

13.4.2 The Expansion Session Zero

At the start of a new campaign or arc, ask your players:

1. "Which expansions have you read?" (Be honest; they may have read none.)
2. "What's one thing from an expansion you'd love to see in play?" (Write it down.)
3. "What's one thing you absolutely don't want?" (Lines and veils for expansion content.)

Then pick **one expansion** to feature prominently in the next 2-3 sessions. Rotate.

13.5 Cross-Expansion Synergy (When Two Books Work Better Than One)

Some expansions are designed to work together. Others accidentally complement each other. Here are known synergies:

- **Seven Bell Court + Vhasia: The Knave's Regret** = duels that are judged on honor, not just damage. The "unbuckled gorget" becomes a mechanical choice (lower Defense, higher Spirit points).
- **The Amaranthine Sea + The Salt Ledger** = sea travel with port mysteries. Use the travel clocks from *Sea* and the lighthouse/spirit stories from *Salt* as random encounters.
- **Witches of Fate's Edge + Horror Campaigns** = curse-based horror. Use the Dread Clock and the Cord mechanics together; each curse failure ticks the Dread Clock.
- **Eastern Realms + The Way of the Warrior** = culturally-infused martial characters. Let a Lethai-al samurai take Bushido-style talents from *Warrior* and re flavor them as "the Way of the Leaf."

13.5.1 Antisynergy: When Not to Mix

Some expansions actively fight each other. Avoid:

- **Too many clocks.** *Horror Campaigns* (Dread Clock, Reality Fracture) + *Political Intrigue* (Mandate, Crisis) + *The Amaranthine Sea* (Weather Window, Patrol Net) = 6+ clocks. Players cannot track that many. Pick 2-3 maximum per session.
- **Contradictory cultural lore.** The *Eastern Realms* and *The Salt Ledger* have different versions of Aelinnel bell-customs. Choose one interpretation for your campaign and stick to it. Tell players "we're using the *Eastern Realms* version."

13.6 Practical Tools: The Expansion Integration Checklist

Before a session where you plan to use expansion content, run through this checklist.

13.6.1 Pre-Session (30-60 minutes)

1. **Select 1-3 expansions** to draw from. Write their names on an index card.
2. **Extract 1-3 mechanics** from each expansion. Write each mechanic as a single sentence on the card.
3. **Prepare one page of reference.** Print the relevant table (e.g., Seven Bell Court judging, travel clock sizes, talent list). Do not print the whole expansion.
4. **Note page numbers.** If you must look something up, know where it is.
5. **Check for conflicts.** Do any of your chosen mechanics use the same resource (e.g., both use Boons in contradictory ways)? If yes, pick one.

13.6.2 During Session (At the Table)

1. **Announce the new mechanic.** "Tonight we're using the Seven Bell Court. Your duels will be judged on Form, Spirit, and Intent."
2. **Demonstrate once.** Run a quick mock duel or skill challenge to show how it works.
3. **Let players opt out.** If someone doesn't want to use a new subsystem, let them use the core rules instead.
4. **Keep a timer.** If a new mechanic slows play for more than 2 minutes, simplify it or drop it for the scene.

13.6.3 Post-Session (5 minutes)

1. **Ask:** "What expansion mechanic worked? What didn't?"
2. **Note:** Write down which pages you actually used. Toss the rest.
3. **Decide:** Will you use this expansion again? If yes, put the relevant page in your GM binder. If no, archive it.

13.7 DM's Cheat Sheet: Quick Reference by Page Count

If you have limited time before a session, use this triage guide.

Expansion	Read these pages	Skip these pages
-----------	------------------	------------------

Seven Bell Court	5-7 (judging table, Honor/Pragmatism)	Tournament logistics, NPC champion statblocks
Vhasia: The Knave's Regret	1-3 (the opening fiction), 25-27 (talents)	Full canton descriptions, duel history
Way of the Warrior	31 (talent quick reference)	Cultural warrior variants (unless a player is one)
Eastern Realms	13-14 (bell-tending, witness knots)	Travel decks (use only when traveling)
Witches of Fate's Edge	i-iv (first principles), 89-91 (Threshold working)	Deep hag lore, full talent trees
The Amaranthine Sea	9-11 (travel clocks, inspection)	Fleet combat rules, ship statblocks
Horror Campaigns	5-6 (Dread Clock), 8-9 (breaking points)	Extended campaign clocks (use only for long arcs)
Dragon's Lair	3-5 (lair generator), 21 (dragon moves)	Hoard generators, dragon stats (improvise Tier)
The Salt Ledger	Any single story (use as adventure seed)	The rest of the stories (save for later)

Magic Adjudication Quick Reference (GM)

Default Magic DV

Effect scope	DV
Cantrip (1 tag)	2
Combat spell (2 tags)	3
Ritual (small, 3 tags)	4
Ritual (large, dangerous tags)	5+

Free Casting (TAGS)

$$DV = 1 + \#tags \quad (\text{dangerous tags: } +2 \text{ instead of } +1)$$

Dangerous tags: Leap, Fold, Gate, Gravity, Create, Summon, Transmute, Animate, Transform, Dominate, Rewind, Resurrect.

Backlash: Spend SB from 1s. Severity by Position:

- Dominant: minor (noise, Fatigue 1)
- Controlled: moderate (Harm 1, Condition)

- Desperate: severe (Harm 2, scene shift)

Rites (Runekeepers & Invokers)

$$DV = \max(\text{ObligationCost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Tier: Low}=1, \text{Standard}=2, \text{High}=3)$$

Obligation overflow: Exceed Capacity (Spirit+Presence) → mark 1 Fatigue per segment. Exceed 2× Capacity → +1 Harm, Patron intrusion.

Healing Magic

- **[HEAL] only:** Restores 1 Fatigue. DV 2. 1 action.
- **[HEAL] + another tag (Purify, Strengthen, Cleanse):** Restores 1 Harm. DV = 2 + number of tags, plus +2 surcharge. Requires two actions unless Push.
- **Ritual healing (Harm 2+):** Requires Extended ritual (clock), rare components.

Summoning

- **Call:** 1 action, spirit manifests.
- **Bind:** 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue.
- **Leash capacity:** Cap + Spirit segments. Tick when: spirit takes Harm, acts against nature, crosses a [WARD], summoner splits focus, rival contests control.
- **Boon Finesse:** Once/round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 Leash tick.
- **Leash full:** Spirit acts once to its nature, then departs (or turns hostile).

Cantors (Songs)

- **Sing:** 1 action, resolves next turn. Roll Lore + Performance (DV 2–3).
- **Push:** Resolve immediately, mark 1 Fatigue, advance Corruption Clock by 1.
- **Corruption Clock:** Size = Spirit. When full → bloom (gain benefit burden from last patron), reset to Tier (min 1).
- **Resonant Rite:** Performance with 10+ witnesses → may found Chorus (minor follower benefit, Obligation to patron each session).

Patron Intrusions (when Obligation overflows or GM spends 2+ SB)

- Demand a quest (“Find my stolen symbol.”)
- Impose a cost (“Your next Rite costs double.”)
- Send an omen (“Candles burn blue; you feel watched.”)
- Summon a rival servant (“Another follower of Malachai is hunting you.”)

Common Magic Rulings

- **Countermagic:** [COUNTER] tag vs. DV = spell's DV. Success cancels.
- **Dispel:** [DISPEL] vs. DV = effect's Tier (1–5). On hit, effect ends.
- **Wards:** [WARD] vs. Outsider. DV = target's Cap. Crosser adds DV to Leash.
- **Line of sight:** Required for most spells; without it +1 DV.

13.8 Adversary Templates

13.8.1 Generic Adversaries

Use these for filler encounters. No special traits—just core stats. Scale by adjusting Threat Level (see Table 13.3). All use standard attack/defense as per ??.

- **Bandit Rabble** (Threat Level 1)
Stats: Body 2, Wits 1, Spirit 1, Presence 1 | *Skills:* Melee 1, Athletics 1
Flavor: “Desperate locals with rusty blades. They flee if half their number falls.”
Use: Random encounters, tavern brawls, distractions.
- **City Watch Recruit** (Threat Level 2)
Stats: Body 2, Wits 1, Spirit 1, Presence 2 | *Skills:* Melee 1, Command 1
Flavor: “Poorly trained but eager to prove themselves. Will call for backup if overwhelmed (alarm raises a 4-segment clock).”
Use: Urban patrols, gate guards, low-level enforcement.
- **Cult Novice** (Threat Level 1)
Stats: Body 1, Wits 1, Spirit 2, Presence 1 | *Skills:* Lore 1 (cult-specific), Sway 1
Flavor: “True believer, poorly trained. Will gladly die for the cause but breaks if shown proof their faith is a lie.”
Use: Guarding rituals, spreading propaganda, cannon fodder. On a Miss when trying to recruit or intimidate, they may flee or surrender (GM discretion).
- **Street Thug** (Threat Level 2)
Stats: Body 3, Wits 1, Spirit 1, Presence 1 | *Skills:* Brawl 2, Intimidation (Presence+Brawl)
Flavor: “Enforcer for a local gang. Favours cheap shots and overwhelming numbers.”
Use: Alley ambushes, protection rackets, gang warfare.
- **Guard Sergeant** (Threat Level 3)
Stats: Body 3, Wits 2, Spirit 2, Presence 2 | *Skills:* Melee 2, Command 1, Athletics 1
Flavor: “Veteran who has seen it all. Leads from the front and shouts orders.”
Use: Leader of a watch patrol, military outpost, or noble's bodyguard.

Adjust all Attributes and Skills uniformly. For Threat Level 0, treat as flavour only (no combat threat). For Threat Level 3+, consider giving one simple trait from the archetypes below.

Table 13.3: Threat Level Scaling

Threat Level	Stat Adjustment	Typical Use	PC Tier Match
0	−1 to all stats	Non-threatening flavour	Below PC tier
1	Base stats (as written)	Standard minions	PC tier −1
2	+1 to all stats	Tougher minions / elite	PC tier
3	+2 to all stats	Mini-boss equivalent	PC tier +1
4+	+3 to all stats & add one archetype trait	Major boss	PC tier +2

13.8.2 Archetypal Adversaries

Each has one thematic mechanic tied to existing rules. Use as recurring threats, scene-setters, or mini-bosses. Scale via Threat Level table.

The Iron Patriarch / Matriarch

Archetype: Ruthless leader of a family, guild, or corporation. Values legacy and control above all.

Stats (Threat Level 2): Body 2, Wits 3, Spirit 2, Presence 3 | *Skills:* Sway 2, Command 1, Lore 1 (family/guild)

Thematic Mechanic: *Legacy's Weight*

When the Patriarch/Matriarch would take Harm, they may immediately order a loyal subordinate (if present) to take the blow. Roll Wits + Command *vs.* DV 2. On success, the subordinate takes 1 Harm instead (armour applies normally). On failure, the Patriarch takes the Harm but gains +1 die on their next action (resolve fuelled by desperation).

Flavor Hook: “They don’t fear death—they fear their life’s work dying with them. Every blow you strike feels like it’s aimed not at them, but at the empire they bled to build.”

Rules Tie-In: Uses opposed rolls (??) and Harm (??).

The Hollow Prophet

Archetype: Charismatic leader of a movement built on a lie (or partial truth). Believes their own deception.

Stats (Threat Level 2): Body 1, Wits 2, Spirit 3, Presence 3 | *Skills:* Sway 2, Lore 1 (doctrine), Deception 1

Thematic Mechanic: *Faith's Fragility*

When the Hollow Prophet successfully uses Sway to convert a bystander or reinforce a follower’s faith, they generate **1 extra Story Beat** (beyond any generated by 1s). However, if the Sway attempt **fails** (Miss), they gain a *Despair* Condition: −1 die to all Spirit and Wits rolls until they successfully persuade someone or gain 1 Boon.

Flavor Hook: “Their eyes glow with conviction as they speak—but when you catch their reflection in a dark window, you see only exhaustion and doubt. The lie sustains them... but how long until it cracks?”

Rules Tie-In: Uses Story Beats (??) and Conditions (see ??).

The Gearsmith

Archetype: Obsessed tinkerer, weaponsmith, or arcane engineer. Sees people as problems to solve.

Stats (Threat Level 2): Body 2, Wits 3, Spirit 1, Presence 2 | *Skills:* Craft 2, Mechanics 1, Brawl 1

Thematic Mechanic: *Improvised Countermove (Cost: 1 Boon)*

When the Gearsmith is targeted by an action (attack, skill use, etc.), the GM may spend 1 Story Beat (or 1 Boon from the GM's pool – see section 3.3) to invent a reactive device on the spot. The device negates the incoming action and imposes one relevant Condition (e.g., *Entangled*, *Blinded*, *Shaken*) on the attacker. The device is single-use and narratively described (GM improvises based on the scene). This ability can be used at most once per round.

Flavor Hook: “They don’t dodge your sword—they’re already calculating how to turn its momentum against you. That clang wasn’t a block; it was the sound of a spring-loading.”

Rules Tie-In: Uses Story Beats (??) and Conditions (see ??). The GM may also spend Boons from the optional Threat Pool (??).

The Iron-Bound Rival (PC Mirror)

Archetype: Former ally, rival adventurer, or ideological opponent who mirrors the PCs’ path.

Stats: Match the PC’s highest two Attributes at their current rating. Match the PC’s two highest Skills at their current rating. Other stats default to 1 or 0 as appropriate.

Thematic Mechanic: *Anticipate Move*

When a PC declares an action targeting the Rival, the Rival gains +1 die to any defensive or opposing roll (e.g., dodging an attack, resisting Sway, countering a skill use). This bonus does not stack if multiple PCs act against the Rival in the same exchange.

Flavor Hook: “They move not like a fighter, but like a shadow of your own choices—always one step ahead of where you *think* you’re going, but never where you *are*.”

Rules Tie-In: Uses opposed rolls (??) and mirrors PC progression (??).

The Weeping Martyr

Archetype: Someone who has lost everything and fights with suicidal abandon.

Stats (Threat Level 2): Body 3, Wits 1, Spirit 3, Presence 1 | *Skills:* Melee 2, Endurance 2, Intimidation (Presence+Brawl)

Thematic Mechanic: *Blood Price*

When the Martyr takes Harm, they immediately gain +1 die on their next attack or physical action (pain fuels fury). Additionally, if they are reduced to Harm 3 (incapacitated), they may make one final attack as a free action before falling. This attack ignores all Position penalties and deals +1 Harm.

Flavor Hook: “They don’t even try to block your strike—they lean into it, grinning through bloody teeth. Every wound is another coin in a purse they’ll never spend.”

Rules Tie-In: Uses Harm levels (??) and the “roller-coaster” effect (??).

The Shadow Broker

Archetype: Information dealer, blackmailer, or spymaster who never fights fair.

Stats (Threat Level 2): Body 1, Wits 4, Spirit 2, Presence 2 | *Skills:* Subterfuge 3, Insight 2, Streetwise 2

Thematic Mechanic: *I Know a Guy* (Cost: 1 Story Beat)

Once per scene, the Shadow Broker may spend 1 Story Beat to declare that they have prepared for the current situation. They produce a minor but useful asset (e.g., a hidden exit, a bribed guard, a forged document) that grants the party (or their own allies) +1 die or improves Position by one step on a single roll. The GM narrates the asset and its limitations.

Flavor Hook: “You never see them draw a weapon. You only see the trap they set three scenes ago, the witness they paid off, the escape route you didn’t know existed.”

Rules Tie-In: Uses Story Beats (??) and Assets (??). The Broker rarely engages in direct combat; instead, they create advantages.

13.8.3 Using These Templates in Play

- **Generic foes:** Drop in instantly. Adjust Threat Level via Table 13.3. No prep beyond naming them.
- **Archetypal foes:** Pick one matching your scene’s theme. Note their one mechanic. Use the *Flavor Hook* to guide narration.
- **Scaling:** If PCs are Tier III, treat Threat Level 2 as baseline. For major encounters, use Threat Level 3 or 4 archetypes.
- **No extra bookkeeping:** Mechanics reference existing rules—just apply them as written. The mechanic is the *only* thing to remember beyond core stats.

Design Philosophy: Generic foes exist to threaten through numbers and positioning (using core rules only). Archetypal foes add narrative depth via one self-contained mechanic that reflects their core theme—never requiring tracking beyond the encounter. All mechanics are verifiable in the core rules (see citations in the text).

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